Transformational Action:

A Case Study of India

Edited by

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

Preface iv

Introduction x

1. Personal Transformation 1
   - Repentance as a Mark of a Transformed Life 1
   - Compassion as the Passion of a Transformed Life 3

2. The Family: Family Values Are Kingdom Values 6

3. The Church: A Transforming Multicultural Community 21
   - The Church as a Transforming Multicultural Community 21
   - The Ecumenical Movement and the Pentecostal Movement 27
   - The Moravian Church as an Agent of Transformation, Elijah Gregan 30
   - Rani Lal: A Brothel Transformed 33
   - Pedhuru Village Transformed 40
   - West Godavari Village Transformed 41
   - The Dalits and the Church, Samuel Jayakumar 42

4. The Kingdom of God and Transformation 49
   - Jesus Christ is Lord and King 49
   - Four Case Studies of Power Encounter 53
   - Liberation of a Dalit Slave Girl 57

5. Transforming Language of Mission 61
   - Religious Language and Violence 62
   - Transformational Mission Language and Biblical Metaphor 66
   - Statement on Mission Language 72

6. Democracy and Transforming India 74
   - Democracy 74
   - Law as a Tool for Transformation 78

7. The Tribals
   - Tribal Identity and the Transformation of India, Dino L. Touthangs 82
   - Identity and Dignity 86
   - Nagaland Transformation: From Head Hunters to Hallelujah Singers 91

8. Urban Transformational Mission in India, Atul Y. Aghamkar....95

9. Transformational Health in Action 104
Health Indicators India....104
Case Study 1: Makunda Christian Hospital:
Subsidized School Education for the Tribal 105
Case Study 2: Jiwan Jyoti Christian Hospital:
Reaching the Poorest of the Poor....105

10. Conclusion: Vision Led Community of Christ as an
Agent of Transformation....107

Appendix A: New Delhi World Inquiry Report....111

Appendix B: World Inquiry Questions for Focus Groups....115

Endnotes 116

Preface

Christian women and men are creative catalysts for social transformation. As the actual historical bearer of transformation, the Church journeys in the direction of possible transformation – towards the fullness of life in individuals and towards justice in society. The market society will not be able to absorb the Church, for the presence and power of God is concretely and publicly manifested in the life of the community. The self-giving love of the community is the shaping power of the household of Jesus Christ.

Social, economic, religious, and political enslaving realities cause massive human misery in the global community. We must focus on the Church community through which these realities in the public domain will be transformed. The Church is a community in which human sin and fear, and the power of evil and death, are taken into the life of God's love because of the redemption provided in Christ; and the power of God's love is given to the community for the sake of the redemption of the world and God's reign of glory.

In our journey of transformation in this world, the household of Christ and market society are uncomfortable partners. In the business world, companies try to transform themselves into significantly better competitors. For example, Nike's reason for being, as defined by its core purpose, is: "To experience the emotion of competition, winning, and crushing competitors." The efforts of the market society to transform are portrayed under various labels: Turnaround, restructuring, reengineering, total quality management, right sizing, and cultural change. The basic goal in almost every case has been to make fundamental changes in how business is conducted in order to help cope with a new, more challenging market environment.

The reality of market is all-encompassing as its channels flow into every nation, city, and village of the world. Market is changing the world. But the market will not redeem the world. Market has no power against sin, evil, and death despite its claims of universal spread and effectiveness. According to Robert Heilbroner, the nature of our society is accumulation of wealth as power and the logic of our society is exchange of commodities.[1] Everything hops around these realities. The modern man believes in them implicitly and shapes his life according to this logic. It is increasingly the reason through which people expect life, happiness, security, and future. No one can deny its awesome effect on modernity.

The damaging effect of the new global economy is visible with the increasing decline of traditional community-based life in the Asian societies. In the information-based modern economic society, the individual comes up against an ever faster circulation of goods, images, money, ideas, and other human beings.[2] The shared meanings and healthy practices of community are emptied out in a process of isolation of the self. The rare product of

modernity is the isolated individual in the midst of technological society, yet embedded in relationships which transcend time and space, via mobile phone and the worldwide web. The markets can be modified with communities that become the bearers of the values which define human beings beyond their possessions, their work, and their consumption. The challenge before the Church is to be the genuine community of transformation. This book addresses the crucial role of the Church as the transforming multicultural community that witnesses to God's power to transform cultural and ethnic differences through the cross of Christ.

The market-oriented models actively promote and impose their secular, materialistic, and modern value systems on society. By doing this, are they not guilty of the proselytizing for which religious organisations are blamed? Secular approaches are not neutral. They have an agenda that the development of people and nation can take place without God and without an analysis of evil and sin.[3] Christians cannot be a party to this ideology. In the major religious traditions of South Asia the search for secular elements in the cultural traditions is a futile exercise. In these traditions the ideology of secularism is not only absent but also resisted.[4] The factor of religion has to be brought into discussion for the development of the community. Otherwise, human beings are being defined as necessarily and essentially secular.

The transformational theology refuses to let the world set the agenda by replacing theological imperatives with ideological causes. Christians can never take pragmatic approach to transformation that appears to be delivering results, for this would allow ideology to replace theology and the pursuit of power will eclipse truth. The Church should never allow any ideology to eclipse its witness. However, the culprit is not the market per se, but what Karl Polanyi calls "market society," that is, a society in which all the spheres in which social goods have to be distributed are controlled by the market logic itself.[5] There is a difference between Christian and secular approaches to transformation. What cannot appear under the market is the reality of God's self-giving love, which is expressed in grace. The logic of the market, which is accumulation of wealth as power even by "crushing competitors," gives no room for relationships and practices that are governed by obedience to the Lord, self-giving, righteousness, love, reconciliation, justice, cooperation, service, stewardship, love for neighbour, equality and empowerment by the Holy Spirit. Transformation is not just accelerating the process of change. God must be the source, the means, and the end for all we do in the transformation of communities – so that God is glorified, as individuals and communities experience the power and presence of God. The transformation of the market man and the influence upon the market society with the above-mentioned values of the Kingdom of God are the tasks of the transformational mission of the Church.

The economic benefits accrue to the

society precisely in accordance with social stratification – the upper social classes have higher access to higher economic privileges, like capital, credit, and entrepreneurial opportunities. Globalisation offers the upper 20% of Indian population the advantages of global market. For the international entrepreneurs, India's upper 20% constitutes a market of nearly 300 million. Those who are rich have power over the lives of those who are poor. Their freedom is eroded and their equal humanity is denied when they depend upon others for the right to work and the right to eat. Those who control people's livelihood control them. Human dignity cannot be given to a person by the kindness of others. It involves equality, freedom, and economic empowerment, along with relations of mutual respect among people and a conscious participation in the life of the society. These are crucial in addressing the issues of transformational development.

The transformational reflection and action belong where the triune God is redeeming his creation, among the poor and the threatened places of creation. There are millions of families in India and around the world whose financial resources – including their educational and occupational skills, the circumstances of their environment at home and at work, and their material belongings – fall dangerously below those controlled by the average person or family in society; they indeed are victims of poverty. Jesus was concerned about the poorest of the poor; the Church needs to be concerned with them as well. What message do we have for India and the global village in which the poor and the marginalised are exploited, disease and death are rampant, education and employment scarce, stinginess and sluggishness common, cheating and corruption epidemic, caste and colour discrimination abusive, and opportunity and realisation of personal potential drastically limited?

Do we know the depth of injustice prevailing in our country? Have we ever intentionally questioned it? More than 160 million people in India are Dalits tainted by their birth into a caste system that deems them impure, less than human. Nearly 90 percent of all the poor people in India and 95 percent of all the illiterate people in India are Dalits. Human rights abuses against Dalits are legion. Dalits are not allowed to drink from the same wells, attend the same temples, wear shoes in the presence of an upper caste, or drink from the same cups in tea stalls. Statistics compiled by India's National Crime Records Bureau indicate that in the year 2000, the last year for which figures are available, 25,455 crimes were committed against Dalits. Every hour, two Dalits are assaulted; every day, three Dalit women are raped, two Dalits are murdered, and two Dalit homes are torched. No one believes these numbers are anywhere close to the reality of crimes committed against Dalits.

Dalit women are particularly hard hit. They are frequently raped or beaten as a means of reprisal against male relatives who are thought to have committed some act

worthy of upper caste vengeance. They are also subject to arrest if they have male relatives hiding from the authorities. The issue of Dalits and the Church is dealt with at length in this volume. We should be under no illusion as to the serious and hopeless state of humankind's condition. Human beings are helpless and powerless to aid themselves: ungodly, shackled with a sinful nature; sinner, lost and in a sorry state, missing the target of divine righteousness and coming short of the divine glory. Humankind's need is transformation. Broken relationship and wickedness make men and women unable to save themselves and lead to them being cast only on the free forgiveness of God. In such a context, God wants the quality of life of the transformed community of Christ to be a challenge and a sign of hope to society around it. The life of the Christian community must be evidence that God is indeed the deliverer.

The role of spiritual transformation of individuals should not cause us to disregard the role of education and legislation in community transformation. The Christian community cannot yield total control of education and legislation to secular agencies. We are duty bound to exemplify and to promote social justice. Institutionalized injustice requires institutional action for change. We have discussed the issues of democracy and law as transforming agents.

It was Adolph Hitler who said to the gathering of pastors "interfering" with government policies, "I will protect the German people. You take care of the Church. You pastors should worry about getting people to heaven and leave this world to me." If good vacates the sphere of government, then evil will move in. Satan wants strife and darkness to prevail at every level of society. Can't we see everywhere his malevolent influence working hand in hand with human sin? There is a need to stand against that which is sinful and corrupt in order to show the good and the creative. We should not accept as normative oppressive, wicked, and exploitative forces that rob human existence of its God-given worth. Constructive social reform according to biblical principles is as legitimate an area for Christian action as the compassionate acts of charity, and just as urgent. Because the crucified Jesus in his resurrection triumphed over the forces of iniquity, they all are now dated and doomed. We are called to affirm and to exemplify love and justice.

Howsoever important that Christian participation in affairs of the state, legislation, and culture may be, the Church is dangerously mistaken to relate to these concerns by sacrificing its prior responsibilities towards the family and vocational calling. Our volume highlights the transformation of families in mission as agents in God's hand for transformation of communities. Nor can the Church rely only on education, legislation, and techniques to achieve social transformation. The disappointment that has followed hard on these experiments should sober and sharpen our awareness of humanities hunger and needs.

Many nations today assertively employ religion as an operative principle for organizing societies.[6] All the neighbouring countries of India opted to make the religion of the majority community the state religion: Pakistan and Bangladesh (Islam), Nepal (Hindu), Myanmar and Sri Lanka (Buddhist). India remains the only secular state surrounded by neighbours who are not. The 21st century has witnessed the renaissance of religion which rejects the premise that God is dead, which Nietzsche predicted would shape the 20th century. The ideologies[7] that defined much of Western culture and influenced the world have declined, and their place is taken by religions and other culturally-based forms of identity and commitment. Increasing numbers of people all over the globe confess they are spiritual but not religious. It's spirituality without truth-claim or authority but filled with belief in the supernatural. Transformation theology must contribute to recognition of the ambivalence and corruptibility of morals and commend life centred in God, revealed in Jesus Christ. Morals can be occupied and guided by the most varied forms of ethos. Religious language is often employed by societies to gain moral sanction for acts of violence. The way forward for transformational mission, as we have discussed in this volume, is of blessing and reconciliation.

We now briefly discuss the process of transformation, considering its usage in the scripture. Transformation stands for internal change, a new vision of life that imparts meaning to existence brought about by a paradigm shift, so that the "form" energizing a particular person or culture undergoes change by an inner process caused by external factors.

Transformation is not changing what is, but creating what isn't. A fitting example is a butterfly. A butterfly is not a different caterpillar or a superior or improved caterpillar, but it is a new creature. Likewise, a person who encounters Christ is not reformed, rehabilitated, or well-informed; he is recreated, living in vital union with Christ. Paul explains this in 2 Corinthians 5:17, "Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; the old has gone, the new has come!" Those in Christ are new people on the inside. The Holy Spirit gives them new life, and they are not the same anymore. Transcendence (God) is the source and power of transformation.

The transformation which the world proposes does not have Christ as its pattern. Paul therefore urges in Romans 12:2, "Do not be conformed to the pattern of this world (age)." Our sinful nature is determined by its cravings and illusions. It refuses to acknowledge human creatureliness and dependence on God; rather, it makes self-satisfaction the highest priority and rejects the love of God revealed in the self-giving sacrifice of Jesus Christ. Our refusal to conform to worldly behaviour and customs must be firmly rooted in our minds, as Paul writes, "Be transformed by the renewing of your mind" (v.2). When the Holy Spirit recreates, renews, and redirects our minds, only then are we transformed. Transformation imparts a new vision of life, and existence takes on a new meaning.

This transformation takes place *within* this world and is not completely futuristic. This beckons us to a transformational engagement in the world and not a retreat into escapism.

The process of transformation is gradual and progressive from one stage of glory to yet a higher stage, climaxing in the goal "to be conformed to the likeness of his Son" (Rom 8:17, 29, and 30). Paul explains this in 2 Cor. 3:18; 4:16. "And we, who with unveiled faces all reflect the Lord's glory, are being transformed into his likeness with ever-increasing glory, which comes from the Lord, who is the Spirit." And, "Though outwardly we are wasting away, yet inwardly we are being renewed day by day." The agent in this process of transformation is the Holy Spirit who effects change, transforming believers into the likeness of Christ, who is the exemplar of the new humanity.

The transformed household of Christ, under his Lordship, is sent into the world to proclaim personal and social righteousness and redemption. Jesus proclaimed and demonstrated the Kingdom of God in human society, in individual life and community. The transformational mission of the Church is characterized by its openness to and engagement with the whole agenda of the Kingdom of God.

Transformational mission is not a matter of prioritizing the various ministries of the Church. Our vision of the Kingdom has been impaired by our tendency to compartmentalize and argue about the priority. An encounter with Christ transforms for the fullness of life, which is found in reconciliation with God and environment and an engagement in liberation of the world from all types of oppressive structures. The Gospel is Good News concerning the Kingdom, and the Kingdom is God's rule over the totality of life. The link which binds all of us together is God's love poured into our hearts by the Holy Spirit (Romans 5:5).

In our journey with God and one another, we should perpetually stay open to rediscover the ingredients of amazement, challenge, and ongoing revaluation. In the Lord's Prayer which Jesus taught his disciples to pray, the will of the heavenly Father is summarized as the establishment of the Kingdom of God on earth as it exists in heaven. Can we pray and work for anything less?

Introduction

The Transformation Journey

Indian evangelical reflection and action has taken shape and evolved with increasing significance since the formation of Evangelical Fellowship of India (EFI)[8] in 1951. Increased participation in World Evangelical events helped in renewed vision and inspiration and new efforts in evangelism. Congresses such as the Lausanne Congress, Berlin Congress 1966, and Asia Pacific Congress on Evangelism in Singapore, 1968 have had significant influence in the calling of the first All India Congress of Mission and Evangelism (AICOCIM). The first AICOCME was conveyed in January 4th-8th 1970 as a mark of gratitude to God for his goodness in EFI's 20 years of ministry. About 300 hundred indigenous and predominantly lay and youth participants gathered at Barnes School, Deolali in Maharashtra, with the primary concern of motivating both co-operative and personal evangelism.

The second AICOME was held on 12th-19th January 1977, again at Deolali with about 400 participants from all over India and overseas observers. Mission was solely understood as the proclamation of the gospel among non-Christians; the emphasis remained on personal transformation to change the society. The significant outcome was the formation of India Missions Association (IMA), with the purpose of bringing together the Indian Missionary Organizations under a national network for mutual help and co-operation and co-operate expression.

EFI was not unconcerned about the poor and the marginalized and in 1967 in response to the devastation caused by flood in Andhra Pradesh it established a consultative committee on emergency and relief. In 1970 it was christened as EFI Committee on Relief. Since then EFICOR has emerged as a major evangelical agency addressing issue of relief and development. Their vision is, "Working towards a just, responsible and compassionate society."

The third AICOME was held in Pune from 4th -8th January 1988 at Union Biblical Seminary, with the theme into the nineties with Christ. About 250 leaders met to review the past and identify the challenges and tasks of the Church in the coming years.

Deeply concerned about the rapid degeneration of our social life; the hatred, often spread by religious leaders, caused incalculable suffering to families of the victims of riots, terrorism and religious persecution, in September 1998 in New Delhi EFI organized a national consultation on reconciliation, religious liberty and social justice in which about 150 leaders and heads of Churches, Christian organizations and mission agencies drawn from 20 states gathered.

EFI issued a statement some portions of which read as follows, "We affirm that God's love as displayed in Jesus Christ compels us to commit ourselves to a

ministry of reconciliation. We recognize that we need grace to learn to forgive instead of fighting for revenge. Reconciliation is impossible without spiritual resources to bear shame and humiliation and return good for evil, blessing for insult. Because inter and intra-communal harmony is a necessary prerequisite for nation building, we commit ourselves to fulfill the mandate for reconciliatory engagement as required by God's reconciling initiative in the death and resurrection of our Lord Jesus Christ."

"We affirm that human rights are inherent in our creation, they are not given by states, or by the majority to the minority. The state exists to protect the rights of the citizens. Human rights are equal rights – equal, in spite of our obvious differences of gender, creed, class, language or race. Freedom of conscience, thought and mind is the most fundamental aspect of human freedom. Securing other person's rights is our responsibility, because God has put us in the same family and so made us related to and responsible for one another. We commit ourselves to defend and strengthen these freedoms for all our citizens, using creative and constitutional means, even at the risk of our lives.

Religious liberty and reconciliation have little meaning except in the context of a just social order. A just social order is characterized by dignity and respect for all human beings irrespective of their caste, creed, or gender. There has to be a special sensitivity towards those who cannot compete equally because of special physical, medical, social, or economic disadvantages. We recognize that a multi-faceted battle against such all pervasive evils is beyond our human strength and ability. Therefore, we commit ourselves to pray for God's Holy Spirit to equip and enable us for the tasks He is entrusting to us."

The consultation was a noteworthy step forward to intentionally embrace issues of reconciliation religious freedom and social justice as mission issues not in isolation but in cooperation with other ecumenical and catholic bodies.

At the dawn of the new century we saw, India with a population of more than one billion, the largest emerging middle class in the world, the tremendous increase in urbanization and its impact both in urban and rural life, media and information technology influencing the life of people more than ever before in history, media and information technology influencing the life of people, and the cry of the poor and the marginalized, the Dalits calling for liberation.

We realized that in addressing the role of the Church and its proactive engagement in nation building, a biblical vision of society needs to be presented as the answer to the desperate communal tensions, economic disparity and human freedoms which continue to ravage the nation. Our work of Christian witness is carried out in the context of the ancient and rich religious culture of India. We do missions with a spirit of courteous listening and respect to people of different religious convictions and practices. Our Christian

witness and mission are essential to the well being of the people of our land.

The evangelical leadership represented by EFI decided that an All India Congress on Church in Mission (AICOCIM) 1999 is necessary to evaluate the situation and develop a common strategy and collaboration to progressively advance the Gospel of Jesus Christ in this context. At the 4th and final congress of the last millennium, the emphasis was on –Church in mission - a significant shift to Church, the community of faith involved in God's mission. About 450 church and mission agency leaders participated. The main objective being to review the past 10-50 years of the Church's mission in India, assess the present trends, with the expected outcomes of a workable strategic plan for impacting India for Christ in the next millennium.

The Church in India is growing. What happened in the 19th century missionary movement of South India during the *hey days* of Western missionary movement is now experienced in the North India but it is led by Indians in partnership with the universal church. Christian workers who are sons and daughters of the soil own the vision and the church in India is indeed Indian.

What started, as essentially a cross-cultural missionary movement in India is now very different in character! There is greater emphasis on the local church doing missions. The emphasis is on the whole church taking the whole gospel to the whole city/nation/world. Transformation as a way of doing missions and living out the values of the Kingdom of God is increasingly emphasized by the various churches. The denominational walls are gradually but surely breaking down. The focus is on partnership and networking in the process of doing missions.

One of the major recommendations of AICOCIM was the launching of an urban ministry initiative. The challenges of initiating a new movement are like a mother giving birth with great labor pain. We have had our share of pain, but the process culminated in the formation of Evangelical Fellowship of India National Urban Network (EFINUN). Each member of the network retains its identity and at the same time is involved in synergistic relationships. EFINUN is primarily a facilitating body.

Evangelizing Our World Inquiry

Then came the City Inquiry process which worked as a catalyst in birthing something new and wonderful. Dr Luis Bush was invited by the Evangelical Fellowship of India to be an external facilitator for the Inquiry. There were sixteen World Inquiry events from January 6th to the 27th 2003 mainly in capitals of the states and mostly one-day events from 10:00 a.m. to 5 p.m.

It all started on 6th January 2003 in Delhi, the capital of India Richard Howell[9] moderated the proceedings (See Report of Delhi World Inquiry in Appendix A and survey questions in Appendix B). The participants were male and female, older and younger who were

carefully selected Christian leaders from mainline churches, Evangelical and Charismatic churches and other inter-church agencies from the primary ethnic cultural and linguistic groups. Listening to the stories of transforming power of God at work and sharing by the participants of God's initiatives through churches, fellowships, institutions and individuals added to the dimension of excitement and all became aware of how God is working in and around the city. The Church in India is growing largely outside the established ecclesiastical structures. The work of the ministry is carried on by men and women and both lay and ordained provide leadership. All this is happening while the country is passing through a social economic and political turmoil

Converging of Different Streams

While in Chandigarh as the sharing progressed all were excited to hear how God is leading the pastors and lay people and youth groups into creative ministries. But towards the end of the session it appeared we will not have oneness on the way forward. One insisted our focus should be proclamation of the gospel, "taking gospel to the hearts of people,' as he put it. Another insisted we need to live out the values of the Kingdom of God and address the issues of social justice. Consensus was reached when a participant unable to contain himself said, "we need a mega vision." It was as if the Holy Spirit had spoken through him. We visualized how all the pieces fit together. It was a real *Aha* moment for us. Polarities are man-made primarily because our vision is small. If the vision is of God and His Kingdom the process of renewing is unleashed. God opened our eyes to something very wonderful-His Kingdom. We overcame the polarities of evangelism, social action and development. We learnt that all peoples and communities need transformation.

Need For Paradigm Shift

Ludhiana experience was very insightful where about seventy pastors' church planters came together. There hearts desire is to reach every people group with the gospel of Jesus Christ. The whole group was further sub-divided into eleven small working groups

The interaction in the eleven small groups was as lively as their discoveries. Each shared their heart beat from the findings as they strove for a consensus. When the combined results of the city Inquiry were released it was nothing short of a revelation. All agreed God is calling his church to a ministry of social transformation. Remember this is a group of Christian leaders who are committed to the proclamation of the Word. The time is ripe for paradigm shift. In stead of understanding Christian mission solely in terms of personal transformation the communities need to obey the Gospel of Jesus Christ in value transformation.

Conducting city inquiry was a multi-faceted adventure. The fog led to delayed flights and even over flights the venues were we were supposed to land. In one such incident the following was written by

Johnny Desai the facilitator of city Inquiry. “What had happened in Patna was very interesting. The flights were cancelled and my train was delayed. When I reached there, they were struggling with the questionnaires. The dinner was waiting and I was given the charge – No Luis Bush, not his computer, no nothing… I wound up with running through the questionnaire – taking majority response in terms of preference and importance of the issues… I shared with the group what had been happening in other cities and the voice of Patna was the same! Transformation”!

In Serampore at the College that William Carey founded, the participants involved in the Inquiry included the Principal, Vice-Principal, faculty of the Seminary, pastors and Christian leaders in the community and the graduating class of the seminary. The principal kept saying "This is the kind of meeting I had been hoping to have for a long time." Amazingly with such a varied group present, in part, because of the minority they are as Christians in the Serampore city a definitive city-based initiative birthed with vision statement, mission statement core group including representation of the various constituencies present at the meeting.

Renewal of the Church

In every city that we went there was a consensus that the transformation movement will lead to renewal of the Church. Since the emphasis is on the whole church taking the whole gospel to the whole world. For this to happen there is greater need for vision, united prayer movement, discipleship, mentoring of younger leaders, study of the word of God, the need for transformation has been stated in the inquiry focus groups. However, it was recognized that it is not only the city and the church that needs transformation it is the Christian leader and his family and other Christians that do.

Mission as Transformation

In South India and North–East India where the Christian presence is strong the discoveries were no less amazing. The city Inquiry threw up the finding that the number one hindrance to Christian work is the relevance of Christian faith, not that the faith is not relevant but the way the church and mission agencies have presented is perceived as irrelevant. Therefore the society at large perceives of Christian faith talking only about sending people to heaven and very less about the challenges facing the society here on earth. It was recognized that it is not sufficient to emphasize that societies would be transformed by converting individuals to Christ, we also need to stress that communities needed to enjoy fullness of life in harmony with God through obedience to the gospel. In the ever changing local and global context mission as transformation is the way forward.

Chapter 1

Personal Transformation

Repentance as a Mark of a Transformed Life

Repenting is a mark of transformed life. Repenting, involves rejecting one set of behaviors and changing to another. Repenting in the New Testament means not just a change of inward nature but a complete change of one's life. The Bible is rich in idioms describing man's responsibility in the process of repentance. Such phrases would include the following: "yield your heart to God" (Joshua 24:23); "circumcise yourselves to the Lord" (Jer. 4:4); ""wash the evil from your heart" (Jer. 4:14). Repenting implies returning to God and turning from evil.

The fact that people are called to turn to God implies that sin is not an ineradicable stain, but by turning, which is a God given power, a sinner can redirect his destiny. Repentance indeed involves repudiation of all sin and affirmation of God's total will for one's life.

Jesus proclaimed "repent for the Kingdom of heaven is near" (Mt.4:17). The coming of Jesus is the coming of the kingdom in person. At the centre of Jesus message is the proclamation of the urgent dawning of the Kingdom of God. In anticipation of God's activity, which involves judgment as well as redemption, there can be only one clarion call, to repent and turn to God revealed in Jesus Christ. Repentance is closely linked with the expectation of divine judgment and need for forgiveness of sins. The Lord clearly taught that failure to repent would result in judgment and death (Matt. 3:10; 11:20-24; Luke 13:3, 5).

Jesus gave an object lesson on repentance by placing a little child among his disciples and saying; "Unless you change and become like little children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven" (Matt 18:3).Jesus contrasted the trust and humility of a child with pride and self-seeking. With repentance, a believer can break from the trap of selfishness. Jesus said, "You cannot serve God and Money" and "Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you" (Matthew 6:24 and 5:44). Jesus' teaching on money and violence show us that repenting has social relevance. Followers of Jesus must turn from the sins of loving money and hating enemies. These two commands of Jesus also prompt us to analyze such words as envy, jealousy, greed, enmity, and hostility.

The Snare of Envy

John earns enough money to provide food and education of his family. He encounters problems when his children come home from school and talk about how rich their class mates are and the good food they bring for lunch. Once young Solomon even asked his father John, "Daddy are we poor people?" John feels embarrassed at work when his colleagues talk about the

television set they possess. In fact his co-workers often quote the advertisement for a brand of television, “Owner’s Pride Neighbor’s Envy”. John begins to believe that to be socially acceptable he needs certain possessions, which would remove the family’s humiliation. This is a trap into which John and his family is dragged. Envy transforms the ideas of the powerful class into the ideas that control society, allowing for the snare of envy.

Here is another man. Having decided to spend a fortune on his daughter’s wedding, especially to out do others in giving dowry, a father received bribes during his long tenure of service to an organization. He later confessed the fact. No wonder Jesus said, “You can’t serve God and Money”. Transformed life in Christ must resist the snare of envy.

The Snare of Enmity

People see power as the key to achievement, whether it is personal or social, technological or military, political or administrative, religious or spiritual. Power also has the capacity to corrupt and destroy. Human history shows this whenever there is a massacre and innocent lives are lost because a person or group has gained the power of money or aggressive use of force. People even perceive violence as indicating social status, so victims of oppression are also prompted to seek redress by violent means. For example the practice of apartheid in South Africa by the white people was oppressive for the blacks and other communities. But since the overthrow of the white regime, blacks with power may imitate the oppressive actions and position formerly enjoyed by whites. Similarly Dalits, who suffer under casteism, when liberated, may continue a form of casteism by Brahmin bashing. The oppressed tend to inherit the values of the oppressors. For an oppressor to repent requires a desire to change and make restitution to those who have been wronged, and also removing the injustice that triggered the original violation.

Envy and enmity, greed for money and violence can be transformed only if their hold on the hearts of those who practice them is broken. This is where repentance comes in. Transformed lives resist the trap of the sinful values and practices and live the new values of God’s kingdom. This enables them to participate in authentic social transformation. This is why Jesus said the first action a person experiences on coming Kingdom of God is to have their heart made pure and receive the promise that they will see God (Matthew 5:8).

Repenting Brings Hope and Transformation

Jesus’ illumined hope in the hearts of the oppressed when he proclaimed that God’s unconditional love was available to those who repent. For example the Samaritan woman’s life was transformed when she met Jesus at the well (John 4). She had suffered from double oppression, first gender, for she was a woman and also racial, for she was a Samaritan, the outcaste of her times. Although she was much sinned against, she also needed to

repent for she too had committed sin.

Repenting by the victim prohibits the oppressors to decide the terms under which social conflict is carried out, the values with which to involve in conflict and the means by which to engage in struggle. Repentance thus empowers victims and disempowers the oppressors. Repentance envisions God's new world in the midst of the old and so makes the transformation of the old possible.

Jesus established a connection between the hope he provides to the oppressed and the complete change of life he demands of them. The new set of values in the Kingdom of God cannot take place without a change of heart and behavior. People from all castes and races need transformation. Be it Samaritans or Jews, Dalits or Brahmins, Blacks or Whites, all need to repent, forgive and reconcile. Transformation ushers in a reconciled community serving and reconciling in society.

Compassion as the Passion of a Transformed Life

God's compassion is rooted in his free love and grace therefore his punishment is more desirable than man's wrath. An excellent example of this is David's sin of pride and ambition in counting his people, which God had forbidden. David by his actions conveyed that he placed his faith in the size of his army rather than in God's ability to protect them regardless of the numbers. Both David and the Israelites were guilty of sin (1 Sam 24). God dealt with the whole nation through David who symbolized the national sin of pride. God offered David three choices. Each was a form of punishment God had warned his people earlier, they could expect if they disobeyed his laws. David sensibly chose the punishment that came most directly from God. Experience had taught him the brutality and cruelty of war, yet he was also acquainted with God's great compassion. Therefore David submitted, "Let us fall into the hand of the Lord."(v.14).God's dealing with David offered a model for all later generations to know that deliverance is a real possibility. While at the same time illuminating God's compassion is consistent with his holiness and love. The content of this compassion is not just an attitude but, a bestowal of benefit. It has a concrete expression with real results: deliverance from sin, disease and death, abundant life, justice for the oppressed. God's compassion was indeed made humanly visible in the incarnation of Jesus Christ.

The Messianic Compassion

The Messianic compassion of Jesus was manifested when as the good shepherd he taught the harassed and helpless crowds (Matthew 9:36) to keep them from straying from God. Jesus positively assured "You will know the truth and the truth will set you free" (John. 8:32). The truth of God's Word when obeyed empowers communities and transforms lives. Jesus was concerned about human bodies, just as he was about the souls. He fed four thousand, besides women and children. (Matthew 15:32ff.) He raised to life the dead son of the widow

at Nain, (Luke. 7:12-15) demonstrating his concern for the world's sorrow. In Jesus the compassion and power of God was made obvious. The power of Jesus was to serve his creation. Before he healed the blind Bartimaeus he asked, "What do you want me to do for you?" (Mark 10:46-52). Jesus' question portrays him as an exemplar of service. Leadership roles are not positions for flaunting authority but functions for responsible service. Have we ever asked the poor, what can I do for you?

Beware of Market Values

The Pharisees saw the common people as chaff to be destroyed and burned up; Jesus saw them as a harvest to be reaped and to be saved (Matthew 9:36-83). With the publication of the book Harvesting Our Souls by Arun Shouri (1999) the word harvest is distorted to mean a selfish gain, whereas Jesus used the word harvest to mean the infinite value of human life which requires compassionate, sacrificial self-giving. In contemporary society the poor and the weak are usually considered chaff. So how does compassion then exist in the market place? An arena where cut throat competition guided by self-interest and individualism is the norm, where weakness is despised and success is defined by the power one possesses and exercises. To survive in a free market economy, one must have capital or skills; in India at least 350 million are at the bottom of society, people who have neither capital nor skills are thus beyond the scope of survival in a market economy. In such a context Christians are called upon to question the priorities of the market society and challenge the demonic that takes the place of God in human lives and reduces humankind to slavery, to lust and greed. Jesus focused on the little ones and took special care of the losers. The church should be in the forefront of empowering the cause and aspirations of the poor and the marginalized for this is true neighborliness.

If we claim to see poverty and are not motivated to elevate the condition of the poor then according to the scripture we have not seen, for in the Bible seeing and being prepared to help are one. The priest and the Levite in the parable of the Good Samaritan saw the wounded but passed on the other side (Luke10:30-37). Whereas the Samaritan saw and used all means, time, strength to save life at the crucial moment. Neighborliness is not a quality but action of showing mercy. Jews were forbidden to receive works of love from non-Jews; both the giving and receiving of mercy transcends national, racial and caste barriers, such considerations are irrelevant.

From the Samaritan we learn that compassion makes the unbounded mercy of God visible. However some philosophies advocate that God is incapable of feelings. The votaries of Advaita Vedanta in the Hindu religion believe God is an impersonal reality, which is beyond emotions. But Incarnate Jesus Christ was moved to the depths of his being. God is not indifferent he really suffers when people sinfully destroy his creation and literally rejoices when one

sinner repents. God's emotions are always consistent with his holiness and love. His emotions are never out of control. Indeed, God is devoid of caprice and unbridled passions.

Maturing Christians in a fallen world become more compassionate. Living in the presence of God we should not only rejoice with those who rejoice but also weep with those who weep. With empathy we identify with sufferings and sorrows of others bearing their burdens. Moved by daily meditation upon God's emotional characteristics, we increasingly seek the empowering of the Holy Spirit to control our own emotional patterns so that they become more like his. Like the God in whose presence we feel, as well as think and act, we will not cultivate apathy or indifference to reality. Having acknowledged the appropriately intense emotions in God, we should not be shocked when Christians are deeply moved in the face of gross sin and repent from it. Those who would be like God increasingly detest evil. In the face of social injustice to the poor and powerless, the godly hate oppression, discrimination, selfishness, greed, covetousness, and always live consciously in the presence of the Holy One.

Compassion brought Jesus from heaven to the humble manger. He who was in the form of God took on the form of man, to be with his rebel creation, to love and to care. – The unclean he made clean, - the defenseless he empowered, - the exhausted he fed, the widow he cared for. The human life he died, as an example of servanthood. He transforms our lives and it is our privilege to follow his example. The transformational mission of compassion compels Christians to confront the hopelessness and despair, with word and deed, for God acts in history to make a difference.

Chapter 2

The Family: Family Values Are Kingdom Values

As agents of God's Kingdom Christian homes must treasure spiritual values in the family. The institution of family is rooted in the nature of the triune God. Each person of the Trinity functions harmoniously in an unbroken fellowship of love with others. Hence God himself is the model of all community and fellowship. God has built in the most basic social relationship of the family as an undeniable feature of the humankind.

The family is the first transmitter of beliefs, behavior and values that sustain communities. One innocent child lost to the faith generally results a family lost to the faith, and not many generations afterwards a whole community of unbelief is set in motion because of some previous particular neglect of parental duties.

> Listen to what Melanie has to say:" My family remains my school house. From those people I learned to love and obey God, the values of the Kingdom of God, the importance of Church fellowship and family prayers. I learned to love music, care for the poor, save my money, and treasure my walks. I also learned how to love and how to fight. Sometimes I learned by good examples; other times I learned what not to do. Now I carry my family with me as I live out the lessons of childhood in the process of creating my new family. At this point, I'm very grateful that I grew up in a good 'school.'"

In Genesis 1 we read: "So God created humankind in his image, in the image of God he created them, male and female he created them" (v.28). Human beings exist in an irreducible duality of male and female; there are no generic human beings, only male or female human beings. Genesis 2 suggests that duality is rooted in their sexed bodies. Gender difference is therefore an inalienable feature of human existence. When Paul writes that in Christ there is "no longer male and female' he is not arguing that Christ has erased differences of the sexed body, rather in Christ some important culturally coded norms attached to sexed bodies are erased, for example, obligation to marry and procreate and prohibition from performing certain functions in the church. The oneness in Christ is a community of people with sexed bodies and distinct gender identities, not some abstract unity of pure spirits. However it is crucial not to lose sight of the fundamental equality between men and women.

Family is rooted in the creation of male and female to leave mother and father, cleave to one another, and multiply (Genesis 2:24). The mutual covenant commitment of husband and wife transforms them to reflect lifelong loving companionship and mutual helpfulness in

their work as stewards of the earth. The final reason for families staying together is not legal agreement enforced by the Church or state, but demonstration of Trinitarian love and grace. It is precisely the one triune God in whose image all human beings are created who holds the promise of peace between men and women.

Kingdom of God must be the criterion for evaluating family life. Marital fidelity promotes personal security, family stability, and community solidarity. Jesus reinforced the creation ordinance by adding, "Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate" (Matt. 19:4-6). People support family values by opposing casual sex, out of wedlock births, abortion on demand, and recreational drug use.

Since the Fall, the best of filial relationships come short of the divine ideal. The family should not usurp the prerogatives of God. Allegiance to the family can be required only under God. If and when family members, however well meaning they may be, would coerce a Christian to break God's precepts, believers ought to follow the higher authority.

Those who seek leadership in the Church should begin with their own homes. Before they lead the church, there should be sufficient evidence of their marital fidelity and ability to lead their own children in worthy directions (1Tim. 3:5; Titus 1:6). Those who would seek to promote a just and lasting peace through out the world should begin in their own families. Those with extended families have responsibilities to strengthen the values of more distant relatives. Christian ought to love and forgive relatives even when they seem to be adversaries. Principles of fairness and love apply beyond immediate family.

Family Communications

Indian society represents a wide diversity of caste, ethnic, tribal and cultural groups which have not become homogenized instead their respective heritages are maintained at times aggressively promoted across generations. Ethnicity affects family life through its traditions, celebrations, occupations, values, and problem solving. The glue for harmonious relations in the family and growth in understanding, love and care for one another is their commitment to Christ and the values of His Kingdom.

The changes over the past five or ten years in your family might amaze you. A family experiences changes that arise in everyday life, such as adapting to the marriage, sickness in the family, or job transfer of one of its members. Each family has both stability-promoting processes and change-promoting processes to maintain it.

Developing Styles of Interaction into Central Family Themes

Can the theme of the Kingdom of God be identified as your family's main theme which defines the communication behavior of your family members? Themes

represent a fundamental view of reality and a way of dealing with this view. Through its theme, a family responds to the questions, "Who are we?" and "What do we do about it?" Themes are statements that actualize the value more specifically, stated below are a few examples,

We are the light of the world.

We have responsibility for those less fortunate than we are.

You can depend only on your family.

You have to work for what you get.

We regularly go to Church.

We give first place to God in our lives.

Themes relate directly to family actions, thereby allowing us to surmise a family's themes by watching its actions. Living according to a theme necessitates the development of various patterns of behavior, which affect (1) how members interact with the outside world, (2) how they interact with each other, and (3) how they develop personally.

As parents what do we communicate to our children? Do we communicate to our children that increased consumerism and having more will result in increased happiness? For many this insatiable appetite for more can cost everything. Christian parents want the best for their children, as do all parents. But because of the pervasiveness and seduction of consumerism we tend to define what's best, as everyone else does, in largely economic terms. Sometimes under the garb of excellence, what we really promote is, "Go for the best you can for your self" – a purpose driven individualism. Do we model for our children and ask of them with regards to compassion and thinking of others. What place do poor have in our family decisions?

The family is indeed the central unit of the society. But should individual need stake priority over family needs? The social vitality should never be neglected in the commitment to provide individual fulfillment and responsibility. The reality is that poor people find it increasingly difficult to support family life amid physical conditions detrimental to family cohesion.

God gave parents the final responsibility for their children's vocational training. Our first parents' task of gaining dominion over the earth involved training their household to work for the good of the home. Christian parents should take final responsibility for preparing their children for productive work. Any work pursued without a sense of calling will lack spiritual vitality.

The Church should be involved in rebuilding families on the basis of love, responsibility, commitment to the education of children abstinence from alcohol and marital fidelity. The purposes of God's kingdom are subversive to many of the aspirations and goals of the dominant market culture. The primary vocation for every family is not what we do to earn a livelihood but how we devote our lives, as Christ did, to seeking to advance the purposes of the Kingdom of God.

Set up Satisfactory Similarity of Family Images

The aim of parents in God's kingdom is to train each child to believe the promises of covenant making God, love God and think and act with moral responsibility in the family, church and nation. Parents should respect and value their children for they also bear the image of the Creator.

If you had to allocate images, or mental pictures, to specific family members, what would they be? Would your father be a teddy bear who is soft, and lovable? Would he be a general – organized, military, and distanced? Or would his image merge some of these qualities? The images determine the pattern of communication with others.

Parents ought to exhibit God's love for children in parental love (Eph. 5:1).With unconditional love parents will provide for their imperfect Children's need for acceptance and for necessities, such as food and clothing. True parental love is unconditional and unselfish and also involves discipline. Loving parents know that they will need to discipline their children to avoid hurting themselves and others. Fathers ought not exasperate or embitter their children, but lovingly and justly bring them up "in the training and instruction of the Lord" (Eph. 6:4; Col. 3:21).Parents ought to discipline the children they love for their good, following God's example (Heb. 12:5-11).Parents should not usurp the place of God in the lives of Children nor should children occupy the place of God in the lives of parents. The highest value and ultimate concern of all family members should be to please God. We must put God's kingdom and his righteousness first.

In reflecting upon family image, people have provided the following examples: circus, flower, lighthouse, broken cycle wheel, nest, corporation, school room. A husband and wife are likely to experience conflict if one sees the family as a "nest" involving nurturing, emotion, and protection and the other sees it as a corporation involving a strong power structure and good organization. The level of similarity relates to the effectiveness of communication within the family.

God has entrusted to parents the ultimate responsibility for their children's moral and spiritual education. Your children will best learn the love of God if it is a remembered, experienced, and verbalized reality to you in every activity of your life. The authority of parents is to lead by example. As husband and wife does your relationship reflect an example of harmonious fellowship of love and grace?

Establishing the Boundaries of the Family's World of Experience

As well as developing images and themes, families create boundaries, limits for how members may act. Boundaries are the barriers to exchange of material, information, and values. All families establish some boundaries as they restrict their members from encountering certain physical and psychological forces. Most frequently, family boundaries regulate

access to people, beliefs, ideas, and values. Christian influence in the home serves to shelter most young people from immoral vocations.

Dealing with Significant Biosocial Issues of Family Life

All families operate in a larger sphere that provides conventional ways of coping with biosocial issues, such as male and female identity, authority and power, shaping and influencing children, and children rights. In most cultures, especially in the public domains, are male-centered and woman are either excluded or pressured to conform through outright discrimination and oppression. It is a male world in which female often feel as aliens in it.

What then are different aspects of husband –wife roles within marriage? Is it, for example, "unnatural" for a boy to play with dolls or a girl to like weightlifting? Would it depart from God's pattern for a father to keep house and look after the children while his wife went out to work? There are three possible sources of male/female roles. First, there are some inherent physical and psychological differences. The second aspect is that conditioning gives us most of our views of what activities we see as masculine or feminine. The third aspect is that God has revealed to us in Scripture certain differences in roles.

The Bible does not condemn a career woman just because of her career or a man for that matter. Either case, love of God and one's family should take precedence over love for money. Paul's first convert in Europe was Lydia, a business woman in her own right, and it was in her house that he stayed first. In Corinth Paul stayed with his two co-workers Priscilla and Acquilla, "because he was of the same trade…they were tentmakers. Both apparently shared in the employment, as both shared in giving spiritual instruction, and there is no hint that it might be proper only for husbands to work at a trade. This is after all, in line with the "good wife' of Proverbs 31, who seems to use her own initiative to engage in manufacturing, agriculture, and social work!

Yet some Christians have argued that man should be the provider. In doing so, they seem to forget that during Jesus ministry his women followers acted as patronesses and provided for him. Thus, though one might say that man has the ultimate responsibility for ensuring that the family is provided for, the actual pattern of provision can surely be worked out by the couple in whatever way they agree. God does not specify for them. All that can be said is that man who truly loves his wife as Christ loves the church will wish neither to patronize nor exploit her.

Gender relations much like human relations all too often lack respect and love and are sometimes suffused with enmity. As we suggested earlier the life of trinity is characterized by self-giving love. Ephesians 5 takes the self-giving of Christ for humanity as the model for relations between male and female: "Husbands,

love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her in order to make her holy" 9vv. 25-26). Self-giving does not imply loss of self. It certainly means caring for the other, to 'nourish' and 'tenderly care' in order to make 'without blemish' and clothe in 'splendor' 9vv. 29, 27). It also means opening of the self for the other, letting the other find space in the self.

In a world of enmity self-giving is the risky and hard work of love. There are no guarantees that self-giving will overcome enmity. Though there are no assurances of success, it does have the promise of eternity because it reflects the character of divine trinity. It is through the power of self-giving that a new community of women and men will emerge.

The Church Cannot Bless Same Sex Partnership

The dissonance of family life is a major challenge facing especially the urban educated India. Gay men and lesbians till recently were a fairly invisible part of the Indian society but now they are beginning to live with a partner. Partnership of homosexuals and lesbians are not a legitimate form of marriage. Why can't the church bless same – sex marriages? Because this decision as J.I. Packer clearly states "falsifies the gospel of Christ, abandons the authority of Scripture, jeopardizes the salvation of fellow human beings, and betrays the church in its God-appointed role as the bastion and bulwark of divine truth." In 1 Corinthians Paul addresses the issue of lawless spirituality. This is what he writes inspired by the Holy Spirit of God. "Do you not know that the wicked will not inherit the Kingdom of God? Do not be deceived: neither the sexually immoral nor idolaters nor adulterers nor male prostitutes nor homosexual offenders nor thieves nor the greedy nor drunkards nor slanderers nor swindlers will inherit the Kingdom of God (I Cor. 6:9-10). When Paul presents a list of vices he speaks of lifestyles, recurring behavior types, habits of mind and deeds. Paul is not speaking of single lapses followed by repentance, forgiveness, and better alertness against repetition, but ways of life in which some of his readers were establish, believing that for Christians there was no harm in them. Paul clearly warns that these habits are sinful and if not repented of and forsaken, will keep people out of God's kingdom of salvation. Undoubtedly lack of moral discernment lies at the heart of self-indulgence. Those who claim to be Christ's should avoid the practice of same-sex physical connection for heterosexual intercourse. Christians need to resist these urges, since acting them out cannot please God. In Romans 1:26 Paul spokes similarly about lesbian behavior.

The good news is that those who as lost sinners, cast themselves in genuine faith on Christ and so receive the Holy Spirit, as all Christians do find transformation of their lives. They gain cleansing of conscience, acceptance with God, and strength to resist and not act out the particular temptations they experience.

There are those who openly and

unrepentantly engage in homosexual acts. We are in no position to judge their individual consciences before God, but since God disapproves of their behavior it would seem that we have guidance on how to react. They are not to be accepted in fellowship as Christians, but treated as though unconverted. This does not mean that they are to be hated or reviled; Christians are to love all neighbors. The protection of God's flock may at times call for firmness, but a gentle and loving spirit is essential. Homosexual activity is not a special sin than the fornicator, adulterer, proud or avaricious.

Pederasty or intercourse with young boys or the more general pedophilia, sexual attraction towards young children cannot be within marriage, since they involve inducing children to participate in such wrong actions, they must come directly under the curse of Jesus. The use of animals for sex is forbidden in the Word of God (Exodus 22:19; Deuteronomy 27:21).

We are all sexually tempted, one way or another, yet we may all tread the path of chastity through the Spirit's enablement, and thereby please God. Tragic consequences follow the loss of fidelity to the family. The author of Hebrews taught that "marriage should be honored by all, and the marriage bed be kept pure, for God will judge the adulterer and all the sexually immoral" (13:4). The moral problem of adultery entails not only the penalty of physical act itself but the violation of freely stated vows and ridiculing the bonding between spouses that God instills. The heinousness of betraying faith with one's spouse is similar to the evil of God's people breaking faith with their Lord (Mal. 2:11-14). Hence the prophet Malachi exhorts, "So guard yourself in your spirit, and do not break faith with the wife of your youth. I hate divorce, says the Lord God of Israel" (vv.15-16).

No matter how attractively adultery may be portrayed in literature, movies, and television, it compromises the integrity of the persons involved, breaks moral commitments, degrades the significance of sexual relationships, and hurts all involved, especially the children.

Christians must decisively choose between mere recreational views of sex that reduce persons to mere recreational views of sex that reduce persons to objects as in lust-inducing pornography and an understanding of sex as a beautiful gift of God to be enjoyed in marital commitment for nurturing spouses in an enduring, intimate relationships. As God's gift, sexual intimacy expresses the spouses' agape love for each other and so symbolizes God's faithful agape for his people.

Marriage is not a sacrament that conveys grace, pointing to the greatness of God's steadfast love. For Christians the self-giving love of husbands and wives also portrays Christ's love for the church in giving himself up for her (Ephesians 5:25). Family has weathered the turmoil of disintegrating influences throughout history across diverse cultures to the present day. The institution of the family as a whole is

tough and resilient for God is its creator.

Daisy and David

The Transformation of a Family

Let the scenes of one woman's life as a child and then as a member of a family point us to the way Christ Jesus changes a life.

Scene 1 – Daisy as a Child

Daisy is a seven year old girl bubbling with life and enjoying the gala occasion of her friend Najma's birthday party. Around eight o'clock about twenty fine-looking parents entered the tastefully decorated living room to fetch their offspring. Daisy watched for her attractive mother, Taj. But suddenly the contrast hit her. The other children had two parents. Fathers cajoled and kissed their children as they left for home. Daisy wrapped her arms around her mother and sobbed.

"What happened my darling?" Taj enquired.

With salty tears trickling down her rosy cheeks, Daisy said, "I want my father". Daisy hungered for her father's bear hug, but it was not possible. Her father Mir Alam Khan had died when she was four years old.

Mir was a son of a rich Muslim chieftain who, when he encountered Christ, was thrown out of his home and deprived of his inheritance. A team of elders did try to induce him to return to the fold by offering again his share in the ancestral property if he would renounce his faith in Christ. A brilliant linguist and preacher, he brought many to know Christ, but now he was gone.

Scene 2 - Young Adult

Taj was medically trained and with this vocation and her strong faith in Christ, she provided a stable home for Daisy, who could then study to become a registered nurse.

Then came a significant meeting at the engagement of a friend of the family, Emmanuel, whose younger brother caught sight of Daisy. It was love at first sight for both of them. David caught a chance for a private conversation and quietly, with no shilly-shallying, proposed to her. "Will you marry me"? "Yes" was the spontaneous answer. What audacity. Arranged marriages were and still are the norm. The pact was not without its hurdles, though. Daisy was Roman Catholic and David Anglican Church. David had to give an undertaking that all the children will be members of the Roman Catholic Church. He consented readily.

In the freeing of India and the painful partition of the Punjab in 1947, Daisy and David chose India, and made a home in Firozpur where the family grew to seven with the addition of four sons and a daughter.

Daisy was a dedicated nurse much loved by patients, punctual in her duties and never dozed off while on night duty at the hospital. A godly woman, she kept a Bible under her pillow and read it every morning without much understanding. There was

no one to explain it to her. Church services were routine and nobody explained the Bible. Even so, Daisy took interest in the spiritual life of her children and saw to it that they went to Sunday school.

Then in 1965 Daisy started to feel dizzy and fall on the ground unconscious for a few seconds. Though she worked for the hospital and lived there, the best doctors could not diagnose her illness. Some doctors frightened her by saying, “Your days on earth are numbered.” The parish priest came home many a time to give her sacraments as if she needed last rites.

Scene 3 - Turning Point

January 1966 was a turning point for Daisy, David, and their family.

It all started when a retired railway worker, Brother Benjamin, wearing the saffron clothes of a sadhu and going about preaching the gospel, visited Firozpur and stayed with his acquaintance, the Hindu railway station master.

“Are there any Christian families in the town?” he asked. The station master directed him to David who was also working in the railways. Brother Benjamin came to the home and was offered Christmas cake and a cup of tea.

He asked David, “Where is your wife”?

“She is sick and lying in bed,” David replied.

“I want to pray for her,” Benjamin said.

David went to Daisy's bedside to ask, “A Christian sadhu has come and he says he wants to pray for you. Is that okay?”

Daisy’s answer was astonishing. “All these sadhus are hypocrites. Please do not bring him to my room.”

But the sadhu heard her refuse his prayer. He walked in uninvited and offered a prayer for her healing. After the prayer he asked, “Sister how do you feel now?”

“I feel light. The heaviness in my head has gone.” The sadhu asked Daisy to rise from the bed and walk, which she did. A miracle had taken place. The children were thrilled to see their mother’s healing, and the sadhu accepted the family's invitation to stay with them.

That was a transformation indeed. Next morning a beaming Daisy resumed her hospital duties, receiving a warm welcome while she narrated her story of healing. Some however warned, “Sister all this is psychological and your dizziness will return”. Thank God it never did.

Then God began to transform more lives – Daisy's children. The sadhu led morning and evening family with hymns and reading and meditation from the Bible, something very special but unbelievably fresh for the family who had never practiced family prayers.

More transformation was in store. After about two weeks of Bible study Daisy commented one evening, “The sadhu is rather ungrateful. He is staying in our home and yet he calls us sinners, and says we who must repent of our sins. “I go

to confess to the priest. I even do penance. My sins are forgiven. What is there to repent about?"

The evening meditation was the sinfulness of humankind. In particular the verse from the Bible, "For all have sinned and have fallen short of the glory of God (Romans 3:23)," had convinced the whole family. The following evening, with the whole family present, the sadhu invited all to confess their sins to accept Jesus Christ as their personal Savior and Lord. Each member of the family prayed in confession. But the youngest could not pray yet. He was silent. So the sadhu led him in a short prayer of confession.

That was a blessed day in the life of the family. Everyone without exception experienced the transforming power of God in their lives. Thus began a journey with the resurrected Lord Jesus Christ that Daisy continues till this day.

Before the sadhu left he baptized the whole family in the river Beas. Little did the family realize the implications of this step. The pastor told Daisy and David they were born again when baptized as a child. He argued that when they took the Holy Communion they had an encounter with Christ, but this couple believed they had not truly met Christ until that January 1966 prayer meeting, when their life took a U-turn.

The sadhu left, the family prayers continued, and the parents were now performing their own priestly, God-given duties, in their family, the first family in the city of Firozpur who had a charismatic experience.

Scene 4 - The Family and the Individual Grow in Strength

More transformation was to come. The prayer life of Daisy became an example for others. She spent hours on her knees praying and interceding for others. Neighbors saw the difference and some started attending the prayer meetings. Then Daisy and David started telling other families God's Word, and how God had transformed their lives. Great results followed. More people let God work in their lives. Some people found it strange that lay people would teach God's Word. Some muttered sarcastically a Hindi saying which translates as: "After eating nine hundred rats the cat is now going on a pilgrimage." More taunts followed, but David and Daisy were changed people. The sadhu could see that with delight when he returned for another two weeks.

Daisy discovered a new talent, singing for patients. The hymns of comfort and hope spread the love of Christ during her morning ward round in the hospital. Her presence made a difference in the life of patients. A Hindu doctor requested Daisy to come for weekly prayer meetings at his residence, and she led with enthusiasm, singing and sharing from the Word of God.

Daisy ventured out to the suburbs of the city to Basti Bhatiya Wali, a colony of poor laborers. She visited homes and shared from God's word. Soon regular weekly meetings started and families met together

in different homes. The believers started praying a whole night every month. Soon Daisy had a team of established Christian women who boldly told how God had transformed them, and they often found God confirmed this with signs and wonders.

Not even reading some books which told women not to teach or preach made her worry for long. She was convinced that God had called her and given her the gifts needed to preach the Word. What would happen when people she had led to Christ needed baptism, marriage or burial? David, who was working in the railways, was ordained by Doon Bible College in Dehradun. He could now perform the pastoral functions. The fellowship of believers organized themselves as Evangelical Church of God.

One father in this new church made a strange comment to David. “Ever since we have accepted Christ we have started receiving a pension. “What do you mean?” David asked.

“We have given up all our addictions and now we have money to meet our family's needs,” the man replied.

It was true. The families found many blessings from God. Some purchased second hand trucks and their business succeeded. The children started attending school. The women formed self-help groups and learnt sewing and stitching. The economic condition of families improved. It all started with the transforming power of God that continues to bear fruit till this day bringing blessings to many far and wide.

Scene 5 - Change on a Bigger Stage

David was a great facilitator of ministries. He invited Sister Alice Shevkenek to preach the Word of God in Punjab in the year 1972. He took one month leave from his work and organized public meetings for revival in the church under the banner Punjab Gospel Campaign in six different cities, himself paying the bills. The Gospel campaigns were conducted on three different occasions and addressed the biggest weakness in the churches of the area, nominalizm, being called Christian without knowing the true God or his power.

David and Daisy’s home remained open for a host of servants of God to come and stay. She loved to serve others. But Daisy was still the pillar of strength of her own family and a beacon of hope in difficult circumstances. The children watched the life of their parents, imitated their strengths and tried to avoid weaknesses.

Daisy had a saying, “We are living together here on earth, but we will also be together in heaven in the presence of God. The Christian family circle is never broken.” She looked forward to meeting her father whose sacrifices she heard her godly mother narrate. Now both Daisy and David are with the Lord, but the work God started through them has increased a hundred times. Their children call them blessed. I know them personally for I am their son.

Richard Howell

A Family in Mission

Lives Transformed in Kinnaur

It all started with a determined fifty year old woman heart patient, whose wild idea to move to Kinnaur was confirmed by a letter from a man who after that did not even seem to exist.

In 1990 Mrs. Shakuntala Matthews' doctors had advised open-heart Surgery as her heart valve had collapsed, making her so breathless she felt she was suffocating. Under treatment in All India Institute of Medical Science in Delhi, was also admitted for a time to Snowdon Shimla Hospital. In 1990 she went to a meeting of Bro D.G.S. Dhinakaran in Delhi and received healing of her heart condition. The attacks of breathlessness never bothered her again.

But a new idea had entered Shakuntla's thinking. She saw the whole family of Bro. Dhinakaran in ministry and she prayed to the Lord for her whole family as well to be involved in sharing God's word and witnessing for him. Joshua had prayed, "But as for me and my family we will serve the Lord" (Joshua 24:15). Mission is the task of the whole family, she felt.

In 1993 Shakuntala was a registered nurse working in the government hospital in Dharampur. Her husband Ranbir Matthew was working as Telephone supervisor in Central Research Institute, Kasauli. Shakuntala took every opportunity in her work to share the love of Christ and serve people, but when she found another nurse working with her was going to work in Rekong Peu, Kinnaur district, HP, she wondered if she should go too.

Ranbir, was serving the lord in Dharampur was hesitant. Rekong I in the mountains at four altitudes of 10,000 feet is very remote. How would a former heart patient walk the mountainous trail, which exhausts even healthy people? Even the bus ride from Shimla takes ten hours.

The Move to Rekong Peu

Obedience to the Holy Spirit prompting required a step of faith. The family prayed to the Lord for his guidance, and daughter-in-law Annushri Matthew asked God for a sign. In August during a Thursday prayer meeting someone brought a letter from a man called Rajinder Chauhan of Chauhan Niwas in Rekong Peu, asking for someone to preach the message of Jesus in Kinnaur as is in other parts of Himachal. The letter confirmed to the Matthews family the move to Rekong Peu. When they later reached Rekong Peu, they searched for Rajinder Chauhan, but found neither him nor any Chauhan Niwas there.

Mrs. Matthews joined duty from 5th September 1993, and her son Randeep with Annushri moved there in November after the birth of their son in September. The first opposition came from the Nirankari's who were busy in Kinnaur. They wanted Shakuntala and her family to become Nirankari's. Once Mrs. Matthew's broke her leg as she fell on the way home from work. The Nirankari saw Shakuntala limping and mocked, 'What has your God done he has broken your leg?" But the

Lord soon healed Mrs. Matthews's leg and she was able to walk normally. The family took every opportunity to witness the love of Christ. A plumber who came to work was also told gospel story.

Miracle in the Market Place

Mother's birthday is a reason enough to celebrate. On 23 December 1994 Randeep went to the market in Rekong Peu to buy a gift for her mother. As he walked pass a crowd he saw a young married woman about twenty years old, named Krishna from Poari village, rolling on the ground, surrounded by hundreds of curious observers and a witch doctor, groks and mali in the local Kinnauri dialect. The Spirit of God prompted Randeep to pray but he walked past the overwhelming scene. Then he felt more strongly a conviction he must pray, and felt the Holy Spirit say, "If you will not pray then the Lord will manifest himself through some body else and he will pray, but what about you?"

Randeep had no previous experience of praying for the sick or of exorcism, but he obeyed and returned. He offered a short prayer and to his amazement, and to the amazement of the crowd and the witchcraft doctor, Krishna was healed. She came to her senses, and rose to her feet. A miracle in the market place in front of a crowd of 200 demonstrated the power of the gospel like in the days of the Acts. I met Krishna on 24th September 1999 in her village and she firmly Believes Jesus Christ delivered her from demon possession and fainting spells. For a number of years she had experienced these about twice a day. After this healing, Randeep brought Krishna, her mother her aunty and younger brother to his home. Krishna was in fact going to the hospital for treatment. From the next day after Krishna's miracle, people started pouring into Shakuntla's house for prayer for their sick ones day after day. The Lord healed instantly and people went back rejoicing. The witch doctors charge huge sums of money from the sick people who come to them, but here was the Matthews family praying for the sick without charging a single paisa. Power encounter is a common phenomenon in Kinnaur where demon possessed people are reported from many villages.

At their first baptismal service in the Sutlej River in June 1995, about a hundred people took baptism.

The Opposition to the Work

When opposition grew, the Sunday meetings shifted to a jungle area near Shakuntla's residence. Communal forces working against the Christians charged the Matthews with fraud and inducement, but their accusations were groundless, as the police discovered when they investigated the movement of people to Jesus Christ. They found all the charges false and baseless. People who accepted Christ had done so of their own free will.

So then the Police gave protection to Christians for their Sunday meetings in the Jungle area. Next came a poster campaign against Christian work in

Kinnaur. It was wonderful to hear this year the testimony of a person who pasted up anti-Christian posters. He now worships the Lord he opposed. Hatred and opposition to Mrs. Shakuntala Matthew grew and on 10 June 1996 she was served with transfer orders with immediate effect. About the same time Ranbir retired to put his efforts into Christian work.

Shakuntala was transferred to a government hospital in another part of Himachal Pradesh but nothing can stop this brave woman from sharing the love of Christ that she has experienced. There too she told the gospel message, and two doctors accepted Jesus Christ as their personal Savior and took baptism. People thought Shakuntala's departure would end Christian work in Kinnaur, but Randeep Matthews stayed there. Financially supported by his parents, he carried on the work the Lord had begun.

Randeep Persecuted

Once a group of people asked Randeep to come to Poari village for prayer. As he reached the bridge over the Sutlej River, 20 people awaited for him. They tied his legs with rope and hanged him upside down in the river, pulling him up and down and threatening to drown him in the river. The Holy Spirit reminded Randeep of Isaiah 43:2 "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you pass through the rivers, they will not sweep over you." He told his persecutors, "Even if you throw me into the river, I will not drown". At this they pulled him out, beat him, and left him unconscious.

On another occasion a group of young people caught hold of Randeep and attacked him with a knife, gashing his hand near his thumb. In the May 1999 issue of a Hindi monthly paper, Matravandana, Rakesh Sharma charged Randeep with using fraud and inducement to win people for Christ. He remarked that Randeep's mother had been transferred but Randeep was still working in Kinnaur. Such false propaganda by communal forces continues to sow hatred and threaten Christian workers.

The Christians in Kinnaur have been stoned at times. They have gone through the fire of suffering and their faith is refined like pure gold. They face harassment by village heads who levy a fine on those who attend Christian worship services. This denies Christians their basic rights in the village.

When the mountain villagers sell Jungle fruit in the market, they usually distribute the income equally to all the village families. Last year they withheld this income from the Christian families. As a result, they filed a court case and won. This year they still received a lesser share among the village families just because they are Christians. For these Christians following Christ is costly 1 believe these believers face the principalities and powers, which the scripture speaks of, both demonic forces and the unjust powers in our world.

The people groups that have responded are the Chamang, Damang and Rajputs. Initially they sat together to worship and

share communion, showing to the world their oneness in Christ. But the new believers soon encountered the caste pressures from their families and friends. Many today stay home and worship Christ, because they find it too difficult to openly relate with new believers of other people groups.

The village council levied a fine to stop people from coming to the worship services. Some did stop coming. Didn't Jesus mention in the parable of the sower that the cares of this world would choke some seed, but some that fell on good soil would bear fruit?

My journey to the Church in Kinnaur was memorable. The scripture was so fresh, the book of Acts was relived, and the parables of Jesus were not just stories from the distant past. They were real. I was in the midst of believers who said, "It is good we suffered. It is indeed a privilege to suffer for Christ who loved us and gave himself for us".

The Holy Spirit inspired our Bible in the context of a suffering Church. That context is still here. The life and teachings of Christ, and above all his command to love and serve even the enemies of the gospel, are our example through the Holy Spirit. Here in Kinnaur a family demonstrated the love of Christ and the local Church continues to do so.

Chapter 3

The Church: A Transforming Multicultural Community[10]

The Church as a Transforming Multicultural Community

Undaunted by exploitative and oppressive Roman occupiers of Israel Jesus taught his small team of disciples, "You are the salt of the earth." (Matt. 5:13) and "You are the light of the world." (v. 14). These statements are part of Jesus' proclamation of the blessedness of the Kingdom of God, therefore are first of all an affirmation of the unique identity of the disciples which depends on the gracious activity of their heavenly Father.

The disciples of Jesus are creative catalysts for social transformation. They are the preserving and illuminating[11] elements in the world without which the earth cannot survive and remains in darkness. Their light thus becomes the hope of the world. The disciples are indispensable for the accomplishment of God's purpose in the world. Their mission is accomplished not only in word but in the deeds of their daily existence.

The Church is indeed the conscience of the culture it inhabits. An overriding commitment to a particular culture does not serve us well in situations of conflict. Christians have many times failed as agents of reconciliation in situations of strife. Churches that are to be 'the salt' of the culture are too often as insipid as everything around them. "If the salt has lost its saltiness, how can you season it?" asked Jesus rhetorically (Mark 9:50). The sense of tragedy hangs over the question. If the Christians make no effort to affect the culture around them, they are of little value to God. Since you cannot season it, tasteless salt "is no longer good for anything, but is thrown out and trampled under foot" (Matthew 5:13). The warning about being thrown should lead us to repentance from the captivity to our own culture which is accompanied so often with blind self-righteousness.

What then is the relation of churches to the cultures where they exist? We must develop an appropriate relation between leaving or distancing from and identification or uniting with the culture. The term leaving is used in the scriptures in the context of marriage, 'For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife…" (Genesis 2:24). Leaving and uniting are part of Christianity identity. In this article we use the terms leaving and identification to indicate our relationship to the culture we inhabit.

The word 'culture' did not become established until the Europe of the eighteenth century, and was not strong in India. (The Sanskrit dictionary gives an equivalent for cultivation, but not for culture, except perhaps the artificial compound *vidyanusevanum*, cultivation of science. A *visyanusevin* is a scholar, an erudite person, somebody engaged in learning, a pundit.)

The notion of culture is as wide as it is vague. It is the sum total of values and worldview by which a particular human group lives. Cultures are not static but always undergoing change. Pannikar writes, 'Each culture begins with, or at least develops, a vision of reality. The principle enlivening this vision is what we call religion. The meeting of culture when it goes deep enough is always a religious encounter. Ultimate values are at stake'. [12]

Christianity, Able to Exist in Many Cultures, is Transcultural. Christians believe the ground of their faith and conduct comes from outside any particular culture, so that you can be a genuine Christian as an Indian, an Eskimo or as an African. They believe in the same God, whose followers are equal and have equal access to that God, and to the blessings that God gives. Christians believe no one culture can claim to own the Christian God. This

God is outside of any one culture. At the same time, Christians believe in the validity of culture. They believe no religion, not Hinduism, not Islam, not Buddhism, and not Christianity, can or should attempt to obliterate the cultural differences, which lie at the core of identity, Asian, African, Russian, Ao, Koki, Thangkhul, Mizo, Tamil, Bihari, or Oriya.

Allegiance to God of All Cultures

The ultimate allegiance of Christians cannot be to any culture, country, or family with their local deities. The Christian belief in the oneness of God implies God's universality, and the universality implies transcendence with respect to any given culture. Christians can never be first of all Asians, Africans, Europeans, Americans, Australians and then Christians. At the very foundation of Christian identity lies an all encompassing change of loyalty, from a given culture with its gods to the God of all culture. The Churches proclamation of the gospel calls humanity to worship of the living God who is transcultural.

Reordering of Relationships

When disciples respond to God's call it necessitates reordering of an entire network of commitments. This is best illustrated in the call of Jesus to his first disciples, "Come, follow me," Jesus said, "and I will make you fishers of men." At once they left their nets and followed him. When he had gone a little farther, he saw James son of Zebedee and his brother John in a boat, preparing the nets. Without delay he called them, and they left their father Zebedee in the boat with the hired men and followed him. (Mark 1:16-19). As a result of response to the call of Jesus the fishermen left behind their "the nets" referring to economy and "the father" referring to family. There was indeed a whole new reordering of relationships. Leaving is part and parcel of Christian identity.

Christians should intentionally reject the seduction of the world and follow Christ in response to a call of God. Leaving and following Christ has a definite goal. For without goal leaving could result in ceaseless roaming. Far from being mere

spectators of life's drama from the balcony of a theatre, we are creative actors on stage. We choose wisely when we select goals in accord with God's revealed values and purposes, we choose to be salt and light of the culture we dwell in, for this is our best. No, the world says; no don't leave, it is better to stay with your family than to follow the call of the Lord to go forth. Stay within the network of your relationship, this is what the distracters would advice those who leave to follow Christ.

Should the fishermen have stayed within the network of their relationships? The call to fishermen does not stand for denial of relationships. The follower of Christ is not a lonely person, restlessly drifting about, for he is most radically bound to God through Christ who laid the foundations of a multi-ethnic community whose horizon is the whole world.

Can humankind be united without leaving cultural loyalties? Does belief in one God entail belief in the unity of the human race? In order to enjoy the full blessings of God does a person have to belong to a particular community?

The Crucified Christ

Paul in Galatians 3:1-4:11 states that the unity and equality of human family is dependent on the fact that God is one and he accepts every one by grace on the basis of the crucified and resurrected Christ and not on claims of race or caste. In Christ all the families of the earth in every age from every nation are blessed on equal terms as they share Abraham's blessings. Paul lays stress on the oneness that exists among all who have responded to Christ through faith. The foundation of Christian community is the cross. In Christ without regard to ethnicity, race, nationality gender, caste or class all those who believe in him are made one body. The crucified Christ creates unity by giving his own self.

Self-Giving the Foundation for Unity

The unity in Christ is the result of the fruit of the self-sacrifice of Christ which breaks down the enmity between people. As Paul writes, "For he himself is our peace, who has made the two one and has destroyed the barrier, the dividing wall of hostility." (Ephesians 2:14). The wall that divides is not so much cultural differences as enmity. Hence the solution cannot be the dictatorial imposition of a single will nor does the rule of a single law remove enmity. Hostility can be "put to death" only through self-giving. Peace is achieved "through the cross" and "by the blood" (2:13-17). The community created by the self-giving of Christ comprises of believers from various cultural backgrounds: Dalits and Brahmins, Black and White female and male, slave and free.

The Spirit Creates Unity

Although the Spirit does not erase bodily inscribed differences however the Spirit does challenges to leave or loosen our socially constructed roles which we ascribe on the basis of sexual or ethnic differences. For example the gifts of the

Spirit are given irrespective of the differences not only of gender and ethnicity but also of denominations. Can we restrict the gifts of the Spirit to certain denominations? The women teach and lead because the Spirit gives them gifts to speak and lead. The Spirit creates equality by disregarding differences when baptizing people into the body of Christ or imparting spiritual gifts. The members of the body are different but not for access to salvation and activity in the community.

Implications of Unity

The description of the community of Christ as united with internal differences has implications for understanding identities.

Each culture can retain its own cultural specifics. Christians need not lose their cultural identity as Indians or Africans and become one new humanity which is neither. At the same time, no culture can retain its own tribal deities. The Gospel deprives each culture of ultimacy in order to give them all legitimacy in the wider family of culture. Our ultimate allegiance must be given to God and Jesus Christ who transcend every culture; this enables us to rise above our culture. Leaving is no longer a spatial category; it can take place within the cultural space one inhabits. A person can be deeply, loyally both Indian and Christian. Being Christian is our way of living as loyal Indians in our culture.

Both Leaving and Identification are essential. Identification without distance destroys: If I affirm my exclusive identity as Indian and want either to shape everyone in my own image or eliminate them from world. But Leaving without identification isolates; I deny my identity as an Indian and draw back from my own culture. Leaving a culture must never degenerate into flight from that culture but must be away of living in a culture.

The Spirit Creates Openness

When the Spirit comes he creates openness in us to receive the other. Consider the transformation the Spirit brings when a person encounters Christ. Paul writes, “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation, the old has gone the new has come.” (2 Corinthians 5:17). The Holy Spirit breaks through the self-enclosed world we dwell in and sets us on journey with him and other members of the community of Christ. A transformed Christian identifies with a particular culture, yet because of the openness created by the Spirit of God he is enriched by other cultures while contributing to the dynamic vitality of each culture.

Judgment against Evil

The openness created by the Spirit by making a new creation implies judgment against evil in every culture. If we cannot thoughtfully discriminate between right and wrong, we become monsters. There are evil deeds that cannot be tolerated by any religion or culture. We must retain our ability to judge, judging ourselves and our own culture first. Those who seek to overcome evil must fight it first of all in themselves. Lausanne covenant has wisely stated, “Because man is God’s

creature, some of his culture is rich in beauty and goodness. Because he has fallen, all of it is tainted with sin and some of it is demonic. The Gospel does not presuppose the superiority of any culture to another, but evaluates all cultures according to its own criterion of truth and righteousness, and insists on moral absolutes in every culture."

The judgment must begin however "with the household of God." (1Peter 4:17) Those who wish to overcome evil must fight it first of all in their own selves and their own culture. Leaving open eyes to self-deception, injustice, and destructiveness, and enable us to fight against them. A transformed Christian is 'a person brought to repentance and shaped by the Gospel engaged in the transformation of the world.'[13]

The struggle against falsehood, injustice, and violence both in the self and the other is impossible without leaving. The fishermen who left everything to follow Christ had one foot planted in their own culture and the other in God's coming kingdom.

Our judgment of the self and the other should not be based on our own terms but in the light of God's new world – a world in which a great multitude "from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages" is gathered 'before the throne and before the Lamb" (Revelation 7:9, 5:9). Churches in mission must seek to transform and enrich all cultures for the glory of God thereby fulfilling their mandate to be the salt and light of the world.

Inter-Church Community

In the battle against evil, in particular against evil in one's own culture, the openness created by the Spirit needs inter-church community. The Church has taken roots globally in many cultures, changing them as well as being profoundly shaped by them. Nevertheless all the Churches in diverse cultures are one just as the triune God is one. No Church in a given culture must commit the sin of self-sufficiency thereby isolating itself. Every Church must be open to all other Churches. Every local church is indeed part of the global Church but the inverse is equally true that the global Church is also part of the local church. This makes every local church a truly global community of the Spirit. This is evident in the life of Christians who overcome national and ethnic rivalries as a result of transformation in Christ. This positions the Church as the multicultural community of the Spirit bound together by the power of the cross of Christ. The moral and social transformation shapes the Church as a transcultural community ordered toward purity of life and adoration of God.

Our commitment to the Lordship of Jesus Christ who is the Word of God must be supreme so that we hear, trust and obey him in life and death. Yet, least we drown the voice of Christ we need to see ourselves and our own understanding of God's kingdom with the eyes of Christians from other cultures.

We should not underestimate our ability to twist the Word of God to serve our own

communal ideologies and national strategies. The desire for our community survival and prosperity of our culture can easily overpowers us all and obscure our vision of God's new creation. Let me raise a rather important but difficult question, is democracy the only truly Christian political arrangement? If we are unaware that our culture has sabotaged our faith we will lose a platform from which to judge our own culture. In order to keep our allegiance to Jesus Christ pure we are duty bound to nurture commitment to multicultural community of Christian churches. Our commitment to the Lordship of Jesus Christ and our commitment to the ecumenical community of Christ must go together. You cannot have Christ and reject his global multicultural body.

There is a transformational stream of inter-church community flowing across the globe. The Holy Spirit is breaking down the walls of division built sometimes on enmity or untested assumptions. In Delhi from 15-17th November 2002 was held "An Ecumenical Celebration of Our Faith in Jesus Christ' jointly organized by the National Council of Churches in India, Evangelical Fellowship of India and the Catholic Bishops' Conference of India. This was an historic event in which Church leaders and Christians from around the nation, representing numerous traditions who perhaps never participated in an inter-church Christian fellowship before gathered because of their faith in Jesus Christ.

In order to jointly address the issues facing the Church in India an ecumenical body has been formed. National United Christian Forum comprising of Catholic Bishop' Conference of India, National Council of Churches in India and Evangelical Fellowship of India.

Even at the global level there is a move towards a Global Christian Forum which comprises of Evangelical, Pentecostal, Orthodox, Catholic, Ecumenical and others the aims of the forum are truly the basis of transforming relations.

Global Christian Forum aims to:

- "Create an open space wherein representatives from a broad range of Christian churches and inter-church organizations, which confess the triune God and Jesus Christ as perfect in His divinity and humanity, can gather to foster mutual respect, to explore and address together common challenges"

- Deepen our commitment to God's Word and mission in the world.

- Enhance our understanding of contemporary expressions of Christian mission.

- Pursue principles and practices that enable us to deal freely, responsibly and peaceably with our Christian differences and distinctive qualities.

- Engage in theological reflection in areas of mutual concern.

- Strengthen the wholeness of the church by encouraging communication and co-operation; and

- Foster relationships that may lead to common witness.

We need to take courage and hope from the new attitudes of love, care and mutual respect among Christians representing communions all over the nation and abroad. An opportunity to listen and feel inspired by the spiritual and vocational journeys of people we meet. We may encounter the potential for new priestly and prophetic vision and voice. We may find cooperation, participatory networks, ministries, projects, and issues that enhance our solidarity. Let our transformational dialogue give witness to our unity. Celebration of our faith in Jesus Christ invites us to a journey of faith and confidence, guided by the Spirit. It invites us to find courage to move out of familiar ground, to meet each other on new common ground, to let trust grow, and to act together to the glory of the One God, Father, Son and Holy Spirit.

The Church is a community of creative catalysts for transformational mission reflected in new modes of behavior and standards of multicultural community of Christ, and crafting of a new self modeled on Christ himself for transformation of the world.

The Ecumenical Movement and the Pentecostal Movement

Amid the strife of world history God's people is called on to offer a model of His Kingdom. The unity of God's people must not remain an empty slogan or an outward ritual. It calls for exposition and appropriation by the proclamation of the Church and in the life of the people. To the world it is not always clear whether or how the Church in worship representing their own destiny of unity in the Kingdom of God remains divided. Christian community's fragmentation is not understood by the world due to its own blindness, which is dazzled by the power of sin. In one way or another Church is entangled in the world's conflicts, and in order to maintain itself in these conflicts it has often obscured the mystery of God's kingdom by intolerance, striving for clerical dominion, inner controversies, lack of love, and finally divisions. By their own conduct, then Christians have contributed to the disasters that have taken place in the history of Christianity. In fact, however, the sign of the divine rule in life of the church is often distorted to the point of unrecognizability. May not there be, the, subjectively justifiable grounds to remain aloof from the Church?

However, God can cause good to come from evil (Gen. 50:20) and in this way to overcome evil with good, as Jesus commanded his disciples to do (Matt. 5:39) and as Paul formulated it as a rule of the Christian life (Romans 12:21).Hence there grow from historical disasters opportunities from new beginnings. This is

true in the Church's history as well. God's judgments on his church force renewal on it or bring it by detour to the state it was resisting. Thus divisions at times have opened the way to the thought of tolerance in the life of the Church. The divisions among the Christians in the Church can make light the difference between truth and error as happened in the secular culture and religious cultures of the world.

The Ecumenical movement in practical terms has predominantly been a twentieth century phenomena of Protestantism. It is essentially a spiritual mood or religious commitment rather than a clearly worked out theological position, and more over much of its impulse has always been pragmatic, the wasteful and scandalous rivalries and duplication of efforts in missionary work of the Churches. For example the In India the pioneer missionaries Bartholomaus Ziegenbalg and Heinrich Plutschau, were of German origin, Lutheran by confession and sponsored by pious Danish king and supported by society for promoting Christian knowledge (SPCK) which was an English organization.

The Christian world includes many evangelical and ecumenical bodies which remain quite outside the reach of World Council of Churches and form a kind of alternate ecumenical movement. On the other hand there are many encouraging signs as we saw concerning the global Christian forum that are bring together Christian churches together.

One of the major issues that needs to be addresses by the ecumenical bodies is their understanding of ecumenism. The term has acquired various nuances but a major weakness is the institutional understanding of ecumenism. This operates on the principal of exclusion. A person, evangelical or Pentecostal, if he is a member of the institutional Church defined as ecumenical is considered ecumenical. Is this the way forward?

The beginning of the Pentecostal movement was both liberating and ecumenical. Let us explore this further. Pentecostals, known for their unwavering commitment to faith and zeal for sharing their faith in Christ, are growing all over the world. At the same time Christians in the evangelical, ecumenical, orthodox and Catholics traditions have experienced and exercise the gifts of the Holy Spirit particularly those of speaking unknown tongues, prophesying, healing, and miracles. Pentecostals occupies 43% of Asian Christianity which in turn claims to have the mere 8.5% of the total Asian population of 3.7 billion in the mid-2000s.[14] Pentecostal movement of the Spirit is impacting the future of Christianity worldwide.

The celebrated leader of the Azusa Street mission was William Joseph Seymour, the son of an African American slave, who had minimal education. When Hollenweger identified that Pentecostalism has a black root,[15] it also included this deprived social status of early Pentecostals. The Israelites were also slaves in Egypt when God heard their came and came down to liberation them. The poor were at home in such an

environment especially in comparison with middle-class well-built and properly furnished mainline churches. Cox believes that such deprived, or socially dislocated have found Pentecostalism provide a socio-spiritual haven for their souls.[16] Another, and rather, more significant liberation which this movement generated was that the community of Christ was no longer spectators but participatory members socially ostracized without a voice in the community suddenly have found themselves to be at the center of their religious life, capable of confronting problems and dilemmas, making decisions, learning from experience. The contemporary cell movement system is not only participatory in nature but has also mobilized women for leadership which is considered anti-cultural and in many cases anti-ecclesiastical as well. Here is social empowerment

Historically, the Pentecostal movement in the Azusa Street mission in its height (1906-1909) powerfully demonstrated the unifying work of the Holy Spirit. First observed is the multi-racial composition of the congregation and the participants, while racial segregation was still a common practice even in the West Coast. William Seymour, son of an African American slave with little education, led the epoch-making revival and about half of his twelve elders were black. The inter-racial congregational life was so striking to the eyes of observers that the first report of the Los Angeles Express on April 18, 1906 was the "weird Babel of tongues" and the racial mix.[17] Charles Parham, a white Holiness preacher and once the Bible teacher of Seymour, visited his successful student in October 1906. But upon witnessing the complete inter-racial integration, his first verdict was extremely negative: "Men and women, whites and blacks, knelt together or fell across one another; frequently a white woman, perhaps of wealth and culture, could be seen thrown back."[18]

However, this is not the end of Pentecostal ecumenism. In 1936, David du Plessis, a South African Pentecostal, began his lone and yet powerful and inspiring work of ecumenism.[19] His conviction was that the foundational work of the Holy Spirit is to make the body of Christ one. He had an audience with the Pope, open doors of the World Council of Churches and unapologetically presented the reality of Pentecostal faith and urged the churches to receive this blessing, which would bring God's people together. This "Mr. Pentecost" did more to convince established churches and thus spread Pentecostal faith among them than anyone in his time, while he was disfellowshipped by his own Pentecostal denomination. Today several younger Pentecostals continue this critical tradition.

One of the most difficult challenges for the transformational mission of the Church is to leave behind competitive ways of thinking and behaving and to develop collaborative ways of thinking and behaving. The most powerful way for the churches to be a sign of the reign and reality of the Kingdom of God is through a quality of community life that concretely expresses

The Moravian Church as an Agent of Transformation, Elijah Gregan[20]

Moravians sacrifice for transformation. The Moravians have gone to the most difficult parts of the world. Jungles of Africa, Tanzania, South Africa, Alaska, and Jungles of Burma and have started from the scratch. They have picked up the toughest areas of the world and God has given them success. The passion was evangelism but the approach was holistic development of man with a gradual consequence to social transformation. The way Moravians worked was that they did not use their clergy but ordinary men and women with work as their vocation. And these men, using their vocation and practical experience in various fields became the extended hand of God to be the catalysts of transformation.

The beginning of the Moravian Church can be traced back in the History of the Indian Church to November 23, 1853 when two missionaries William Heyde and Eduard Pagell arrived in Calcutta (Kolkatta). The vision of these two Moravian missionaries from Germany was to reach out to the Tibetan Buddhists in Mongolia. They pursued their purpose to reach the Tibetan Buddhists in Mongolia through different options – from Russia to China to even through Darjeeling in India. But Russia being ruled by the Czars in those times had stringent rules about entry of foreigners into the country while the Chinese Government and the authorities did not seem quite comfortable and Darjeeling too was ruled out. Consequently, they resorted to go to Calcutta where they established a centre while navigating their way to Mongolia on the southern wing of a silk route.

With an unshakable commitment and burning passion, overcoming the obstacles on this pilgrimage they surrendered themselves to the move of God. They contacted their Headquarters at Herrnhud (Saxony, Eastern Germany), informing them about their inability to get the permissions to reach the Tibetan Buddhists (Mongolians) in Mongolia. In this state of dilemma, they expressed to respond to the need visible to them – Lahul Spiti, predominantly a Tibetan Buddhist region with some Hindus in the state of Himachal Pradesh in India. By the grace of the Lord, the work began in Lahul.

These Moravians – Heyde and Pagell were professionals, one was a blacksmith and the other was an agriculturist were professionals with strong linguistic abilities. Undertaking the accountability to be stewards of the Father's creation, they directly spoke to the situation of the Lahulies living in this region.

The situation with the people was that all the *Himachalis* in this mountainous region of Lahul, Almora, Garwhal etc. had to go down to the plains of Punjab and barter(exchange) their sheep wool, whatever they had in exchange for grains for their living. Most of the Lahaulies living in Himachal Pradesh were unable to cook everyday in their homes due to their permanency of debts as they were dependent on the Punjab traders for their grains. Moreover, in those times these

areas were princely states with Kings and rulers, thus debts was like a vicious circle hard to break. But the valley of Lahul had a climate almost similar to eastern Germany. The snow, slopes, soil condition, and weather everything was absolutely appropriate for potato cultivation. So, this Moravian brother - missionary cum agriculturist brought his farming experience to share with the *lahaulies* to introduce potato and vegetable cultivation to this region. And soon the people started growing potatoes here in large volumes. It grew so well that by selling these potatoes in Punjab in form of barter with grain, in no time they were able to pay-off their long standing debts. And today the *Himachli Aloo/Moravian potato* goes all the way to South Arabia. – Kuwait, Oman, Baharain and is considered a superior quality of potato in the country. Even Mc Donald's, the famous international food chain prefers to use this variety for their universally favorite French fries.

But the primary objective still remained evangelism. They got down straight away to learning a specialized and difficult language as Tibetan... During this time, there were joined by another person called Jaesche.

Jaesches was a linguist, who could read and write several languages. He used to write his dairy through the week in different languages. In Hebrew on Monday, in Greek on Tuesday, in English on Wednesday and in German on Thursday and so on in order to maintain his proficiency with all the languages over the week.

In 1853, as these three men got together going through the process of translation of the Bible into the local dialect i.e. Tibetan, largest literary corpus ever translated. Finally when all the sections of the bible were completed, they needed to be printed which was a rare phenomenon about 130-140 years ago in Lahul. The press was transported from all the way from the Germany to Lahul. It was carried all the way to Rothang across to 18000 ft to Lahul. It was quite a milestone in the History of Lahul when a century and half ago, the printing press was brought from Germany.

Kailang became the place where the transformation began through these Moravian brothers through evangelism, personal sharing, cultivation, technology and even, teaching people in various areas, including education. And the works spread into the main Tibetan highway that's the Kinnaur valley. Phou was the village on the Rampur Tibetan highway where the Phou station was established. Later, Paglle moved on to Phou while Heyde stayed in Kailang and another station was started at the Spiti as well in Khaza, Chini and other places. Hence the Moravians contributed the holistic development of these communities staying in these regions from connecting them to the outside world through the railway networks, training them to be self sufficient; equipping them with knowledge through education and the list goes on.

Are you wondering what kept these men

going? Their eyes of faith were still looking at the unreached Tibetan Buddhist areas of Ladakh and beyond Ladakh. Voluntarily choosing an inconvenient life where in summers they went to Ladakh and in winters returned to Kailang due to the refugee status granted to them by the Ruling authorities.

They progressively marched on as Soldiers of Jesus and in August 1885, the first centre was set up at Ladakh. The demographic composition of these new people (converts) accepting the Lord was very different in these places of Ladakh and Kailang.

In Kailang, there were mostly blacksmiths and artisans (artisans tribe – *kumaroo, loharoo* generally caste as lower caste) while in Ladakh, people of all cross sections of the society became Christians. Ladakh became an important place for several reasons. Firstly, the proximity to the central Asian train route improved tremendously, better established living standards of the people and overall development of the town.

Whether it was vegetable cultivation, meteorological record, scientific discoveries (first Tibetan typewriter), printing of the first newspaper in Jammu Kashmir state, translation of the Bible, introduction of education for women, it all happened in Ladakh. Ladakh had three remarkable developments - one of them was the establishment of the Leh centre in early 1887, a school for modern education and an allopathic dispensary. The allopathic dispensary in Ladakh was the only allopathic facility across the next 3000 miles across the channel. In earlier days the Leh centre was the only Church around 3000 kilometers radius which also exists today pastured by Elijah Gregan.

In Ladakh, one of the first early converts was Gregan. He was a Lama; his grandfather was a Lama teacher to the one of the highest lamas of the Tibet. He was a teacher to the missionaries. Gregan ad his son listened to the stories of the gospel sitting while these Moravians from Germany were learning the language. Gregan's son became a Christian at age of 12 years. He was a firm Christian and at about age of 16 or 17, he went for his former studies, English studies in Srinagar. There he learnt Urdu, English and other language. And as soon he got hold of these two languages (English and Urdu) other than his mother tongue Tibetan, he returned to Ladakh for translation of the Bible. He worked primarily along with the missionary called A H Francke. Francke gave the Hebrew, Greek base for the Tibetan. They worked over a stretch of 30-35 years and finally the Bible came out in 1948, which was after the dead of my Gregan Junior in August 1946. The work that had begun in 1853 finally got is completion as the Bible got printed in 1948. But it took almost a long stretch of 100 years. Even today the Bible is the largest literally corpus in Tibetan from of a foreign language.

The Moravians were Germans and hard core evangelists. But they were down to earth people. There was a severe division among the villagers (Indians) and the

rulers (whites) with off course the caste system very predominant in those times within the society which became a great barrier to Evangelism. So, when the Moravians (whites) went to preach to the local villagers there was an immediate resistance to foreigners (whites) by the people. But slowly and steadily the villagers became more receptive to the Moravians brothers from Germany as the cared for the people, identified with them, spoke their language but most of all responded to their pains and share in their sufferings.

Number wise Moravians remained small everywhere. Moravians followed a family based approach to church planting because they believed God's approach to evangelism is through the whole family. Moravians identified with the emotions and heart of the people of India. It was either accept Christ or reject Christ. Another thing that was distinctive about them was their radical and strict approach to life – emphasis on Holy living. Boys and girls were to sit separately in the Church. For Men and women, there were rules of living. If somebody committed a sin, he was excommunicated and debarred to participate in Holy Communion for several months and sometime years.

The Moravian Church, envisioned by God adopted the holistic approach of involving the community as an agent of transformation. They did not merely go and share the Gospel with the people but instead went along with the people to understand them, care for them and help them to overcome their situations of poverty, illiteracy etc. Pioneering to transform the thought and mind of the people through Kingdom values was the real key to the macro level transformation which was witnessed. Beginning with empowering a small to self sufficiency from debt situation through potato cultivation meant developing their thinking patters through awareness and education. The knowledge and information worked in these individuals' lives to first alter their values and life patterns which consequently modified the culture of the society. The culture of a community is the locus point of political structures and the economic systems which emerge in the community. Hence transformation needs to move from inside outward – from few to millions.

Rani Lal: A Brothel Transformed

I migrated to Canada in the early 1980's and went to study in a Bible College. It was just few months down the road when I fell seriously ill. I had developed a bladder malfunction which the doctors said was a major problem and that my bladder would never function again. I was horrified.

They hospitalized me and started treating me for MS. My suffering intensified when a C.T. Scan showed a tumor in my brain. The doctors therefore concluded that I did not have M.S but a Brain tumor. My world was falling apart at the age where I had a lot to live for. I was fighting for life because an operation might prove fatal or would leave me to remain a vegetable for the rest of my life. I chose not to have an operation and instead asked the doctor how long I

could live without an operation. The doctor replied that I was literally sitting on a time bomb, which could explode any time within the next two years. Thus in 1984 when I was just still a young adult, I had only until 1986 to live all the years of my life. The situation was indescribable. I was in and out of the hospital, had the worst seizures and was on very high sedation, and had to be catheterized. In the mornings I did not know if I would see the evening and in the evenings I did not know if I would see the morning.

In 1986, my condition grew steadily worse. Some people invited me to a healing service, but I did not wish to attend since nothing had happened so far. I even tried praying for death, which did not come and the chances for me to live were bleak.

It was during this traumatic period that one Sunday evening, as I lay on the couch flipping the channels on the television, I heard on one of the Christian channels a preacher saying these important words, "Today if you believe God will heal you...." What struck me was that even though many had prayed over me, deep in my heart I had already accepted the fact that the only end of this condition was death. So I prayed to Jesus and said, "Lord, I know what my condition is and this life is of no use to me. I have been asking for death, but you did not give it to me. However, today I ask you for Life and I promise to live only for you." Then I got up and decided to go to that healing service with faith that that day God would heal me. And indeed, to the Glory of God, He healed me and made me whole.

I found to my great joy that everything within me had changed. I no longer had a dead bladder and the neurologist could not trace any tumor despite the fact that he prescribed repeated tests. Now Life began on a brand new note for me. For a while, I went about testifying, encouraging people, visiting hospitals etc. However, as time passed, I was once again wrapped in the routine of life. I attended Bible College while supporting myself by becoming a financial consultant. This profession did not just remain a source of income, but it became my business vision for expanding. Soon I was a Regional Vice President in the company where I worked. Then I started my own business, expanded further from Ontario to British Columbia in Canada and thought it was good.

I felt it was enough if I gave time for the Church now and then, here and there. I would sometimes teach Sunday school, take sessions for the Youth group, be involved in Praise and Worship and do outreach to unbelievers - all of it within Canada. I never entertained the thought of serving God fulltime. I would neatly tell myself that I was too young for greater commitments. You see I was Indian, moreover a woman.

All along, however, the Lord kept reminding and prompting my spirit that I had promised to give my life to Him. I would tell the Lord, "Yes, yes I will serve you once I have retired financially in the next five years or so." Thus I gave God excuse after excuse. Then the Lord said, "I need you to go to India."

I said, “Lord, I will go for two months and give that time for missions.” Then the Lord clearly said that he did not want me to go on a holiday. He said, “I need you to leave everything and just go and I will tell you what to do.”

This appeared a tough decision to make. I wondered, “How in the world was I to leave my home, business, my mother who lived with me and everything and go to India?” How can I support myself in India if I have no business?” But the Lord again said, “Go”. Finally, I surrendered myself to God’s plan in 1996. Then in January1997, I took the bold step and came to India. I just did not know how I did it.

When I came to India, the Lord told me that he would tell me whom to meet and where to go. Then came a period of silence from God. I arrived in Mumbai, India. Now the only thing I knew I could do was fast and pray and to wait upon God for further guidance. When I took this step of coming to India, my friends back in Canada thought I was crazy.

One day, I received a telephone call from a friend of one of my employees back in Canada. The lady said, “We got to know from British Columbia that you are in Mumbai. My husband is quite ill. I was told you pray for people, so can you please pray for my husband?” When I went to pray for this man the Lord began His work through me for which He had sent me to India. Theirs was a Punjabi Sikh family. Through this lady, God opened doors to the household of Shri Dharmendra, a famous Indian Bollywood Cine actor and thereafter people began receiving Jesus in the industry. The word passed around in the area about my ministry and more and more doors opened in the Bollywood community and I began to witness for Jesus and win souls.

In 1997, we were at Dharmendra’s farmhouse at Lonavla. Once, during my morning meditation there God showed me a vision of an open space with a long structure and lots of trees around and a little further down I could see the sea.

At the breakfast table, I shared my vision with my friends. According to the size of the place I saw in the vision it did not seem to be Mumbai, which is a city so compact with buildings. Mr. Dharmendra said to me, “You just give us the details we will get it done for you.” But I told him that I had not heard from God that Dharamji was to prepare such a place for our ministry. Anyway, I blessed his thought and told him that I did not hear from God in this regard and soon the topic closed.

On 13th March 1998, The Lord instructed us to begin a ministry in Mumbai. The only instruction we received was to build a team of prayer warriors or intercessors. God even gave us a name for this ministry, PRAYER & CARE CENTRE.

After the opening of the Prayer & Care Center, the First call we received for prayer was from a lady suffering from chest pain. She was hospitalized so we left our contact number with her acquaintances. We earnestly prayed to the Lord for her to be healed. Generally, one

would expect a praise report in response to prayer, however, we got a call saying this lady had a cardiac arrest and was clinically dead. We were shocked. We once again pleaded before the Lord that this report is not for God's glory. We did not give up but continued to pray claiming that by Jesus' stripes this lady should be healed.

Having personally known the power of God in my life, I refused to quit in faith. To our immense joy soon we got another phone call from this lady's friend requesting us to continue praying for her since the doctor said that she has started breathing and is 40% out of danger. Our hopes rose. We could see that our prayers were at work. Then when she was 60% out of danger we were allowed to go to see her.

When we talked to the lady concerned, she testified of seeing Jesus. When she looked at Him puzzled as to what was happening to her, he said to her, "It is alright you can go back."

This lady began attending our Bible study with her nurse after she returned from hospital. At that time I was teaching from the book of Proverbs. This lady, whom we shall call Meena, came to me after the session and said, "I really thank God for using you all in my life. I own a particular place, which you can use to carry out the ministry work. Through your ministry many lives can be touched. I said "Sister Meena, we are just establishing the ministry. We are just a few members and moreover, we do not have the kind of money to run a big ministry at the moment. I did not even know her properly except that I had witnessed her miracle and now she was a part of the Bible study group.

Months later when I took a trip to Canada and returned, she came to me once again and said "Raniji, have you thought about that place I told you of?" I said no to her once again because it did not suit me financially. She kept on insisting that we take the place she had for ministry. And in 1999, she told me that I should pray about it. To be honest, at that time, I had no intention of getting a place and could not financially see myself making any such commitment so I frankly told her about it. But she only said, "Raniji, why don't you come and see the place once and then you can decide?" At last I agreed. I thought it was all right for me to go and see the place and went with her.

As we entered the gates of this place at Yari Road, Andheri West, Mumbai, I was shocked to see that this was the very place God had shown me in a vision in 1997. I asked her if there was a sea around here. She said, "Yes, just a few meters from here, there is the sea." I almost had tears in my eyes. If you think this is amazing, no, the best is yet to come.

Sister Meena then said, "Raniji, I want you to see this house on the inside too, there is so much you can do out here." Then she opened the door of one room. There I saw what I had never before seen in my life. There were girls who by every appearance were what you would call prostitutes or call

girls. I was baffled as I opened another door with more girls. The third door too opened to a similar scene. As we stepped out to my left, I saw statutes of many Hindu gods wearing garlands. I was in a maze at what I was seeing. We immediately went and sat in the car as I suppose sister Meena could detect the horror on my face, which was growing pale with shock.

Next came the revelation. She revealed to me that it was her own business. It was only after her illness that her manager was operating it. But now since Jesus has put a new meaning in her life, she wanted to give her place to Him as well. This place had a turnover of lakhs of rupees where they had many girls working out a living through this flesh trade. Now she wished to close down this business. She did not know how she would manage financially after closing this operation or where her income would come from. It had taken her years to build this - starting from many different locations. But this one was a hub of reputed men of the society who enjoyed their privacy here.

She said to me, "the only reason I kept asking you to take this place was so that we can work with many such girls and rescue them as this was a one Way Street where you can get in, but there is no turning back." I also learnt that this lady was a daring terror in India and even notorious men feared her stature. She had one side which was very good and the other the vice versa.

This was a place of bad reputation. A place well known for its activities with police officials, tourists and such like. Females from 10 or 11 years of age onward came into this trade either being sold, or chose to provide sustenance for their poor families in this trade. Some were misled into this profession on coming to Mumbai to become actresses etc. The reality is that mothers, aunts and fathers I met were pimps of their own girls. There were innocent girls born and brought up at such brothel homes. Many were addicted to the known vices of smoking and drinking. Others were afflicted with transmitted diseases, while yet others suffered from AIDS. There were women hating men for using them as rags, while some girls burnt their lust with other girls in sexual fantasies. Some had developed mental disorders and so on; I can go on describing the many pathetic and painful experiences of these women.

This question rose in my mind foremost: what must I do to help them? It is very easy to tell somebody that they need Jesus, must enter into a new life by salvation, and come to Church etc.

Here was a situation which required someone to go deep and remove the pain, someone who could love them just as they were, some one who could stand in the gap for many such, and intercede for them before God pleading for forgiveness, someone who was willing to share their purse with such as these. They needed someone who they could relate to, to confide in and be assured that if they hold this person's hand and walk along they won't be sorry. Was that not too much

required? I looked up to God and asked Him: "Lord, is this why you brought me to India to show me all this had I been still in Canada, I could have done something for them. Here I am only living on faith lines as you asked me to and this is a very big responsibility."

"This place paradoxically called, 'Love Nest' was a place of sin - a place of bad reputation. It was dirty - physically and spiritually. What is it that you expect me to do and how? A part of me wanted to just turn my face and say this was all just a bad dream. But, what about the vision three years ago, and what about this lady who was the first person we were called to pray for, could all this be a co-incidence?" I began to ponder deeply and prayed for answers.

The only answer I received from God was not an explanation to my question but simply the words: "Trust me!" That was His answer, nothing more, nothing less. The only thing we had and could use was faith and this sure was a leap of faith. The choice that we had was to obey or disobey.

Today, I thank God we chose to obey Him. Hallelujah! On November 23, 1999, we took over this place cleansed it physically and dedicated it to the Lord on December 24, 1999.

However, then began the warfare with the enemy. We can only say if God had not asked us to be here for His purpose there was nothing that would hold us back. The attacks on us got intense as work began from the place. It took a lot of fasting and praying. Every time we thought of starting a Church here, we would be attacked very badly. We were fighting the unseen, though we knew we were up against the enemy we constantly needed to keep reminding ourselves of His promises such as: "Greater is He that is in me, than he that is in this world." And again the scripture says: "Be still and know that I am God." Also as it is written in the Word, "the battle is mine but the victory is yours."

With much prayer we began our ministry in this place. We saw how the Lord was touching the lives of many and preparing us for the next step. We had to directly combat with the devil declaring that the Lord has desired to set not only the people, but also the land free from its clutches. This place was in every sense filthy, where sin was carried out, where other gods were called upon, and sacrifices made for more business to come in. A place where no decent person would want to give a second look. It was A HOUSE OF SIN called the Love Nest… Such a land, God desired to convert into a HOUSE OF PRAYER. Praises be to His Mighty Name.

We put bread and wine (the sacrament) on the four corners of this property to break the curse of this land and declared, Jehovah nissi, the Lord as our banner of victory. On 20 January 2001, we established a prayer house in this place. It started with a shed with curtains reminding us of the tabernacle and by His grace by 2002 we have been able to build a sanctuary to the Lord to preside in this

house forever more. We can only say today that we are grateful to God that He made us a part of His divine plan. God left us with one desire to serve Him i.e. to take His love to this lady and many such who need to see Jesus in us. This was the beginning of Miracles…

So much is happening now that one chapter would not suffice. It will take an entire book to share what God is doing here. While God is transforming lives of people from Bollywood, He is also transforming lives of prostitutes, pimps and brothel owners. We work among the "uttermost" and the "guttermost" for Him who so loved the world that He gave us His only Son.....

One of the most remarkable and life changing of testimonies is that of this lady whom we called Meena. The righteous seed of believers today financially supports this woman who gave this place to Jesus, since her life became a seed for many lives like hers. Today she is serving God fulltime in this ministry.

There are other testimonies of people such as these:

A female prostitute turned male by 11 operations and addicted to drinking and smoking is now totally set free and living for Jesus.

A prostitute born in a brothel home is rescued, married, and has a son. Because of this child whom we supported we started the SAVE A CHILD ministry for destitute children. Today we have over 45 such children.

A prostitute who avoided us so many times broke her spinal cord, could not move, sit or stand. Caring for her made the difference. We got her admitted in a hospital where she was treated for six months. She is now born-again and free from a life of sin.

A prostitute for many years with Parkinson's disease was rescued. She is not only totally free and born again, but is one of our intercessors.

A prostitute with full-blown Aids received Jesus and is growing very well in Him.

An 11 - year old girl sold into prostitution by her own mother was rescued. Jesus has saved many more such lives; many are on the way, yet many more are awaiting someone to rescue them.

We have seen God's transforming power at work in every project of ours, be it the ones mentioned, or with the lepers, the handicapped, or the unbelievers. We believe the blood of Jesus has the same power today as it did 2000 years ago. It just awaits someone obedient enough to use it in faith. Today not only in Mumbai, India, but also in Dubai and many other places of crime, RHEMA HOUSE stands as a testimony and a landmark of God's transforming power.

We have people from such a dark world come to visit Rhema House because they cannot imagine that a place of flesh trade for so many years has now become a house of prayer. Could we do it? No way! We have and always will give Jesus all the Glory, Honor and Praise. We thank Him for

giving us this humble privilege to be watchmen of His house. I just thank God for "He indeed loved us while we were yet sinners, He died for us."

Pedhuru Village Transformed

In a village called Pedhuru in Vizianagaram, Andhra Pradesh, Lakshman Rao seemed like just another typical simple man of the village, going about his work, cutting firewood from the jungle and selling it. Working hard to feed his family was his main priority. On the other hand, he was also involved with the Naxalites, a terrorist group known to create terror in places where they operate. Living a dangerous life was part of Lakshman Rao's life. Little did he know that one day he would lead his entire village away from its stagnant condition, physically, spiritually and socially to development and progress. All because of the impact of the radio program and the power of the gospel of the Lord Jesus Christ.

A devout Hindu, Lakshman Rao was fervent in doing all the rituals, worshipping his gods and being religious. But when he heard the gospel and gave his life to Jesus, he turned away from his old faith and turned fully towards Jesus. Despite opposition from people in his village, he refused to let go of his new-found faith in Christ and grew strong in the Lord. This angered the people who told him to leave the village if he continued to follow Christ. Lakshman Rao gladly left the village, walked across the other side of the road, built a small hut and started living there. Soon he was followed by another listener who became a believer and then they started a worship group. As they both began to go share the gospel, the Holy Spirit began to work in the hearts of people in the village they had left behind. In the process of time, almost the entire village of around 80 families, barring a few families left their old village and moved to the other side, where Lakshman Rao was staying. From '97 onwards, they are doing full-time ministry. The amazing aspect of this entire life-changing story is that, the Government established a school, a public health center and bore wells making it a model village, while the old village remains the same. People have built concrete houses and the village basically got a new look, not just spiritually but socially as well.

The people in the village then wanted a proper church to be constructed and one donor came forward to donate money. Today, the first thing that you see when you enter the village is the church. Once, the people were animists but the power of the Holy Spirit has brought the Telugu Soura village from darkness to light. The transformation of the Soura community is an evidence of God at work in this country. When we obey the Lord, He truly does wonders and manifests His power in and through us.

Towards the South of the Western Indian state of Gujarat lies a village called Rupwada, which has transformed greatly by the power of God. There are around seven hundred people here, belonging to the Gamit tribe. It was economically and socially backward, and was low on moral

values and ethics. Social evils were rampant and polygamy in marriages was common. In spite of the fact that the village is situated in a dry area (selling and consuming liquor is illegal) there were people who used to make and sell liquor and because of this most of them were addicted to alcohol. Another social evil was that the villagers were in the habit of stealing electricity from the overhead wires so they did not have to pay the bills. The other notable factor was that the people used to cultivate only once a year when the rains would come, as there were no irrigation facilities and hardly any wells. Thus the villagers were out of work for most part of the year and would drink and waste their time. This resulted in economic and social depravity.

This was the background of the people of Rupwada before the gospel came to them in May 1992, through the ministry of Vishwa Vani. At that time there were around eight people who listened to the TWR Gamit radio program, so the Vishwa Vani field workers started a Home Bible school with these listeners. More began to join the group encouraged by the teachings of the gospel. God began to work in the hearts of the villagers through this small group and now there are more than a hundred and fifty baptized believers! The significant transformation of this village, besides the spiritual, is the economic and social progress that has come about through the gospel and ministry here. The field workers taught them not just the word of God, but how to improve their quality of life in every sphere. As a result, the believers stopped drinking, stealing and living an immoral life. Agricultural work also improved as they dug wells, so they could cultivate twice a year. By this, they set an example to the non-Christians; and by the grace of God, there is a believer in almost every home in the village today. At present Home Bible School is conducted through the week, fasting prayer once a week and there is a regular Sunday worship service. The village has been transformed and set free by the Truth, freed from bondage and is creating an impact even in the surrounding villages.

West Godavari Village Transformed

Mr. Durga Rao is from a small village in West Godavari of the Southern Indian state of Andhra Pradesh. There are about 120 people in the village. But despite the small number of people it was famous for all the wrong reasons. It had a reputation of keeping the nearby villagers at bay, as the people were notorious for their practice of witchcraft and other demonic activities. This used to scare people and prevent them from entering their village. In the midst of the sinful and terrible situation of this village, it was by the grace of God that Durga Rao came to know about the Lord Jesus Christ.

Durga Rao belongs to the Koya tribal community. His parents were devoted worshippers of their traditional gods. He is the eldest of two sons. He was addicted to alcohol right from his childhood. Even though there was a school in their village no one dared to come and teach the children because of its reputation. Anyone

coming to the village to teach was ill-treated. Due to this reason they were all illiterates. They were deeply immersed in their culture and beliefs. The villagers were not only spiritually lost but were also economically and socially backward.

One day Durga Rao fell very ill and it was believed by the villagers that one of the spirits of the gods entered his body. His father performed many pujas (prayers) to the gods for his recovery but they were all in vain. His condition worsened and he was bedridden for about 6 months.

During this time, a Christian teacher came to their village with much courage to teach in their school. Her name was Kumari. Durga Rao's house was besides this school, so when she came to know of his illness she visited his home. She shared the gospel and told them that Jesus Christ alone had the power to heal Durga Rao. She gave them a radio and encouraged them to listen to the TWR program.

As Durga Rao listened he believed in the messages and was healed from his sickness. But as time went by he forgot about God as he was not discipled in the faith and went back to his old ways of living. He got married and was blessed with two children. During this time, his father passed away.

Then one day Durga Rao fell very ill again. At that time he remembered the TWR program that he had heard and the God who healed him. He tuned in to the radio and listened to the word of God in his own language - Koya. He came to realize that Jesus Christ was his savior. He looked at Jesus and was healed physically and spiritually. The gospel through Radio worked powerfully as a change agent in Durga Rao's life.

He and his wife slowly began to influence the entire village with their newfound faith. He also changed his name to Tellam Yonah (John). Later on his brother Chandra Rao accepted Jesus Christ and also changed his name to Tellam Ezekiel. As their lives changed, people saw this change and were in turn touched by the love of God. The brothers began to preach the gospel and as people started to come to the Lord, they started a worship group in the village. This set in motion a process of transformation in the entire village, which is also now economically and socially progressive. This change is so visible that there is no ancestral worship anymore and the standard of living has greatly improved. The school now has teachers and their old practices no longer exist. Today it is a model village for other villages around the place.

At present, the Vishwa Vani field workers are working with them and giving them pastoral and spiritual guidance.

The Dalits and the Church, Samuel Jayakumar[21]

This case deals with the role of the church/gospel in empowering the poor and the oppressed communities of modern India. Secondly it deals with issues relating to caste discrimination among the Christians. Also, it explores the issue of

justice and equality. In this paper we have adopted a historical case study approach to deal with these crucial issues.

The Church/Gospel Empowers the Dalits.

A recent historical study relating to South India makes it clear that, the 19th century missionary contribution to vernacular literacy, training of native leaders, education and health care brought a substantial transformation among the Dalits.[22]

The aim of Christian mission then is not to civilize aboriginals in the sense of imposing on them a Western way of life or any other way of life that is alien to them. It is rather to draw out the distinctive qualities within them and help these to grow and flower.[23]

The missionaries served the people with the confidence that, "if they preach to them, Christ and Him only, in all His fullness of power and love, some measure of success will follow"

During the 19th century in some parts of South India the missionary approach to the caste system, village community life and native religion was quite different from colonial strategies and methodology. While the latter was interested in a political solution on the basis of pre-British Brahminical patterns, the former was to provide a Christian answer on the basis of conversion to Christ. Although the missionaries shared the indigenous and colonial view of Indian society as characterized by *kaliyugam,* a culture of despotism and decline, unlike the Raj they did not attempt to retain the so called *sanatan,* 'abiding', primordial civilization.[24] Instead they attempted to transform it into a visible *koinonia*, a Christian community. The first missionaries to South India were, for the most part, committed to their transformational approach because they had a reason for it.[25]

The first generation Dalit Christians of South India confessed that, "Christianity has brought us fellowship and brotherhood. It has treated us with respect, and it has given us self-respect. It has never despised us because of our lowly origin, but on the contrary has held us as individuals who are valuable before God and man as any man of any origin."[26] Mission as transformation involved community building. It is the total commitment to the social community, to build communities, to build and bring change."[27]

The Victorian missionaries gave special attention to building up strong church communities in the mission field. As a result, during the 19th century in South India, in the areas of missionary work, with the help of the local missionary each of the outcaste villages had its own corporate church life with independent activities: village schools, morning and evening prayer in each village, Bible study and classes for catechumens.[28] The village congregation was a kind of *koinonia,* fellowship of believers devoted to Scripture and worship. It was community-living based in Biblical principles of equality, liberty and fraternity for the all-round

advancement of the poor believers.[29]

Building up church communities would solve much of the caste problems and promote harmony and peace between castes.

Proclamation, an agent of transformation and empowerment: The missionaries served the people with the confidence that, "if they preach to them, Christ and Him only, in all His fullness of power and love, some measure of success will follow."[30] The result of preaching in the common language was that thousands of poor and oppressed who were ostracized as outcaste used the opportunity to listen to the Gospel, and not only become Christians but to become a people of a new society comprised of small Christian communities.[31]

Foremost of all, preaching and the formation of Christian congregations among the Dalits contributed to the emergence of a new alternative Christian society a kind of community between new Christians and the established power structure. In many ways it was a society counter to the then existing violent Brahminical Hindu social order. The outcaste communities who were once considered by society as polluted and fit for nothing, made effective use of the Biblical images such as 'New Creation' and 'Sons of God' given by the missionaries to increase their self- worth and dignity which had been denied to them for centuries.[32]

Some of the 19th century missionaries who worked in India among the poor and marginalized people did regard themselves as agents of new creation or agents of social change; and changes were seen in the lives and situation of their converts.'[33] For Forrester, the missionaries were 'political radicals' and 'social revolutionaries' who sought social and political revolution without being in the least mindful of the consequences.'[34]

In fact they were committed to social transformation of society through conversion of people to Christ. They worked with the hope that if persons accepted Christ, they would he better people and their society would progress. As Bishop Neill contended, the missionaries gave themselves to the preaching of the Gospel, in the confidence that 'the moral transformation wrought by the Gospel would in time solve economic and social problems'.[35]

The need then of Dalits was not a false hope or even a positive feeling, but faith and confidence in a tangible personal God, the Savior who removes guilt, both real and false, such as karma. Proclamation of the Gospel provided the poor and the oppressed with a general confidence that life is meaningful and that it was possible to change one's quality of life by one's efforts. Bishop Picket came up with a similar conclusion after undertaking a thorough study of Dalit conversion movements.

The depressed classes in India are desperately poor. But their chief economic need is not financial; it is an antidote to the

poisonous ideas that have made them incapable of struggling successfully with their environment. As severe as is the physical oppression to which they are continuously subjected, the depressed classes could not have been reduced by its operation alone to the low state in which they have lived for centuries. Much more devastating than physical oppression has been the psychological oppression inflicted by the Hindu doctrines of karma and rebirth, which have taught them that they are a degraded, worthless people suffering just retribution for sins committed in earlier lives. It is then, a true instinct that makes the depressed classes respond more eagerly to the preaching of the Christian Gospel than to any direct ministry to their social and economic ills. The concepts that the Christian Gospel gives them of themselves and of God in relation to their sufferings and sins are worth incomparably more to them than any direct social or economic service the Church could offer.[36]

The experiences of Indian leaders, who are involved in community development among the poor, concur with this view. V. Mangalwadi wrote,

"Perhaps the most devastating effect of the centuries of poverty and oppression is total loss of self- respect, self- confidence, trust in others and hope for any change. ... Poverty is not their main problem. The lack of hope (for a better future), lack of faith (in man, government or God) and lack of initiative (born out of dehumanizing oppression and loss of self-confidence) are paralyzing mental/cultural factors which prevent them from any action towards freedom and development."[37]

Samuel Escobar, an evangelical missiologist in Latin America, writes of similar experience of the effect of evangelical preaching. He wrote. "Evangelicals are accustomed to seeing the preaching of the Gospel produce radical and visible changes in the life of the persons here and now."[38]

Christian/western education leads to equal opportunity and actualization of social justice: Recent studies on mission history have proved that the introduction of vernacular literacy and western education transformed the minds of the natives. The state of universal ignorance and illiteracy was removed among those people groups who became followers of Christ. Female education brought dignity and identity to future wives and mothers.[39]

Education brought the intended inner transformation in the lives of the Dalits. For example, a girl who had been educated in a boarding school had a remarkable influence in her home village. Very often she was the only person in the place who could read, write and sew. She was able to perform many acts of kindness for her village people.'[40] The missionaries and the natives themselves witnessed the transformation wrought by the schools. Margoschis noted,

"On going to a strange village, not visited before, I have often been able to detect at once a girl who has been educated in the boarding school, for her manner,

language, and general appearance is so utterly different to that of the other girls in the same village."[41]

Similarly, Indian leaders such as Bishop Azariah experienced the importance of Christian education for the transformation of Dalit communities. Azariah maintained that rural uplift and awakening of outcaste villagers was affected through Christian education. He wrote,

"Through Christianity too illiteracy is being chased out of rural India. It was well known that the first thing done for a village which desires to join the Christian Church is to send a resident teacher there to instruct the village in the Christian Faith and open a school for their children. The teacher and his wife - if he has one - are truly the introducers of Light and Learning."[42]

He often asserted that 'to teach, teach, teach' -is one of the needs of the hour.[43] According to Azariah the education of a single girl means the uplifting of the whole family. He rightly understood that in India among the poor and the oppressed the success of the male education depended on women's education. Azariah encouraged the education of girls and women. He made elaborate arrangements to promote adult literacy and education among the illiterate women.[44]

The purpose of education among the outcaste Christians of Dornkal was to empower as well as enlighten the Dalit converts so that they might be restored to personal awareness. Moreover, he wanted the education given to them to prepare them for life, believing that thus trained; Dalit Christians would become centers of light wherever they were.

Christian education greatly awakened the Dalits' consciousness of the injustice and deceit caused by the caste Hindus. Azariah's co-workers reported that the young adults who learnt to read and write, generally at night schools in due course began to question their Hindu masters about their 'debts' and became aware in many cases of how they had been deceived.[45] Azariah observed that Dalit Christians "on account of integrity, command higher field wages; that Christian laborers are in demand for transplantation and harvesting because they do not require close supervision."

Azariah understood education as something that belongs to the Judaeo-Christian tradition. Furthermore, Azariah's concept of education was very much value based. It was offered as an instrument to correct, to direct, to change and to transform the lives of the Dalits. Education offered by the mission was useful to them in their day to day living. It prepared them to take up jobs and earn their livelihood. It provided them with strong self-awareness which in turn established their sense of individuality. It assisted them to be careful with their wages and to maintain their health and hygiene.[46]

For the most part missionary education gave the Dalits access to new knowledge and fresh information by providing a wider perspective to think beyond the

boundaries of their caste and village loyalties, and to become ambitious and adventurous in their lives. Hence, a large number of Dalits migrated to Ceylon, Malaysia and Burma to seek better fortunes. Thus, mission education introduced the Dalits to a wider world - beyond the Brahmins. It gave them access to new information and power - especially in the areas of Western scientific knowledge which was becoming increasingly important. In the new order of western related knowledge, the missionaries were giving the Dalits an important advantage - at least positioning them alongside the Brahmins if not ahead of them. It opened up new boundaries, horizons and opportunities.

Those who were educated by the missionaries became teachers, Church workers, government clerks, businessmen and some even became policemen.[47] How else did people who were told they could only be sweepers get the motivation and notion that they could do something different? The fact that they went in the new professions as a result is critically important.

Christian higher education prepared the nation for self-rule. As Kumaradhas has pointed out, in South India the education that the missionaries provided actually promoted the elements of political consciousness. At the turn of the century, the emancipated Dalits, in particular, along with the Christians of upper-caste background, provided leadership to the Christian community in general in the matter of the emerging national politics.[48]

Conversion leads to brotherhood (and minimizes caste discrimination) which results in common witness to the world: From what we have seen, the 19th century missionaries who worked among the various Dalit and subaltern communities believed in the direct relation between conversion to Christ, new identity and awareness, and social transformation.[49]

Bishop V. S. Azariah, (a leader within one generation of the early missionaries) understood mission as a common witness. It is not just a witness of the single individual, but a witness of the whole church. He reported from his missionary experience that the outcaste believers were a witness to the upper-caste non-Christians outside the church. He wrote,

"...the inner change a change of heart in either the oppressor or the oppressed could alone permanently change the vicious circle in which the rural life is moved. In some areas testimony has come ...that the non-Christian zamindar, landlords, became friends ... and Christians are treated with respect by the caste people who once despised them as untouchables."[50]

Consequently on many occasions upper-castes could witness to the new spiritual joy, hope and the character exhibited by the Dalit Christians. They could sense the change wrought by their conversion to Christ. Even the upper-castes wanted to experience the same change in their lives. Thus the Dalits commended the Gospel to their oppressors.

They have seen what new spiritual joy and hope and what new strength of character Christianity has brought to their less fortunate neighbors, and they believe that they have found a way of deliverance for themselves from the ignorance and fears and superstitions that have kept them in chains so long.[51]

As the years passed both castes and outcastes together made appeal for conversion. Azariah noted,

"The outstanding event in December was the baptism at Nidhanapuram. Six communities provided the converts of whom four were from various caste sections. Altogether 220 were baptized that day - less than half only of the usual panchama classes."[52]

After that, castes and outcastes freely intermingled in Christian worship. Azariah acknowledged that his strategy created an impact among the outcaste Christians by quoting the confession made by the local believers.

"Formerly the caste people shouted at us to get out of the way, not to go too near them; all that is gone now. Formerly they used to deride our religion, calling it mala-religion and madiga-religion, now they have no hesitation in coming to our church, in sitting down side by side with us, to our Lord Jesus, making no difference..."[53]

The above affirmation of the poor believers reveals the observable change ushered in by Christian mission among the people of both low and high caste background. The chief cause of this change in attitude by the high caste people was due to the impression made upon them by the remarkable change in the lives of their outcaste neighbors as a result of their conversion to Christ.

Consequently, the kind of peace, harmony and brotherhood that was emerging among the natives who had so far been divided by caste is worthy of consideration. The passing of untouchability and unsociability was something that happened due to real change in the mental disposition of the people. When the Dalit Christians began to live a dignified life the caste Hindus, as well as caste Christians began to change their opinions and attitudes towards the Dalits.[54] Thus a transformed life-style becomes a witness to others.

Conclusion

The 21st century ushers in new challenges for mission practitioners for ministry among the Dalits and subaltern communities. The prospects of Christian mission among Indian poor and oppressed classes are not very clear, but the methods of mission are not going to be altogether different because the Gospel of Christ remains the same. The proclamation of the gospel must continue unhindered combined with engaging in socio-economic and political liberation of the Dalits and subaltern communities.

Chapter 4

The Kingdom of God and Transformation

Jesus Christ is Lord and King

Personal encounter with living Christ transforms life and incorporates the believer into the body of Christ, the Church. The church was born at Pentecost as a community made up of Spirit-filled individuals. The biblical concept of individual-in-community is the basic unit of personal existence. At Pentecost Christ became a dynamic contemporary reality never again to be absent from his disciples. The early church publicly confessed Jesus is Lord. The church is called to invite people to acknowledge the Lordship of Christ personally and not privately. This requires accepting the Lordship of Christ over total life, personal as well as social. The Lordship of Christ relates personal conversion and social responsibility.

Jesus identified his mission, ministry, and message with the inauguration of the Kingdom of God; the time of God's messianic salvation (Mark 1:15). In the teachings of Jesus, it is clear that he proclaimed that the kingdom is both a future event (Matt. 13:36-43; 47-50), and a present reality (Luke 11:20; 12:32). Hence Jesus preached the Kingdom of God neither solely as a present reality nor exclusively as a future event. He was aware that the future rule of God was present in his actions and in his person.

Jesus demonstrated the outer effects of His Kingdom's power. He won victory over Satan in temptations (Matt. 4:1-11). He drove out evil spirits (Matt. 12:28). The miraculous signs Jesus did to deliver people from illness and death, the proclamation of good news which resulted in fruitfulness (Matt 13:1-2) were all illustrations of the powers of the kingdom at work in the world. After his triumphant resurrection, Jesus spoke of the kingdom (Acts 1:3) and told his disciples of their Pentecostal endowment with power to become his witnesses, to the ends of the earth (vv. 6-8).

The kingdom is utterly transcendent and supernatural; it comes from above, from God alone. It is God's gift and cannot be built by people. When God's kingdom comes, the hungry are filled and the sad are comforted (c.f. Beatitudes, Matthew 5:3-10, Luke 6; 20ff). It demands that men should love their enemies (Matthew 5:38-42, Luke 6:27f, 32-36), and they will be free from care as the birds of the air and the lilies of the field (Matthew 6:25-33; Luke 12:22-31). Here again it is Jesus himself, in whom alone the future kingdom is present, in whose words and deeds that kingdom has already appeared. It has come already, in that Jesus seeks out the company of tax-collectors and sinners, offering them fellowship at table and so promising them forgiveness of their sins. As the king invites to his feast the beggars and homeless (Matthew 22:1-10), as the father's love receives back again the

prodigal son (Luke 15:11-32), as the shepherd goes out after the lost sheep (Luke 15:4-7), as the woman searches for the lost coin (Luke 15:8-10), as the master out of the goodness of his heart pays the laborers hired at the last hour the full day's pay. (Matthew 20:1-15), so Jesus goes to the poor to give them the promise of forgiveness, "for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (Matthew 5:3). Only sinners, who know what it is like to have a great burden of –guilt (Luke 7:41-43), can appreciate the remission of sins through the goodness of God. For "those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick" (Mark 2:17; c.f. Matthew 9:12, Luke 5:31). Jesus made kingdom inseparable from his own person. Hence the concern for the Kingdom of God and for transformational mission is basically a Christological concern. Pentecost narratives in the book of Acts are integrally connected to the Kingdom of God and mission of Jesus. The fullness of the Holy Spirit and the hope in the return of Jesus Christ were the empowering realities that equipped and shaped early church's mission and indeed the contemporary church in mission movements.

The early church followed the example of Jesus by proclaiming the good news of God's redemptive reign in Christ. Signs, wonders, miracles of deliverance were performed acts of compassion were practiced in response to human need. The local churches in the New Testament were made up of men and women who had experienced transformation wherein the racial and cultural barriers within the community of faith were overcome in a demonstration of the reconciling power of God's reign. In the same way the community of the Spirit-filled believers in every age and in every nation can expect to proclaim and demonstrate the transforming power of gospel to the peoples of the world.

The Kingdom of God is also the kingdom of Christ. Psalm 103: 19 states, "The Lord has established his throne in the heavens, and His Kingdom rules over all". God's rulership extends to everything, both in heaven and earth. The Psalmist summons to all Yahweh's creatures and subjects to praise him as King and Lord. In the New Testament both expressions are found together, sometimes God being named first, and sometimes Christ. Thus it is equally acceptable to speak of "the kingdom of Christ and of God" (Ephesians 5:5). Paul frequently in the context of non-Jewish cultures refers to Jesus as lord which is an equivalent in connotation to those among Jews as King. The rule of Christ and the rule of God are in other word identical. There is no tension between "the power and the kingdom of our God and the authority of his Christ" (Revelation 12:10). The Kingdom of God means primarily the rule of God, the divine kingly authority.

God's redemptive rule is not exclusively spiritual. The mystical emphasis makes the individual withdraw from the world – without attending to one's neighbor. The Hindu mysticism makes God's work in the world independent of matter and body. The saying of Christ is often quoted out of context by such advocates, "the Kingdom

of God is within you," (Luke 17:21). The editors of The New Age Journal write, "Each of the major mystical systems has its own way of expressing this [pantheistic] idea. The Hindu Vedantists say that the Atman, or immanent eternal Self, is one with Brahman. Christians might say, 'the Kingdom of God is within you.' Buddhists sometimes say, 'You are Buddha.'"

The statement of Jesus does not limit the kingdom to the heart nor teach that all are divine. Rather it affirms that God's rule had come near and was in the midst of his people. Jesus made a radical distinction between the father above and all else beneath, and for entry into God's kingdom he requires regeneration.

The Kingdom of God produces tangible results in the physical world. The primary biblical contrast is not between the material and the spiritual, but between two inner inclinations towards good and evil. People created in the image of God express themselves for good and evil through their bodies in all kind of relationships in the family and in society. Physical acts are not unreal or indifferent but express one's ultimate loyalties either to the kingdom of light or the kingdom of darkness. The evil tree brings forth evil fruit. The good tree bears good fruit in relationships with others in their families and churches, their places of employment, and their nations.

There is nothing, whether spiritual or material, outside the Kingdom of God. God's kingdom was meant to rule not only over the Christian family, the church but over economics, education, science, the media, entertainment, government, and so on. God commanded Adam and Eve to subdue the earth and 'rule over…every living creature that moves on ground" (Gen. 1:28). The context of the chapter implies the command explicitly to managing plants, fish, birds, and land animals. This mandate provides a basis for people to serve as God's stewards in areas of ecology, agriculture, and animal husbandry. God's activity inside the church is not separable from his activity outside; any separation would tend to make church activity irrelevant to the needs God would have his people address in the world. This connection of God's activity in the church and the world is indeed very powerful. For example, for the Christian community to be involved in the liberation of the poor and the marginalized it is an imperative that we understand the connection between their day to day living conditions, their history which will help to understand what has contributed to their present condition and the work God wants to do in their world. This gives legitimacy to religious dimension of activism. When this is overlooked, one loses a comprehension of the profound relationship between daily life and the sacred understanding of that life. The power of that connection and the power of faith working in our lives empower the community to reflect on issues and take appropriate action. God's concern is that all enter His Kingdom. The powers to be expressed in the future eschatological kingdom entered into history in the person and work of Jesus in order to work toward

its realization.

Kingdom Utopias

The utopian visions seem to suggest that the Kingdom of God in all its fullness can be built on earth. This is not possible since the scripture informs us of the reality and pervasiveness of both personal and societal sin. (Isa. 1:10-26; Amos 2:6-8; Mic. 2:1-10, Rom. 1:28-32). Union of World Religions

The union of world religions with a global government should not be identified with the Kingdom of God. Transcendental Meditation propagated by pantheistic movements encourages mediators to surround government offices. The effect of the vibrations of their mantras would solve the world's social, political, and ecological problems. Their meditative vibrations have admittedly not made a noticeable difference.

No mixing of world religions and economic powers will bring a lasting and just peace to the globe. The lord Jesus said, "My kingdom is not of this world" (John 18:36). God's kingdom in the present age is no more to be identified with a union of nations than with a single political party or church.

One World Government

Mark Satin's New Age Politics[55] considers peace possible only if we break out of the "prison" of nationalism. Among larger nations, nationalism encourages chauvinism, he thinks, and among smaller nations, feelings of inferiority. So the nation-state system inevitably leads to war. Satin's prescription for the illness of nationalism is a planetary consciousness of the oneness and interdependence of all life. He advocates complete military disarmament and a decentralization of each nation. Further more, all individuals should give up their national citizenships and become world citizens. Classless Society

Karl Marx's dream of a global government of the people proved unrealistic. Peace, Marx thought, could be attained only in an economically classless society when the last vestiges of capitalism had been eradicated from earth. History painfully showed, however, that the dictatorship itself was affected by depravity. The "temporary dictatorship did not foster liberty so people overthrew the communist dictatorships of Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union in 1989 and 1990.

Engagement in Society

A faith that has withdrawn from central areas of modern society will not be taken seriously, and what ever is left of Christianity in public can either be manipulated or mocked. The temptation is to withdraw from public life and to restrict religion to the private sphere. Christians avoid the first error of withdrawing from the public sphere. We overcome privatized religion but intentionally supporting the values of God's providential and redemptive kingdoms in our families, churches, and country. Christian activists should focus their agendas not merely on media-identified issues but on the

classically relevant family, church, and national institutions, though in their means of functioning they need to keep abreast of the times. Christians need to prize the spiritual values of the Kingdom of God. In his discourse Jesus declared, “Unless your righteousness surpasses that of the Pharisees and teachers of the law, you will certainly not enter the kingdom of heaven” (Matt 5:20).This means more than legalistic righteousness in our relationships with others in the area of our social ethics. Followers of Jesus avoid even the thought of murder and adultery. They shun divorce, oaths, vengeance, judgment of others, worry, and laying up treasures on earth. Instead, they love their enemies, give to the needy, pray meaningfully, fast, accumulate treasure in heaven, and wisely build their lives on the solid foundation of all Jesus’ teachings (Matt. 5:21-7:29).

Christian social activists ought not to lose the “keys to the kingdom” that Jesus delegated to his followers (Matthew 16:19). So his Spirit-endued ambassadors have authority on earth to proclaim the gospel of forgiveness of sins, deliver the repentant from the dominion of darkness, and make disciples of people of all nations. The one to whom cosmic authority has been given did not intend, as Karl Barth said, to found “a pious little Jewish club.”[56]

Let no Christian use social concern as an excuse for evading responsibility to implement Great Commission. The call to new birth from above is the key that opens door to a spiritual life characterized by kingdom ethics. The task of building spiritual values in God’s kingdom begins but does not end with the new birth.

The crucial question is one of methodology, of how to translate biblical truths to public policy prescriptions. The best of legislative strategies and methods must be developed in harmony with God’s purposes for political institutions in the present age. Christians need to correct social injustices without blurring the distinctions between the Church and the world. Later we will consider the instruments of democracy and law as tools of transformation.

Four Case Studies of Power Encounter

Healing of sick people and casting out evil spirits is the reality of the Kingdom of God. Jesus affirmed this in the answer he gave when the disciples of John the Baptist asked, “Are you the one who was to come, or should we expect some one else?” (Luke 7:20).

Jesus gave observable deeds as proofs, not theories. Notice the report. “At that very time Jesus cured many who had diseases, sicknesses and evil spirits, and gave sight to many who were blind. So he replied to the messengers, 'Go back and report to John what you have seen and heard: the blind receive sight, the lame walk, those who have leprosy are cured, the deaf hear, the dead are raised, and the good news is preached to the poor' (V.21-22). In the works of Jesus the Kingdom of God is a present reality. Significantly, the concept of God ruling, which is frequent in the gospel, describes, Jesus Christ as the

agent through whom God rule is made manifest.

The Kingdom of God is in direct conflict over the Kingdom of Satan. The chief function of Satan in the gospels is to oppose God's redemption. Paul calls Satan the “god of this age” (2Cor. 4:4), expressing the same idea. In the New Testament this opposition never becomes an absolute dualism. Throughout the gospels, Satan is pictured as a supernatural evil spirit, the prince of demons, at the head of inferior demons (Mark 3:22). The demons recognized Jesus and said, “What have you to do with us, Jesus of Nazareth? Have you come to destroy us? I know who you are, the Holy one of God” (Mark 1:24). They recognize a Jesus' supernatural power is capable of crushing satanic power.

The belief in demons and their exorcism in the ancient world were intertwined with magic of a crude sort. By contrast, the amazing factor in Jesus’ ministry was the power of his mere word. This was new. “With authority he commands the evil spirits, and they obey him” (Mark 1:27). When Jesus was accused of himself exercising satanic power, he replied that he cast out demons by the power of God, and this was proof that the Kingdom of God had come upon them. The kingly power of God was attacking the dominion of Satan, and delivering men from the power of evil. “Or how can one enter a strong man’s house and plunder his goods” (Matthew 12:29). In these words Jesus declared that he had invaded the kingdom of Satan and “bound” the strong man. In each exorcism Jesus saw a defeat of Satan.

The same victory over Satan is seen in the power Jesus gave to his disciples when he commissioned them to travel throughout Galilee preaching the Kingdom of God (Luke 10: 9). When the missionaries returned, they reported with joy that even the demons were subject to them in Jesus’ name. Then Jesus said, “I saw Satan fall like lightening from heaven” (Luke 10:18). The context suggests that Jesus saw in the successful mission of the seventy an evidence of defeat of Satan. In the mission of Jesus a decisive victory has been won. Satan has been bound; he has fallen from his place of power; but his final destruction awaits the end of the age.

Today in India a major factor in the growth of the Church is preaching healing and deliverance ministry. Below are some incidents of deliverance.

Case Study 1

My friend Pervez woke me up in the middle of night. He wanted me to visit and prayer for a family in great distress. As we pedaled down the road he narrated the story of the father in a drunken state who that late evening had booted out his family of five who then hired one room to spend the night hoping to return home in the morning. When we reached the family we saw the eldest girl in her early twenties rolling on the ground. Her eyeballs rolled back and her hands and feet twisted. She claimed to see a family of three glaring at her. The girl’s family was praying for

deliverance from the evil spirit. We also joined in prayer for her deliverance. I asked the mother, “How long has your daughter been sick? Has she told you anything?” The mother told us, “A boy wants to marry her, but the girl does not like him and neither do we. But since he has been chasing her we have agreed for him to marry our daughter. Now whenever we talk to her about marrying the boy her condition deteriorates and she starts having hallucinations.”

The stress on the poor family of being thrown out was now coupled with the pain of the girl. The whole family joined us in praying for God to intervene. I called the girl by her name and after about four minutes I got a mild response. All this time her hands and feet twisted, so we gently turned them back to the normal position.

I asked the girl whether she wanted to marry the boy and her answer was no. During the course of conversation I encouraged her to trust God’s power to heal her. I also told the story of the love of Christ who died for our sins. I encouraged her to claim the promises of Christ for herself which she did. The good news is that the girl sat up and was peaceful. I don’t think it was a case of demon possession. I hope they did not make her marry the boy.

Case Study 2

For about six months a girl in her early teens undid her plaits and spun her head until she was exhausted. Her parents took her to medical doctors and to sorcerers but her condition remained the same. People thought a goddess had possessed her and came to her for blessings. Her distressed parents were willing to make any sacrifice to cure of their much loved daughter.

One evening, accompanied by my friend, we visited the family at her parent’s request, explaining that we were ordinary people like them who believe in Jesus Christ who is the healer and deliverer. We saw the corner of a room where the girl had kept a pitcher full of water different sorts of colors and photo calendars of gods and goddesses including one of Jesus Christ. The moment she was in her corner her face changed. With the permission of her parents we asked the girl to accompany to a Christian neighbors house for prayer. Before departing I removed the pitcher and broke it, and she gave me the most hate-filled angry look I have ever received.

My friend and I sat for prayer along with some members of the family. As we sang a Christian hymn the girl again opened her plaits and began to spin her head. We prayed for her laying her hands on her. She became more agitated, so we commanded the spirits to leave in the name of Jesus Christ. Praise the Lord, the girl was delivered. The parents were as happy as we were to see a girl, created in the image and likeness of God, liberated by the power of the triune God.

Case Study 3

An old woman brought her son who was divorced for prayer. We saw on the man's

forehead a wound the size of a big coin. We asked the mother about it and she said, “I took him to a witchdoctor who placed a hot coin on his forehead so that the evil spirit would leave him.” The full story is quite painful. Apparently his wife, seeking a divorce, had gone to a witchdoctor who had sent an evil spirit to posses the man. The woman was able to prove that her husband was mad, receive a legal divorce, and marry her lover.

When the man was under the control of the evil spirit he had such strength that it was difficult for four of us to control him. It took two days of fasting and prayer before the man was delivered. Indeed, we kept at the task because Jesus said, “Some are delivered with prayer and fasting.”

Case Study 4

A woman came to a public meeting with her household servant asking for prayer. As we prayed she began to behave strangely. She went into a trance and said, “I have killed her newborn baby and I have disappeared the money kept on the shelf of her home.” On further questioning the women said in mannish-sounding voice, “She is my wife. I am her first husband. When I died, she used to weep for me beside the sea shore of Bombay saying, 'why you have left me?' and so I have possessed her. I am not happy with her second marriage”.

We checked with the servant whether she was a remarried woman. “Yes,” was the answer. We asked the servant to call her husband who had a small machine tools manufacturing unit. He confirmed the story of the new born baby dying and about the money disappearing as well and that he was her second husband.

The woman was crying and with closed eyes gave correct answer to the number of fingers I raised behind her head. We prayed for her but all of a sudden she became very loud and dominating and commanded her husband to come home and offer a food offering to the spirits. She marched away without being delivered of the evil spirit that was controlling her. We allowed her to go and since we were not aware of her house we were unable to follow up.

Application

People in the ministry of deliverance should wait and pray and seek as much information as possible about the person before deciding whether it a case of demon possession or not. If it a psychological problem, refer the person to a medical doctor. Remember that in the material scientific view there is no room for God or evil spirits and diseases are explained as psychosomatic. But if it a case of demon possession, pray to the Lord who heals, delivers and forgives sins.

Some people beat a person possessed with evil spirits. This is cruel for you harm the person who is beaten. Pray and fast and be sure you reflect the love of Christ and his power and not your greatness.

Some people are proud of their deliverance ministry. Luke 10:17-20 tells

how the disciples ministered in the Jesus' name with his authority. They were elated by the victories they had witnessed, and Jesus shared their enthusiasm. Then Jesus helped them get their priorities right, by reminding them of their most important victory – that their names are written in the book of heaven. Christian identity does not depend on our work or place and family of birth but on who we are in Christ Jesus.

If you have not encountered Christ and your life is not filled with the Holy Spirit you must never attempt the ministry of deliverance. Luke records in the book of Acts that some Jews went around driving out evil spirits. A man tried to invoke the name of the Lord Jesus over those who were demon-possessed, saying, "In the name of Jesus, whom Paul preaches, I command you to come out." Seven sons of Sceva, a Jewish chief priest, were doing this. One day the evil spirit answered them, "Jesus I know, and I know about Paul, but who are you?" Then the man who had the evil spirit jumped on them and overpowered them all. He gave them such a beating that they ran out of the house naked and bleeding" (Acts 19:13-16).

Many follow Christ because of healing or deliverance, but some stop following Christ when their old ailments return. It is imperative to teach about discipleship and maturity and give much pastoral care to believers in Christ.

Jesus wrestled with the powers of evil, won a victory over them by dying on the cross and rose from the dead so that in the end of the age evil powers may be finally and for ever destroyed. Spiritual conflict is not just something we read about in the Bibles. It affects our everyday world of ideas and ideals, shaping our history, determining our future, and to a large extent controlling how we live. God must be the source, the means, and the end for all we do in the transformation of communities.

Liberation of a Dalit Slave Girl

Transformation Has Consequences

"In the name of Jesus Christ I command you to come out of her!" At that moment the spirit left her. (Acts 16:16-24).

Paul and Silas' encounter with the slave girl portrays an agonizing condition of exploitation by her masters who minted a fortune at her expense. The Church of Jesus Christ lives in the midst of such harsh realities, but are we listening to the feeble voices of poverty, injustice and oppression from India and all over the global village as they challenge and call us to combine prayer and action? The world needs transformed Christian communities of faith to demonstrate Christlike courage and compassion. To press on against all odds in the midst of a sinful and adulterous generation that hinders the growth of humanity to its fullness as God intended it to be.

The Liberation of the Slave Girl

Luke in Acts 16:16-24 presents an account of a slave girl who is condemned by society to the lowest level of its hierarchy, for slaves have no rights. On the Sabbath

day when Paul and his friends were going to the place of prayer, the slave girl who stood in their way met them. Luke's mention of prayer emphasizes that the work of transformation must be saturated with the power of prayer. When people pray, God works. Prayer shows our dependence upon the Lord. Prayer is for the helpless.

Luke Tells Us Two Things about the Slave Girl

First, she had a spirit by which she predicted the future, or literally, she had a spirit of a python' or 'a python spirit'. The reference is to the snake of classical mythology, which guarded the temple of Apollo and the Delphic oracle at Mount Parnassus. Apollo was thought to be embodied in the snake to inspire 'pythonesses', and his female devotees with clairvoyance. Luke does not commit himself to these superstitions. Many similar beliefs are rampant in India as well, one such is, that some people are possessed with the tiger spirit and any harm to the person harms some tiger and vice versa. But Luke does believe and rightly so that the slave girl is possessed by an evil spirit.

Second, Luke mentions the slave girl was exploited by her owners, who made a lot of money on account of her fortune telling (v 16). She followed Paul and his friends shouting, "These men are servants of the Most High God''- a term used for God the Supreme Being, the Jews used it for Yahweh and Greeks for Zeus - "who are telling you the way to be saved'' v. 17. Why should demons engage in evangelism? The ulterior motive could be to discredit the gospel by associating it in people's mind with the occult or even equaling herself to God's servant.

In the scripture the phenomena of demon possession is part of the conflict between Jesus, who came to destroy the works of the devil (1 John.3:8) and evil. The demoniac shrieked at the top of his voice, "have you come to destroy us?" It is unusual that demons should stress the thought of consecration to God's service- "you are the Holy One of God!" This is a good example of what James said when he wrote 'the demons believe – and shudder' (James2:19). Demons have knowledge which is unaccompanied by faith, hope or love. When Jesus healed the people were amazed at his work and proceeded to comment on the authority and power with which Jesus commanded the spirits.

"Finally Paul became so troubled that he turned around and said to the spirit, "In the name of Jesus Christ I command you to come out of her!" At that moment the spirit left her." Today the church is growing all over India because of the ministry of deliverance. However the decisive issues of the Kingdom of God are not power issues, but the sheer privilege of entry into the Kingdom of God. We see this clearly explained by Jesus to the seventy when they returned from the ministry and reported to Christ of what had happened.

"The seventy – two returned with joy and said, "Lord, even the demons submit to us

in your name." He replied, "I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven. I have given you authority to trample on snakes and scorpions and to overcome all the power of the enemy; nothing will harm you. However, do not rejoice that the spirits submit to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven" (Luke 10: 17-20).

The ultimate focus of our ministry should not be to exercise power over the demons, but to see people transformed by the power of God and become members of the Kingdom of God. Christian ministry first and foremost is that of teaching the truth of the Word of God.

The Consequences of Liberation

The deliverance of the slave girl had unkind consequences for the missionaries. Paul and Silas encountered the hostility of the owners who had lost their oppressive and lucrative easy gains by the girl finding her freedom in Christ. It happens even today, Christian workers are persecuted because the gospel of Jesus Christ empowers the poor with the message of human dignity, of equality, freedom and mutual respect. In one incident the rich and the powerful threatened the Dalits by saying, "If you become Christian then who will polish our shoes". In another incident a Christian NGO was admonished 'not to educate the poor illiterate for then they would become our equal.' When the exploiters lose their business they often retaliate with violence.

The slave owners dragged Paul and Silas into the market place, which was the centre of public life (v.19). They then brought them before the magistrate in a Roman colony. The charge was that these men were Jews who disturb our city and introduce customs that are not allowed to us Romans to adopt and practice. The accusations of causing a riot and introducing an alien religion were serious. Officially the Roman citizens were not allowed to practice any alien cult that did not receive official sanction, but even if they did practice any alien cult care had to be taken that that it did not involve any political or social crime. (vs.20-21). The slave owners were manipulators. They concealed the real reason for their anger was the loss of oppressive economic income, but they also framed their legal charges against the missionaries that appealed to the anti-Semitism feeling already latent in the minds of people "these men are Jews" and their racial pride, "us Romans" and so they set on fire the inferno of prejudice. Today the Church in India is often criticized as the 'foreigner Church' importing 'foreign influence'. Therefore many Hindu leaders have given a call to the Church to pursue the path of indianizing by becoming one with the "main stream" of the Indian culture by severing their connection with entities outside India. "Advice" is also given not to engage in a mission of preaching Jesus Christ and "converting" the national into foreigners;" for Christian mission is an "anti-national and subversive act." Christian charity and social services are "unethical and motivated" programs. The Church in India is both Indian and Universal. The life style of the Christian

community of faith should reflect both the universality of the gospel and the particulars of the Indian culture.

The owners mobilized a crowd and they attacked Paul and Silas, and the magistrates ordered them to be stripped and beaten. It was a severe flogging, followed by their being thrown in prison. It is amazing that even in the midst of such agonizing pain Paul and Silas at about midnight were praying and singing hymns to God. Not wailing but melody came from their mouth in praise of the sovereign Lord. Just as the Roman colonist never forgot in any environment that he was Roman, so Christians should never forget in any surrounding that they are Christians, members of the body of Jesus Christ. Living in India in the midst of various classes, customs and hierarchies of castes, Christians must exemplify from their lives that they are people of the living God. Yet Christianity has shown a remarkable adaptation to the expression of faith in the local context. Christianity has the genius to contextualize without altering the personal revelation of God in Jesus Christ. In Christ, the Word became flesh, and today the bearers of the Word also communicate the Word to be understood. The Church is the steward of the gospel, which is good news for the poor, but are we sharing it with word and deed?

Good news for the poor liberated the slave girl from the clutches of slavery but the preachers had to pay a high price for it. To be involved in transformational mission has a price to be paid.

Chapter 5

Transforming Language of Mission

With the unimaginable of horrors of nuclear weaponry becoming increasingly alarming due to religious prejudice and ideological hatred between countries in this global village that we inhabit; there is a sense of urgency and a moral imperative for us to raise the question, what is the purpose of religious language? Because religious statements are considered truthful by a people, they allow their lives to be shaped by them and project a world they would like to inhabit. In this section of part one, we will discuss how societies employ religious language to gain moral sanction for the acts of violence. And in part two elucidate that the Church in its transformational mission is duty bound to encourage and employ the biblical metaphors of reconciliation and blessing.

Language Is a Necessary Tool of Communication

The biblical view implies that God instituted language as a vehicle for interpersonal communication and fellowship. Language enables us to communicate our thoughts and knowledge claims, as well as our emotions, desires and fantasies. Human culture is possible because of language. Yet the primary purpose why language was divinely gifted to humankind was to facilitate intelligible communion between man and God and communication of truth. The gift of human speech presupposes the image of God in man, particularly rationality.

Christianity stakes its truth claims not only on the reality of God, but also on the involvement of God in historical events. The truth of God is revealed publicly for all to see, in history and in Jesus Christ. The purpose of the Christian story is to witness to the transformation of the world that God brought about when Jesus Christ entered history confronting powers proclaiming the truth and enacting the Kingdom of God, when he was crucified, resurrected, and seated at the right hand of God. The truth of the Christian story consists in adequately pointing to what the triune God did in Jesus Christ and by His Spirit. This story is communicated in language in the Bible. In practical terms, reverence for truth demands openness towards it, and submission to its leading.

Where does anyone other than Jesus of Nazareth stand forth to declare “I am the Truth” to be either worshipped or crucified? That Jesus has by human standards an abnormal sense of authority is beyond all dispute. While the great prophets declared themselves dependent recipients and bearers of divine truth of God, more than one student of Quran has noted that while Muhammad professes to recite the Word of God, he never himself gives that Word as coming from himself. “Whereas prophets spoke of the word of God, Jesus incorporated it in himself,’

writes E.C. Blackman. In Sikhism, Guru Nanak made a distinction between himself as God's mouthpiece, and the message he uttered: "I spoke only when you, O God, inspired me to speak" (Adi Granth).[57]

Religious Language Is Meant To Do Something[58]

This brings us to the question of power, which undeniably shapes our individual and social behavior. The purpose of religious language is to use all available intellectual and intuitional means to interpret the nature of ultimate reality and to invite the human race to share in the privileges of a personal relationship with God. But religious language has also been used to justify violence.

Religious Language and Violence

Democratizing societies in South Asia display a disturbing common tendency towards ethnic and religious violence. The reason is simple. As societies open up and politicians scramble for power, they appeal to the public for votes using what ends up being the most direct, effective religious language, which cements group solidarity in opposition to some other group. Religious language is most effective in adding fuel to the fires of ethnic or religious conflict. Sometimes the conflict turns into a full-scale war. The warfare religious language is often used as a motivational tool for political ends, for nothing better unites and mobilizes people and resources for action than war.

Religious intolerance is only the first glimpse of the new face of Indian democracy. But why are religious symbols employed for acts of real violence? Do we fault the violent human nature for exploiting religion? Unquestionably, human behavior and actions measure between brilliance and depravity. Pascal pointed out this antithesis between the person's greatness and his meanness: "What sort of freak then is man! How novel, how monstrous, how chaotic, how paradoxical, how prodigious! Judge of all things, feeble earthworm, repository of truth, sink of doubt and error and refuse of the universe!" [59]

One cannot undermine the social, economic and political issues that have birthed violent struggles under the facade of delivering justice and ushering in freedom, and peace of the graveyard. But why is religious language exploited by people betrothed to inhuman violent struggles? Mark Juergensmeyer observes, 'By identifying an earthly worldly struggle with the cosmic struggle of order and disorder, good and evil, light and darkness, justice and injustice, political actors and religious leaders utilize the readily available way of thinking that justifies the use of violent means.' [60] The social scientists research to discover primarily the social and political aspects of the problem, but as Juergensmeyer states some 'have tried to trace the patterns in religion's own logic'.[61] David Rapport, for instance 'has identified several features of Messianic movements that he believes leads to violence, most of which are characterized by a desire for an antinomian liberation from oppression.'[62] For religious language to lead to violence it

is essential for the pious to believe that the cosmic struggle is realizable in human terms. Juergensmeyer writes, "If the war between good and evil, order and chaos, is conceived as taking place in historical time, in a real geographical location, and among actual contestants, it is more likely that those who are prone to violent acts will associate religion with their struggles."[63] Politicians realizing the power of religious language are fond of making allusions to religious and literary traditions in their speeches. They are quick to characterize their worldly foes by associating them with enemies in legendary battles. 'By sacralizing economic, political and social concerns the political activists give an aura of legitimacy that they did not previously posses.' [64]

Morals can be occupied and guided by the most varied forms of ethos. Religious intolerance is not alien to Hinduism. Romila Thapar writes, "Despite the nineteenth century myth that the Hindus are by instinct and religion a non-violent people. The genesis of this myth was partly in the romantic image of the Indian past projected, for example, by scholars such as Max Muller."[65] History bears witness to ample religious conflicts in the Indian society. 'In Hindu tradition, for instance, the mythical battles in Mahabharata and Ramayana epics are frequently used as metaphors for present day struggles, just as are the actual battles in Sikh and Islamic history and in biblical Judaism and Christianity.'[66]

Writing about "The Mahabharata Legacy, and the Gita's Intent" Rajmohan Gandhi says, "Proud as we are of the epic's codes of chivalry, we cannot be proud, I suggest in all humility, of the story, or history, it reveals. In particular, we cannot be proud of the epic's acquiescence in triumph of revenge over reconciliation. I suggest, further, that we cannot be glad that the epic is reproduced in varied forms in our history"[67] Romila Thapar questions, "One is often struck by how different the message of the Gita would have been and how very much closer to non-violence if Gautama Buddha had been the charioteer of Arjuna instead of Krishna"[68]

The Concept of Soldier-Saint Is Inherent In Sikh Religion

Before his death, Guru Arjan, (1581-1606) seeing the war-clouds gathering, advised his son Hargobind (1606-1645) to sit fully armed on his throne, and he asked Bhai Buddha to make soldier-saint out of him.[69] Sikhs are independent and democratic; they are equal members of a Brotherhood, the Khalsa. It was this spirit of independence that drove them to revolt against the Brahman-dominated caste system in the first place; and it was this same spirit that led them to organize the Khalsa as a militant brotherhood to oppose domination by Islam.[70] 'The warrior strain appeared in their ancestors of old. Their Aryan forbearers conquered all Northern India, singing the hymns of the Vedas as they went. A devout appreciation of Nature went along with the ruthless dispossession of the *Dasyus* (Dalits). These Vedic Aryans were the original warrior saints, and the ideal of the soldier-saint dominates the Sikhs to this day.'[71]

Certainly the Quranic model of leadership is authoritarian. Starting with the eleventh AD over a span of eight centuries, conquerors flying the flag of Islam raced down the passes of Hindu Kush, and down the plains and deserts of India, killing those in their way, smashing numberless idols in temples, including images of the Buddha, plundering gold and other precious booty. Sometimes they returned from where they came with their treasures. Occasionally they remained and ruled. Islam teaches it is the duty of Muslims to exert themselves strenuously "in the cause of God" against both personal ungodliness and the enemies of Islam. Jihad can mean "holy war," but the struggle for uprightness of life and propagation of the faith prefers peaceful means such as persuasion and example. Muslims consider themselves as comprising the *Dar al-Islam*, "the Household of submission," and the rest of the world's peoples as the *Dar al-Hard,* "the Household of warfare." It is the duty of Muslims to extend the *Dar al-Islam* by means of missionary activities and in some cases even by military *jihad,* if necessary, toward the ultimate goal of a worldwide Islamic community embracing all. However Quran explicitly admonishes that there shall be "no compulsion in religion." (Sura 2:256). *Jihad* is the only form of armed conflict sanctioned by the religion, and those who fall "in the cause of Allah" are martyrs who will immediately taste the joys of salvation (Sura 2: 154; 3:169, 195) Muslims distinguish between the "greater *jihad*,' which is the constant struggle of the individual believers against his own evil tendencies, and the "lesser *jihad*," which is actual armed conflict in defense of the faith or its propagation.[72]

Catholic Popes combined religious authority and political power for centuries. In 1095 Pope Urban II urged his listeners to undertake a holy war to free the Holy Land from pagan control. The appeal succeeded, and the first crusade was launched. The crusades were the most obvious example of the merger between violence and holiness which took place in the medieval Church. The crusades were a tragic distortion of Christian mission, for which the Church is still criticized. The religious wars that followed the Reformation were some of the most violent in all of European history.[73]

Peck has wisely stated,

> "Crusades and inquisitions have nothing to do with Christ. War, torture, and persecution have nothing to do with Christ. Arrogance and revenge have nothing to do with Christ. When he gave his one recorded sermon, the first words out of Jesus' mouth were, "Blessed are the poor in spirit." Not the arrogant. And as he was dying he asked that his murderers be forgiven."[74]

The West created truly global empires between 1500 and 1750 by improving its ability to wage war which has been termed as 'the military revolution.' Huntington remarks,

> "The West won the world not by the superiority of its ideas or

> values or religion (to which few members of other civilizations were converted) but rather by its superiority in applying organized violence. Westerners often forget this fact; non-Westerners never do."[75]

The established leadership usually does not resort to violence; rather the second level of leadership, a younger and more marginalized group for whom the acts of violence are enormously empowering. The psychological dimension of power may be even more effective. Even a small display of violence can have immense symbolic power: the power to awaken the masses into realization of their potency. This is best illustrated, when on December 6, 1992, the Ayodha's Babri Masjid mosque, built in 1528 by Mir Baqi under the authority of Babar, the first Mughal emperor of India, was demolished in revenge by a mob of more than 300,000 Hindus, most of whom wore the saffron color of Hindu nationalism. Ashis Nandy aptly puts it, 'there is now a peculiar double-bind in Indian politics: the ills of religion have found political expression but the strengths of it have not been available for checking corruption and violence in public life.'[76]

Our brief survey of religious violence sufficiently attest the fact that a community of human beings can be thoroughly blind, corrupt, and incapable of recognizing what is good, just, liberating, and corresponding with God. Very few people would deny that violence with utterly false orientations in which the very powers providing orientation are employed is a conspiracy against life itself. Religious language always becomes a handy tool to mobilize violence. The Christian community in India does not have a history of involvement in religious violence, even though we are victims of violence. They have practiced with honor and respect from all communities, their rights and duties as citizens to work for social progress and promote the ideals, which seem true and right. They work to alleviate human misery and injustice because they believe God loves all people equally and desires justice for all.

The Cross Defines our Relationship with Others

How should we then relate to others? The cross defines this. Jesus Christ "died for the ungodly" is the central assertion of the New Testament. The message of the cross is that when we serve and even suffer for others, we are in the company of Jesus Christ. Christ's love in us motivates us for Christian service, so the church is involved in relief and development, in imparting education and medical services to people. The cross opens us to grace, which is the power and presence of God, giving us the kind of love Christ showed when he washed the disciples' feet and cared for the unlovable. The transformed community of Christ must be in the forefront of serving others.

In his book *The Rise of Christianity* sociologist Rodney Stark documents how the church lived during the first three centuries of the Christian era in the Roman

Empire. Abortion, infanticide, adultery, demeaning treatment of women and plague were all common in the Roman Empire, with negative consequences on the Empire. The Roman population barely reproduced itself because of frequent abortions. Female infanticide produced a serious shortage of women for marriage. Adultery, abortion, and forced pre-adolescent marriage destroyed the fertility of many women. Plagues killed a high percentage of the population.

Stark demonstrates that Roman Christians behaved differently. They did not practice abortion. They treated women with dignity and respect and cared for others instead of fleeing when plagues hit. The impact was tremendous. The Emperor Constantine legalized Christianity in AD 313. Transformational mission witnesses to the fact that Christ creates reconciled people who work for justice in the midst of injustice, for truthfulness in middle of deception, and for peace in the centre of a violent society. The best example of this is the reconciling words of Mrs. Gladys Staines in face of the horrific murder of her husband and two sons in 1999 in Baripada, Orissa. "I have no anger. I have no hatred. I forgive them." People asked Gladys, "How could you forgive?" Such forgiving is not natural, but we believe it comes from Christ and reveals the true power of Christian character. When those who follow Christ focus on godly and righteous behavior, they supernaturally become a respected alternative. What then should be the language of transformational mission?

Transformational Mission Language and Biblical Metaphor

"And he has committed us the ministry of reconciliation" 2 Corinthian 5: 18-19.

Our study will show that the Church in its transformational mission is duty bound to encourage and employ the biblical metaphors of reconciliation and blessing.

Transferring the Biblical Message

We believe the Bible's communication has its own music of melody and harmony. It calls us by a still small voice to reflect and act. It has been the common conviction of all Christians that life must be lived under the authority of the word of God, but how can we be sure that that we are allowing the Scripture to speak with its own authentic and authoritative voice?

Mere translation from the original Greek and Hebrew is not enough. We need the thought forms also for the present day. There is a double risk for communicators, either to ignore the cultural gap of many centuries and to read the Bible as though it were contemporary literature, or to exaggerate the cultural gap and ignore the similarities between the biblical world and our own. Let us not separate the language and metaphors from their time and place where they had their original contextual boundaries, for that may distort.

We should ask, "Do the metaphors used of the activities of the people of God cohere with scripture's ethical and character requirements?" For example, does warfare imagery cohere with the fruit of the Spirit

and New Testaments call for gentleness, kindness, compassion and love? The problem is not with the metaphors themselves but with humans who extend metaphors until they break down.

The Nature of Metaphor

Comparison is one of our most valuable sources of knowledge, the main path leading from the known to the unknown. Metaphors and similes are not literal. For example, Jesus compared the Kingdom of God with mustard seed and yeast. "How shall I explain to you about the Kingdom of God? It is like mustard seed, like yeast" (Mark 4: 30). A comparison may fail for two reasons. First, it may fail if the speaker assumes the audience knows something they do not know. The warfare vocabulary of the Bible is difficult even for a biblical scholar, so how would those with secular and non-Christian worldviews understand it? We are not acquainted with many things the contemporaries of Isaiah or Paul knew well.

The second reason is even more important. When two things are compared, they need not be like in all respects, only in the point of comparison. When the psalmist tells us that a united family is like oil dripping down Aaron's beard on to the skirts of his robe, he is not trying to persuade us that family unity is messy, greasy or volatile. He is thinking of the pervasive fragrance which deeply impressed his memory at the anointing of a high priest (Ps. 133:2). A preacher once sermonizing on Psalm 133 interpreted that women do not have a beard and drew conclusions to his liking.

We must distinguish between metaphor as a figure of speech and the mental event, the engagement with the idea. A metaphor is "one thing suggesting another", yet a metaphor presents a person with a significant new idea or way of interpreting, or even a new hypothesis. As Soskice observes, metaphors offer potentially new "categories of interpretation and hypothesizes new entities, states of affairs, and casual relations".[77] When metaphors become part of our language, they contribute to the way we interpret our world, they may even transform us by determining how we engage our self in the world, while drawing meaning from our world. For example, our understanding of the phrase "fellow soldier" is shaped by whether a soldier is thought of as a mercenary or peacekeeper. We must make a distinction between the metaphor itself, which is a linguistic event, and the mental event associated with it. We must keep in mind both the mental and emotional elements inherent in the metaphor.

Some metaphors readily lend themselves to high development because they belong to a metaphor system. They are linked together by their common origin in a single area of human observation, experience or activity which generates its own peculiar vocabulary. For example the metaphors of farming, commerce, law, warfare, family, weather, love, health, nature, and sport have a recognizable language of its own. Paul in particular has a way of piling up analogies from agriculture (1 Cor.9:7-12),

from the athletic stadium (1 Cor. 9:23-27), from book- keeping (Phil. 3:7-9), and from the experience of darkness and light (1 Thess. 5: 1-8); and this same characteristic is also in evidence in the extended military metaphor of Eph. 6:10-17.

Military metaphors are highly developed. Words like target, conquer, army, crusade, mobilize, advance, enemy, battle, strategy, are used to motivate and inspire for mission. The military metaphors, which had a limited reference to battle campaigns, when placed in the context of market or mission are extended beyond their original boundaries. The metaphors have been distorted, with unfortunate results. They are separated them from their time and place and hence from their earlier boundaries of meaning.

Military Metaphors are Counter-Productive for Mission

The secular corporate world stresses crisis to increase the sense of urgency for change. War imagery fits their needs to claim precedence even over personal life. Since war unites and mobilizes people and resources for action it is used as an instrument for motivation. The use of warfare metaphor as a motivational tool for transformational mission is inappropriate.

The New Testament teaches to maintain good relations with those in authority. The state is a gift of God's common grace and is granted authority to maintain law and order and restrain evil in the society (Romans 13:1-7). We must always remember that the ultimate authority comes from God and its exercise must be in harmony with His character. If the government passes legislation, which takes from the individual his freedom of religion, the New Testament does not expect obedience to that legislation. For example, when the Sanhedrin commanded Peter and John not to speak at all in the name of Jesus, they replied, "Judge for yourselves whether it is right in God's sight to obey you rather than God. For we cannot help speaking about what we have seen and heard" (Acts 4: 19-20). When human authorities maintain civil order and provide for individual freedom of religion they are indirectly at the disposal of God for the carrying on his work, Christians are to respond in co-operative service.

The imagery of Roman soldier and militaristic campaigns are valuable in understanding the issues of acknowledgement of authority, personal discipline and personal sacrifice but it's not effective as a metaphor for Christian activity. The image does not advocate that the believers are at war with either culture or other people. The gospel certainly challenges and transforms all cultures, but this is not war.

When Paul does use military imagery he weakens it in doing so, Paul writes to the Corinthian Church,

"I beg you that when I come I may not have to be as bold as I expect to be toward some people who think that we live by the standards of this world. 3. For though we live in the world, we do not

wage war as the world does.4. The weapons we fight with are not the weapons of the world. On the contrary, they have divine power to demolish strongholds. 5. We demolish arguments and every pretension that sets itself up against the knowledge of God, and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ", (2 Cor10:2-5)

Paul admonishes that we don't need to use human plans and methods to win our battles. God's mighty weapons are available to us as we fight against Satan's "stronghold." The Christians must choose whose methods to use, God's or the world's. Paul assures us that God's mighty weapons – prayer, faith, hope, love, God's Word, the Holy Spirit are powerful and effective (cf. Ephesians 6: 13-18). These weapons can break down the proud human arguments against God and the walls that Satan builds to keep people from finding God.

Bible teaches that we all have a common enemy in Satan, the devil, and the powers aligned with him. The power encounter is with satanic forces and not with nations. Warfare language can confuse that the battle is God's and not ours, and the conqueror is Christ and not us. Such language also present those to whom we want to witness in the category of enemies rather than friends. With the emphasis on relativism and tolerance in our culture today the use of warfare imagery makes us appear intolerant and antagonistic, even to fellow Christians, to say nothing of people of other faiths and ideologies.

Mission Language in the History of the Church

The emphasis in the early Church was that every Christian should live in obedience to Christ. Clement (A.D. 30-100) gives the examples of the martyrdom of Peter and Paul "who spent their lives in the practice of holiness" and urges Christians "to give up vain and fruitless cares, and approach to the glorious and venerable rule of our holy calling".[78] The "Letter to Diognetus," was written by an anonymous apologist about (129) to present a case for Christianity. The argument is set in the context of the transcendent God who made himself known in history in the person of Jesus Christ, 'destroying the divinities of human imagination'. The character of Christian life is a primary piece of evidence for supernatural basis of Christian religion. 'Christians are different and mysterious, because they live by a superhuman power.' Christian faith brings vitality and grace and love to a world full of hatred. This illustrates the early church's conviction that every believer is so to live in obedience to Christ that others, seeing their exemplary lives, will want to follow Christ also.[79]

Mission for most Christians in the early Church was defined primarily in terms of being rather than doing. This became a recurring theme of Orthodox mission theology. How then did the Gospel spread to every corner of the Roman Empire within two centuries? The Christians were ablaze with the power of the risen Christ, the threats of persecution did not dampen

down their passion to spread the gospel. The first great church historian Eusebius of Caesarea (260-340) wrote that many unnamed charismatic evangelists traveled widely, "scattering the saving seeds of the kingdom of heaven far and wide throughout the whole world… a great many marvelous miracles of divine spirit were still being worked by them."[80]

A very different motivation and understanding of conversion occurred in the well known case of Constantine (d337) who followed the Christian God because he was more powerful and gave victory in battle.

The crusades beginning from 1096 dominated the life of both the Church and state in Western Europe for over two centuries. They had their roots in the teaching of Gregory the Great that it was the duty of Christian rulers to defend and extend the Christian faith. Since salvation came by obedience and participation on the life of the Church, conversion by force seemed logical. The crusades were a tragic distortion of Christian mission, the results of which are still with us.

The Waldensians movement (1176) was motivated by two concepts which become important in later movements; radical discipleship, and the conviction that all believers were potentially priests, women as well as men. The Waldensians were terribly persecuted, but a remnant joined with the followers of John Huss and became the nucleus of the Moravian movement.

The Roman Catholic mission in the sixteenth century continued many of the characteristics of the crusades especially in Latin America. The Society of Jesus saw itself as an army whose members were soldiers of God. They vowed to fight under the direction of pope for the good of souls, and the propagation of faith in whatever countries he might wish to send them. The order produced some of the most attractive and effective missionaries, among them, Xavier, who wished to 'bring natives into the fold of Jesus Christ."[81] The tragic side of Roman Catholic mission in this period was seen in the colonization of Latin America, with mass baptisms, exploitation, and often extermination of the native populations.

The theme of the glory of God becomes important in the Puritans, who began to engage in mission among the Native Americans in the seventeenth century. Jonathan Edwards went back to the focus of blessing, quoting Genesis, Psalms, and Isaiah, "All nations shall be blessed in Him, and all nations shall call Him blessed."[82] The motif of the glory of God was also seen in Pietism, which had some of its roots in Puritanism. A.H. Francke, who sent the first Protestant missionaries to Asia, wrote that he was motivated "by the glory of God and service to neighbor'.[83] Zinzendorf of the Moravian movement also emphasized blessing.

The modern Protestant missionary movement began with William Carey, who wrote that Christ "has a kingdom that is to be proclaimed in its power to the ends of

the earth. It is the duty of all Christians to engage in the proclamation of this kingdom."[84] But the movement arose along western colonialism, and the assumption that Western Culture was Christian and thus superior to all others.

The conciliar circles discern God's presence in the world and work for humanization, helping victims of injustice, oppression, poverty, and racism. It emphasized that the world provided the agenda for the Church.[85] In 1986 a group of third world theologians stated evangelization can no longer be a matter of spiritual conquest or religious colonization.[86] The concept of "Unreached peoples," the "ten forty window," and 'strategies for world evangelization' are still very much part of our mission language. Many Indian Christian theologians use the religious categories of various systems of Hinduism to theologize.

Mission: an Activity of the Church

The military rhetoric in mission language needs a careful scrutiny lest it underestimates the crucial point that mission is the activity of the church. The Church universal organizes itself in many different forms for many different purposes. They are all expressions of the Church and obligated to manifest the character of the body of Christ.

The Identity of the Community of Faith

What is the identity of the servant of Christ and what reflects the lifestyle of the community of faith? The basis for Christian existence is the grace and love of God, which provides the motivation and power to live like the people of God. Paul states that the Christian life is to be lived in response to the compulsion of Christ's love which was demonstrated in his willingness to die for all. (2 Corinthians 5:14f). Peter like wise offers a similar portrayal. He explains that the motivation for the proclamation of the word is the Christian's experience and core identity as God's own people. "You are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people belonging to God, that you may declare the praise of him who called you out of darkness into his wonderful light" (1 Peter 2: 9-12). The reason for Christian's existence is to offer praise and proclamation. The motivation for proclamation is the Christian's experience and identity as the people of God.

Mission is Primarily Blessings the Nations

The central missionary text for missions is found in Genesis 12:2-3, "I will make you a great nation and I will bless you: I will make your name great, and you will be a blessing. I will bless those who bless you, and whoever curses you will I will curse: and all the peoples on earth will be blessed through you".

Transformational mission is primarily a ministry of blessings the nations. The suffering servant passages in Isaiah also resonates the same theme. "I the LORD, have called you in righteousness; I will take hold of your hand. I will keep you and will make you to be a covenant for the people and a light for the Gentiles, to open

eyes that are blind, to free captives from prison and to release from the dungeon those who sit in darkness" (Isaiah 41-6-7). Jesus echoes the same words in the synagogue at Nazareth (Luke 4:18-19). Isaiah continues the same theme of light. "I will also make you a light for the Gentiles, that you may bring my salvation to the ends of the earth" (49:6.) Light is an important term for Jesus in the Gospels. "I am the light of the world' (John 8:12) and "Let your light so shine, (Mt. 5:16) Light is also an important theme in the conversion account of Saul of Tarsus, "I am sending you to them to open to open their eyes and turn them from darkness to light, and from the power of Satan to God, so that they may receive forgiveness of sins and a place among those who are sanctified by faith in me" (Acts 26: 17-18). Here we observe the theme of blessing and spiritual encounter is present. The Church becomes a source of blessing by proclaiming and practicing the gospel of reconciliation.

The metaphor of light has implications for mission: to illumine, to show reality, to guide us on the way to warn, etc. Paul tells us that we are to be ambassadors for Christ, taking the message of reconciliation to the world, both by word and by demonstrating it among groups, which have traditionally been hostile. (cf.2 Cor.5: 17-20).

The last book of the Bible speaks of the water of life, which nurtures the tree whose leaves are for the healing of the nations. "Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, as clear as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb down the middle of the great street of the city. On each side of the river stood the tree of life, bearing twelve crops of fruit, yielding its fruit every month. And the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations". (Rev.22: 1f).

The Biblical terms like Good News, salvation, and redemption, all fit into the category of reconciliation and blessing. The overwhelming Biblical language for mission reflects the motif of blessing rather than warfare. While we believe in the reality of spiritual warfare, we must question the wisdom of using warfare language for mission today. The history of crusades and western colonialism and the inaccurate perception that Christian mission was an aspect of western imperialism make it unwise. The biblical language about mission stresses the blessing and reconciliation motif far more than that of warfare. This is the language that will move us forward in transformational mission.

Statement on Mission Language
Richard Howell and Augustine Pagolu[87]

The national consultation of the Theological Commission of the Evangelical Fellowship of India on Mission Language and Biblical Metaphor met at South Asia Institute of Advanced Christian Studies, Bangalore, 4 – 7 October, 2000, with representatives from across India.

We accept the need to be sensitive in our language to show consideration for others and how they may perceive our words.

This applies to what we say or write for any medium at all, including letters, reports, songs, prayers, and material on the Internet, for the boundaries between in-house and public domain are disappearing.

Offensive Terms

We acknowledge that some churches and Christian missions have borrowed offensive secular terms, and over-extended military metaphors from the Bible. For example, the Bible uses "soldier" to illustrate how we should obey God, but not to encourage an aggressive attitude to other people. While we want to avoid inappropriate military language, we profit from Bible metaphors that call us to respect and obey God and those in authority.

However, warfare words, such as "army", "advance", "attack," "battle", "campaign," "crusade", "conquer", "commandos", "enemy", "foe," "forces," "marching orders," "mobilize", "soldier," "tactical plan," "target", "victory," "weapons," have been wrongly used as motivational tools for missions. Other offensive words include "pagan," "darkness," and "heathen." Emphasis on such vocabulary is unloving, inappropriate and counter-productive. Language that excludes women also offends. We must continuously examine both our attitudes and our language.

The Danger of Labeling

We believe evil in all its forms is in conflict with the rule of God. Evil is our enemy and not people. We object to language that can wrongly label people as enemies, or appear aggressive. Although the gospel call to follow Christ may cause offence and be opposed by some, we must take care to avoid vocabulary that can be distorted to justify that opposition.

Our Motivation

Warfare language is not our motivation for mission. We share Christ because we experience the love and grace of God, leading us to worship and proclamation. As God loves all people without discrimination, so should we. We respect and serve all in words, attitudes and actions, regardless of caste, race, class, creed and gender.

A Call to Christians

We call upon our brothers and sisters to take care not to offend with words.

We also ask the church outside India to be aware that inappropriate mission language not only offends people of other faiths, but also brings harm to Christians here.

Words that lead us Forward

Let us draw our mission terms from biblical concepts. Let us use words like family, relationship, love, welcome, embrace, reconcile, hope, serve, peace with God, promoting justice, offering gifts of life and blessing.

Chapter 6

Democracy and Transforming India

Democracy

The lowering of the Union Jack and the raising of the Indian tricolor on August15, 1947 effected the transfer of power from the British colonial rule to the people of India with all its allurements. In this article we will consider briefly the making of democracy in India, the prevailing challenges to the democratic polity and the transformational role Christians are called to play.

The British arrived as merchants of the East India Company but after the battles of Plassy (1757) and Buxar (1764), the English gained control and formed a new government. The Muslim ruling elite was pushed aside and replaced by Englishmen. The British built and operated most of the crucial institutions of liberal democracy in India: courts, legislatures, administrative rules, and a press that was free to a great extent. But the government did not give much power to the Indians themselves. After the Indian independence in 1947, Indians inherited these institutions and traditions, and led by the Indian National Congress laid the foundation of a democratic country. Nehru, India's first prime minister, from1947-1964, was committed to building genuine traditions of constitutional governance. He was deeply respectful of liberal institutions and traditions, such as the prerogatives of parliament and the press. He supported an independent judiciary and laid great emphasis on secularism and religious tolerance.

It has been argued well by many scholars that while Gandhi put his faith in the ethically reformed individual, in creating an ideal society, Nehru considered the democratic institutions as the best means of achieving the goal of creating a better society. He believed that the modern institutions would be the principal engine of social change. For Nehru, state was first and foremost democratic, but in an economically poor and religiously and culturally diverse country it could hardly be truly democratic without being socialist and secularist. Nehru knew that the masses of India were not in tune with his thinking to share his view of secular politics and the secular state. He wrote in 1961 just three years before his death: "We talk about a secular state in India. It is perhaps not very easy even to find a good word in Hindi for "secular". Some people think it means something opposed to religion. That obviously is not correct….It is a state which honors all faiths equally and gives them equal opportunities. Our constitution lays down that we are a secular state, but it must be admitted that this is not wholly reflected in our mass living and thinking." [88] It is noteworthy that Nehru refused to use coercive powers of the state in hastening the process of secularism.

How could democracy, brought in by the British rule, flourish in a highly hierarchical

Hindu society promoting the ideal of egalitarian society? This appears to be an enigma. The Indian response to this democratic ideal of an equal society must therefore be seen in the specific and unique context of its own culture and tradition.

Pavan K. Varma argues in his book that 'democracy has survived in India not because Indians are democratic, but because democracy has proved to be the most effective instrument for cherished pursuit of power.' [89] In fact Varma builds a case that the Hindu society 'exalts the pursuit of material well-being, artha, as a principal goal of life.' A significant thought that he sums up is, 'Indians are extraordinarily sensitive to the calculus of power. They consider the pursuit of power a legitimate end in itself, and display great astuteness in adjusting to, and discovering, the focus of power. Those who renounce the lure of power are worshipped, not because their example is capable of emulation, but in sheer awe of their ability to transcend the irresistible.' [90]

Answering the question why Gandhism failed in India, Varma states, 'Mahatma Gandhi believed that the means are as important as the end. His creed failed to attract followers because the concept was alien to Indian tradition. India's most well-known treatise on statecraft, the Arthashastra, written by Kautilya almost two thousand years ago, wastes little time on moral underpinnings of power. On the contrary, it advocates a compelling unsentimental recipe on how to seize power through means fair and foul. Kautilya's essential thesis is that expediency is far more important than conventional morality in conducting the affairs of the state.' [91] Democracy has flourished in India because most Indians perceived it to be a pragmatic and effective means to personal power by participating in the democratic process. [92] In the past, status was prescriptive, a consequence of one's birth. Today it can be acquired by other means, including greater avenues of upward mobility. But this has not made people more egalitarian in their outlook. In a country where resources are scarce, and opportunities for upward mobility are limited, political power opens the gates to both.[93]

The hierarchical frame of mind of the Hindu society has not been replaced by a new egalitarianism rather democracy provides legitimacy to hierarchies, both old and new. Varma argues that, "democracy did not adopt India. Indians usurped democracy because it could be molded to fit earlier structures without threatening them. The miracle of India is that the practice of democracy has flourished within its boundaries for over five decades in the absence of a democratic temperament."[94]

Democracy has led to gradual but genuine political empowerment of the weakest and poorest sections. Socially the lower castes have continued to rise through the ballot box and the growing literacy. Local self-government in the form of Panchayati Raj has slowly become a reality, thanks to the Seventy-third Amendment to the constitution in 1993.

The congress party over the years declined as a dominant national institution. New challenges rose for the Congress party, the most prominent being the Hindu fundamentalist Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The BJP, however, is only one among a host of energetic new parties that draw their appeal from regional, religious or caste differences. As a result, new voters mostly from the poor, rural, and lower caste backgrounds have entered the political system. Yogendra Yadav, an Indian political scientist studying this trend, argues that India is going through a "fundamental quiet transformation" that is opening up its politics to a much broader group of people who were marginalized. These parties have made India more democratic, but they have also made it less tolerant.

The BJP came to power in 1998 by denouncing Nehruvian socialism, advocating a quasi-militant Hindu nationalism, and encouraging anti-Muslim and anti-Christian rhetoric and action. The rhetoric of hatred appealed to its core voters, the Hindus who form the majority of the population. Whenever BJP has found itself in political trouble, it has stoked the fires of religious conflict, as it did in Gujarat in 2002.

The Indian society has failed to bring under control the divisive forces which resulted in the partition in 1947. Though fifty seven years have passed, tempers continue to rage, and occasionally even blood flows in some places, as a result of mutual hostility between the followers of different religions. Religious intolerance is only the first glimpse of the new face of Indian democracy. Massive corruption and a disregard for the law have transformed Indian politics and shaken its credibility. The danger of oppression in a democracy comes from the "tyranny of the majority," the essence of democratic government consists in the absolute sovereignty of the majority. Democracy alone does not guarantee rule of law. Hitler the ruthless dictator of Germany was also democratically elected. The experience of democracy over the past few decades in India has been in which, writes Fareed Zakaria, "majorities have quietly, sometimes loudly eroded separations of power, undermined human rights, and corrupted long-standing traditions of tolerance and fairness." [95] India has certainly become more democratic. But it has 'become less tolerant, less law-abiding, and less liberal. And these two trends - democratization and illiberalism – are directly related. Zakaria makes an important observation, 'mature liberal democracies can usually accommodate ethnic divisions without violence or terror and live in peace with other liberal democracies. But without a background in constitutional liberalism, the introduction of democracy in divided societies has actually fomented nationalism, ethnic conflict, and even war.' [96]

Indian democracy faces new challenges, ethnic conflicts, fighting terrorism, adjusting to globalization and adapting to the aspirations of a young society. India will have to make its system work much better than it currently does. That means making democratic decision-making

effective, reintegrating constitutional liberalism into the practice of democracy, rebuilding broken political institutions and civic associations and above all those with immense power should assume responsibilities, lead and set standards that are not only legal but moral. Without this democracy will become an empty shell, not simply inadequate but potentially dangerous, bringing with it erosion of liberty, the manipulation of freedom, and the decay of a common life.

For Christians to withdraw from the political sphere will mean accepting by default the prevailing socio-political scenario in the country. If there is no religious protest against certain policies or injustices, then there seems to be a tacit approval of them. It is imperative for Christians to be involved in the political processes of the country to put forward their point of view. Christians in India find themselves increasingly impacted by government policies. The passing of freedom of religion bills in four states of India is just one small example. What option is more Christian –political activism or political withdrawal?

Christian faith is opposed to privatization of religion, to the narrowing down of religion merely to the inner life, the private sphere. Religion cannot be private; it must always be the religion of a particular person or community. Religion is immediately involved in a variety of social relationships and responsibilities.

The Kingdom of God must not be reduced to extending democracy or free enterprise or socialism or promoting peace and harmony alone among the fallen humanity. Changing socio-political structures raise important and inescapable issues. The Bible calls for no one preferred form of civil government. All political forms can be misused. While a responsible republic or democracy at least protects political self-determination, it can deteriorate into anarchy. Christians must guard against two serious errors: first, that the world by structural changes can be turned into a new society or Kingdom of God; and second, that improving socio-political structures is unimportant since we are called to proclaim the gospel.

Hendrik Kramer wisely writes: "to promise that Christianity will dispel economic misery and social disturbance is to invite disillusionment, because economic misery and social disturbance are caused and cured by many factors entirely outside the control of Church or missions….' 'Christianizing' the social, economic and political order, although necessarily included in the living act of manifold mission expression, cannot be the real motive and ultimate purpose."[97]

For many affluent Christians, God is a heavenly capitalist who has vested interest in business success; for many labor bosses, He is a Divine Worker who propagandizes for higher wages and for multiplied fringe benefits. For others as Jacques Ellul says, politics is the new god of technological society; they hold the "the illusion…that they can modify reality itself in our day by exercise of political power."[98]

Yet Biblical religion stands in unquestionable opposition to unjust laws and structures in our present social order, and does so in view of God's new messianic covenant that seeks to inscribe the holy divine will upon the life of nations. Faith in the final victory of righteousness already has a partial historical vindication through the resurrection of the crucified Jesus, and human history is even now wholly open to the eschatological future and awaits the consummation of biblical messianism. The need is for fuller Christian involvement in political affairs, more initiative in confronting caste discrimination and problems of poverty, unemployment and human freedom.

Religious freedom has a very close and crucial connection with the Church in India. Ms Jayalalitha, the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, enacted a Freedom of Religion Bill against which there were protests from every section of civil society. The Church was in the forefront seeking withdrawal of the Bill. But after all the candidates of Ms Jayalalitha's party – the AIADMK lost in the general elections to the parliament in April 2004 she withdrew the Freedom of Religion Bill. The Church played a crucial role in resisting this anti-people and anti-freedom of conscience Bill. For the Church to constitute itself as a centre of resistance, the exercise of religious freedom must be constitutionally granted. What is needed is not just improved laws but a change in social and political structures wherever these perpetuate glaring injustices. Christians serve the providential realm of God's kingdom by taking a responsible role as citizens -by caring for their neighbors and the nation. Transformational mission indeed brings biblical perspective to bear on social ills and influences society by the values of the Kingdom of God.

Law: A Tool for Transformation
Tehmina Arora[99]

A college dean once glibly suggested that students should have no rules so that they would not feel guilty of breaking them. That would be intolerable. Most humans have a sense of justice and fair play. How could God remain just, we ask, and not call injustice wrong? In his essay "Why care about justice?" Nicholas Wolterstroff asks if the doing of justice and the struggle to undo injustice belong to Christian piety. The answer to his query resonates across the Scripture with a loud 'Yes', as there is sufficient evidence of God's heart for justice all through the Bible.

Can Justice be Dominated by Self Interest?

In the parable of the unjust judge (Luke 18:1-8) Jesus speaks for the rights of a harassed widow and charges a corrupt judicial process. But he does more. He reminds his disciples of the approaching judgment of God. When the judge finally responds to the desperate woman's plight, he is motivated not by the high priority of justice, but by personal factors: "Because this widow keeps bothering me, I will see that she gets justice, so that she won't eventually wear me out with her coming!" (Luke 18:5). Such justice is dominated by self-interest.

Jesus is saying that despite the negligence of earthly stewards justice will ultimately triumph because God is the supreme and heavenly trustee of justice. Church must affirm the transcendent basis of justice and law.

Justice Requires Public Duty

Through civil law God seeks to redirect fallen humanity's inclination for greed, power and privilege, and provide a safe and creative environment Human rights are important not only in human but also in God's sight. God wills civil government as a framework to preserve justice and restrain disorder (Rom. 13:1ff). Christians need courage to voice the demands of justice and law in the life of the world.

Christians around the world, under whatever government, are duty bound to serve God through public duty, keeping the Ten Commandments, and fulfilling God's law of love (Romans 13:10). The Old Testament prophets constantly called people to basic morality under God.

For instance, Isaiah 59: 14-16a says: "So justice is driven back, and righteousness stands at a distance; truth has stumbled in the streets, honesty cannot enter. Truth is nowhere to be found, and whoever shuns evil becomes a prey. The LORD looked displeased that there was no justice. He saw that there was no one, he was appalled that there was no one to intervene." Jeremiah 22:3 reiterates this by stating, "This is what the LORD says: Do what is just and right. Rescue from the hand of his oppressor the one who has been robbed. Do no wrong or violence to the alien, the fatherless or the widow, and do not shed innocent blood in this place." "And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly … and to walk humbly with your God" (Micah 6:8).

As Christians, we must acknowledge that God desires justice in all areas of human life, and therefore we are mandated to practice justice within the church as well as to fight for the justice on behalf of victims of injustice. And, as the Bible declares that it is God who ordained civil government to restrain evil, reward good, and protect the innocent, secular law should be used as a useful tool in the establishment of God's kingdom, in spite of numerous fallacies.

In most modern democracies, like India, the rule of law prevails and as law pervades the lives of its people it makes law a useful mission tool. For, it governs the conditions and terms of the employment, marriage, habitation, even the birth of children[100], providing protection from harm, compensation for injury and encroaching upon closest relationships. In fact, it provides the necessary framework within which a society can flourish. In fact, the absence of an operational legal system or violation of the rule of law permits terrible injustices to be visited upon the weakest and most vulnerable members of society.

Besides, the biblical values of justice and equality can also be found within the Indian Constitution, which provides for necessary safeguards in Part III to protect

and uphold the dignity of any individual.

The Constitution guarantees to the people certain basic human rights and freedoms, such as, inter alia, equal protection of laws, freedom of speech and expression, freedom of worship and religion, freedom of assembly and association, freedom to move freely and reside and settle anywhere in India, freedom to follow any occupation, trade, business or profession[101] .

In fact, the Constitution puts a high premium on upholding the rights of the individual and holds the State and its agencies accountable for any violations of the fundamental rights. For instance, the nature and extent of State's responsibility for the protection of human rights was indicated by the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) in its orders made in the case of the infamous communal carnage in Gujarat in 2002. The Commission observed:

"It is the primary and inescapable responsibility of the State to protect the right to life, liberty, equality and dignity of all of those who constitute it. It is also the responsibility of the State to ensure that such rights are not violated either through overt acts, or through abetment or negligence. It is a clear and emerging principle of human rights jurisprudence that the State is responsible not only for the acts of its own agents, but also for the acts of non-State players acting within its jurisdiction. The State is, in addition, responsible for any inaction that may cause or facilitate the violation of human rights".

It is worth praising how the Supreme Court in India has, through the judicial process, allowed social activism to thrive and has acted as the protector, guardian and interpreter of the Fundamental Rights. Public interest litigation in the areas of human rights, bonded laborer, labor laws, environmental protection, etc. has acted as a dynamic device to mitigate the sufferings of the poor, Dalit, tribals and marginalized sections of society.

As a matter of fact, a great body of jurisprudence has developed on the interpretation and enforcement of these fundamental rights. The Supreme Court of India has played the principal role in interpreting the Constitution and in maintaining a just balance between the rights of citizens and the requirements of the State. Commenting on its role the Supreme Court observed in Daryao:

"The fundamental rights are intended not only to protect individual's rights but they are based on high public policy. Liberty of the individual and the protection his Fundamental rights are the very essence of the democratic way of life adopted by the Constitution and it is the privilege of this Court to uphold those rights. The court would naturally refuse to circumscribe them or to curtail them except as provided by the Constitution itself" However, the law, in itself, is incapable of transforming society and rather relies on active social reform coupled with a conscientious judiciary and executive movement.

To quote Justice Sujata V. Manohar: ".It is not easy to eradicate deep seated cultural values or to alter traditions that perpetuate discrimination. It is fashionable to denigrate the role of law reform in bringing about social change. Obviously law, by itself, may not be enough. Law is only an instrument. It must be effectively used. And this effective use depends as much on a supportive judiciary as on the social will to change. An active social reform movement, if accompanied by legal reform, properly enforced, can transform society. And an effective social reform movement does need the help of law and a sympathetic judiciary to achieve its objectives.

An obvious example is the Sati eradication movement. Raja Ram Mohan Roy's and William Carey's campaign for eradication of Sati when backed by Lord Bentinck's Sati Regulation of 1829 brought the practice to an end. The extent of the practice can be gauged by the fact that prior to the Regulation, in Bengal Presidency alone there were 600 satis every year! An attempt to revive and glorify the practice in 1987, the Roop Kanwar episode was fortunately nipped in the bud with the commission of Sati Prevention Act, 1987. In contrast, in the absence of a strong social reform movement, Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961 has not checked the practice of dowry and its accompanying evils"[102].

And who better to carry out this great and awesome task but the Body of Christ. Living and working among the poor, the marginalized, the minorities and the isolated peoples of our world, it will be those who have the heart and mind of Christ who will best bear this burden. [103][5] For, we have a God given mandate to rise and stem the tide of power being used to abuse the most vulnerable sections of society.

Agencies such as the International Justice Mission (IJM) have successfully used the law to ensure rescue of children from brothels and bonded labor. In Radha's case[104], for instance, IJM's undercover investigators infiltrated the brothel and found Radha being held in forced prostitution. Using surveillance equipment, the IJM investigators were able to document her plight and refer the information to a trusted police contact. IJM then assisted the police in raiding the brothel and secured Radha's release. Although Radha was unable to return home, IJM found her a safe government home, free from daily abuse.

Christian community involved in various aspects of transformational mission should work in close quarters with local governing bodies, lives; indeed societies can be influenced by the values of the Kingdom of God and be transformed. For, each such initiative serves to reaffirms the inherent human dignity of each individual in the society and an opportunity to live out the gospel through words and deeds.

Chapter 7

The Tribals

Tribal Identity and Transformational Mission in India
Dino L. Touthangs[105]

The issue of Identity has witnessed violent eruptions of passion and power all over the world. "Identity is understood in general as a set of external features and internal traits which, negatively, distinguishes an individual or group of people from others, and positively, renders uniqueness through specific characteristics."[106]

In contemporary India the particular issue of tribal identity has occupied centre stage of much discussion and debate. Various tribal movements in different parts of India demand constitutional recognition, autonomy, statehood and self determination. The claims for independence by Tribals can he interpreted as a demand for survival by a distinct group of people for they perceive their very existence is being threatened. This demand is strengthened by the existence of an inter-tribal network that extends across India educating Tribal people to deepen their understanding of their own distinct identity. The question of Tribal identity in India is therefore an anthropological, sociological, political and missiological issue.

Who Are The Tribals Of India?

Tribals are one of the most studied communities in India, and approximately seventy of the tribes have some ethnographic account written about them. However, there is no scientific treatment of the concept of tribe in India. The term "tribe" is not defined in the constitution of India nor is there a satisfactory definition found else where, it is an administrative concept used widely but not defined.

'To an ordinary man the word "tribe" or "tribal" suggests simple folks living in the hills and forests: to some people who are better informed, it signifies colorful folks famous for their song and dance; to an administrator, it means a group of citizens who are the special responsibility of the President of India.: to an anthropologist, it indicates a special field of study of a social phenomenon.[107](2) In their own ways all these impressions are correct. Members of some tribal communities in India who met in Shiliong in 1962 described a Tribe as "an indigenous, homogeneous unit, speaking in a common language, claiming a common ancestry, living in a particular geographical area, backward in technology, pre-literate, loyally observing social and political customs based on kinship."[108] (3)

Though there may be no common agreement on a single definition of the word "tribe" or "tribal", the Tribals in India are treated as distinct and different from the majority of the Indian population. They are called the Adivasis or the Aboriginals accrediting them as the indigenous people.

Except for a few communities, the Tribals had lived in isolation from the dominant Hindu caste groups all through history and do not suffer from any negative stigma since they have not been included in the Hindu hierarchy which is guarded and controlled by pollution and purification laws. Tribals are categorized as ethnic minorities and treated as a backward and underdeveloped section of society. For the purpose of special treatment, economic benefits and reservation, the Government of India recognized the Tribals as Scheduled Tribes. There are also some Tribal groups who are not listed in the scheduled Tribes lists but are considered Tribals.

Tribal Identity and Its Components

Tribal identity in India is based on many components, the most important ones being land, forest, religion, culture, ethnicity and power. Land is looked upon by most Tribal groups not only as the source of their livelihood, but also as the inevitable nexus for their identity. In addition to economic factors the identity of Tribal communities is closely associated with the territories inhabited by them. The importance of land and forest can only be properly understood in the context of the tribal economy where about 90% of the population is engaged in cultivation. Different aspects of tribal life and culture are closely connected with the land and forests.

Religion and culture play a very important role in the communitarian life of Tribal society. Religious rites and rituals are central in the life of a Tribal community. The social life of Tribal society has a strong religious background which holds the community together and gives the community a distinct identity. Culture gives Tribal people a framework of meaning which is preserved in language, thought patterns, ways of life, attitudes, symbols and is celebrated in art, song, music, dance, drama and life. If religion is the key to the unity and cohesion in Tribal society, culture is the collective memory and heritage handed down from generation to generation which helps to maintain a distinct identity and character.

Ethnicity, ethnic territory and political power have recently become very crucial components of shaping Tribal identity in India. Many groups prefer to he recognized and addressed by Tribal names rather than simply as the officially designated “Scheduled Tribe”. This shows how important an ethnic name is to Tribal people. The demands and desires for ethnic territories are closely linked with Tribal identity. The importance of political power for establishing and shaping the Tribal identity is also a very crucial issue today.

Though the Tribals of India generally lived in isolation, many of them have come into contact with different people and cultural groups throughout their long history. As a result of such contacts Tribal communities have gone through a process in which their identity has been affected and even altered. Dr. Nirmal Minz, himself a Tribal, has written a number of articles on the Tribals of India and their concerns.

He has identified three models or processes that have had a significant impact on Tribal communities. These are: Sanskritization (or Hinduization), Missionization (or Christianization) and Modernization (or Industrialization and Urbanization)[109] (4). Governments have treated the Tribals in a variety of ways. There have been policies of isolation and most recently, policies of integration.

Tribal Identity and Christian Mission in The Past

It is about one hundred and fifty years since Christian missionary work amongst the Tribals began. Today a large concentration of Tribal Christians are found in north-central India consisting of the Jharkhand areas of Bihar, Orissa, MP and West Bengal and the seven states of North-east India. Around 10% of the Tribals follow Christianity and Tribal Christians constitute some 15% of the total Christian population in India.

There is an opinion, especially amongst the dominant Hindu castes, that Christian mission has destroyed Tribal culture and heritage which in turn has had an adverse effect on their identity. They say that as Tribal people accept Christianity, they abandon their traditional religion and culture and have thus become "detribalized". Every now and then there has been a call against Tribal conversion to Christianity, and a demand for stopping the activities of Christian mission amongst the Tribals.

It is true that Christianity has brought division in Tribal society. Christian tribals no longer participate in the Tribal religious rituals or in many cultural activities expressed in music, song, dance and drama. There is also division between the traditional Tribals who stand for strict adherence to customs and cultures, and the Christian Tribals who, in the light of the new awakening and western values, have became more liberal in their outlook and interpretation of life.

While it is true that to some extent Christian mission in the past has contributed to the demise of some customs and practices of the Tribals, Christianity has also had a positive impact on Tribal people's lives. Christian faith and values have helped to reshape Tribal people's lives in a way that gives them a new meaning and interpretation of their identity. It was Christian mission that gave the Tribals of India the written language, education, medical services, economic improvement, political awareness and above all, spiritual liberation. All these things contributed to the strengthening and maintenance of the Tribal identity in India. Four significant positive effects of Christian mission amongst the Tribals were highlighted in a study published in 1965 by the CIRSC, Bangalore, in a book entitled Tribal Awakening:-

"First, because of Christian mission involvement, the Tribals became owners of land as they were freed from forced labor and other economic injustices previously done to them. Second, Christianity gave the Tribals a new model of relating to their neighbor. Third, the Tribals were freed

from inferiority complexes and became self confident through literacy and education provided by the Christian mission. Fourth, the Tribals got spiritual freedom in Christian faith which liberated them from the psychology of fear and enabled them to enjoy life to its fullest."[110] (5).

Tribal Identity and Contemporary Christian Mission

In the last few years there has been an identity crisis amongst the Tribals of India. In the past, religion and culture were crucial elements for maintaining Tribal identity. Today, the question of land, ethnicity, ethnic territory and political power has become important issues for Tribal identity in India. In the past, Christian mission was successful in giving a new interpretation to Tribal religion and culture in such a way that their identity was strengthened and crystallized by Christianity. Today contemporary Christian mission needs to offer a Christian framework and interpretation on land, ethnicity, ethnic territory and political power. There is a danger that if contemporary Christian mission does not provide the framework for thinking and action on these issues, the Tribals of India will look to other quarters which may be totally opposed to Christian faith and teaching.

What does it mean for contemporary Christian mission to work among the Tribals of India who have a distinct identity and yet to emphasize their common identity with the other human beings? What strategies and principles need to be followed by contemporary Christian mission working among the Tribals so that there is a meaningful integration of Tribal customs a culture into the Christian faith in a way that produce proud Tribal Christians and not detribalized Christians as alleged by some? Christian faith must be present in the ideology, language, idioms, traditions and history of the Tribal society so that Christianity is indigenized and contextualized to a Tribal, situation rather than Christianity taking the Tribals away from their context. There is a need for recognition and appreciation of Tribal life and culture. The commonalties between Tribal life and Christian faith need to he recognized. I this way Christianity will be able to be presented as fulfillment of Tribal aspirations and longings.

The majority of Tribals in India still live in poverty, suffering economic hardship and exploitation. Therefore there is the challenge for contemporary Christian mission amongst the Tribals to be concerned with economic issues and justice.

Among Tribal Christians the issue of what it means to be a Tribal with a distinct identity, and also a Christian who has a common identity with other people across the racial, linguistic, cultural and ethnic differences is of great significance. What are the implications of being Tribal Christian and one's understanding and interpretation of ethnic territorial identity and the assertion for Tribal political power? Is there a danger that in asserting distinct Tribal identity there is too much of what we call ethnocentrism where there is

no place for other identities to co-exist? If that has happened is it consistent with Christian belief and teaching? What are Biblical teachings on land rights and ownership? These and many other crucial issues on land, ethnicity, ethnic territory and political power which are closely linked with Tribal identity must be given serious thought and consideration by the contemporary Christian mission among the Tribals of India today.

Conclusion

This article argues that the Tribals of India are distinct people with a distinct identity. Through contact with other peoples and cultures the Tribals underwent a process in which their identity was reconstructed. The impact of Christianity on Tribal identity has been significant, in many ways Christian mission has preserved and strengthened the Tribal identity by giving new meaning and interpretation to the Tribal identity. Issues such as ethnicity, ethnic territory and political power has become such important issues in regards to Tribal identity that contemporary Christian mission must provide the framework for interpreting Tribal identity in the light of Christian teaching and practice.

Identity and Dignity

Identity and dignity are key categories in India for interpreting and applying the gospel- defined by Jesus as good news to the poor. The Samaritan women suffered from racial and gender discrimination was shocked by disbelief when Jesus asked her for a drink of water that she responded, "How is it that you, a Jew, ask a drink of me, a woman of Samaria" (John 4:9). Jesus the friend of tax collectors, the prostitutes and the drunkards crossed status boundaries as he ate with them and questioned the discrepancy shown to them by the society of his day.

Identity answers the question 'Who am I?' while dignity answers the question 'What am I worth?' The Bible makes the subject of identity the prior question. It emphasize that both the creation of humanity and redemption are acts of God's grace. There are no human elements however meritorious or sinful involved in our creation or redemption. Grace confers identity. The Seventy-two messengers sent by Jesus returned excited by their experience of the reality of supernatural and spiritual power. Jesus admonished them that the ultimate issues of the Kingdom of God are not power issues, but the sheer privilege of entry into the Kingdom of God. The gospels illustrate that Jesus makes it clear that a person should have an identity that is not imposed, random or denied. As Stephen Mott describes, "Jesus names as 'the lost' those whom his objectors call 'sinners'. (cf. also Luke 15:6-7). The redefinition is significant. They are not sinners to be hated and driven away. They are lost, needing to be found and rejoiced over. 'Lost' implies a different status; there is something to be recovered. 'He is a son of Abraham' (v.9). He is neither a devil, nor less than human. He is a lost child of Abraham, the very criterion of membership in the community. The status boundaries that Jesus crossed are crucial to the

stability of a society. That is why he provoked hostility. Status is one of the most basic elements of asocial system. It is way of controlling people …To those who claim that Jesus' ministry was merely personal, we reply that he could not have done anything more basic to challenge institutions and social structures."[111]

If the Christian view that views humanity as the creation of God, redeemed by Christ and destined for eternal life through the resurrection is lost then identity tends to be grounded in worth. In a secular world view, the identity tends to be grounded in worth, in the accomplishments of a person; in their victories or failures as this example of George a Non Resident Indian (NRI) explains:" I was among the early immigrant to America from India, and although I stood among out among both whites and blacks in the country, I did not allow myself to feel like an alien. Racism and discrimination were certainly obstacles to overcome. The hurdles I faced as a consequence of my racial origin were not insurmountable. I was able to transcend my origins and was free to make of myself whatever my talents permitted. My experience is no different from that of most immigrants; each has succeeded because of his her self-reliance, independence, resourcefulness and pragmatism. That is why, in America, one is not asked who one's family is, but what one does. I have often wondered what it would take for Indian society to accept its members for their accomplishments, rather than for their social backgrounds."[112] When worth becomes the basis for determining identity the poor and weak are marginalized. The choices for investment then are determined by how much can an individual contribute to the market. George positions identity in worth but he questions the wisdom of social background determining dignity. In the Indian society caste is the most tyrannical way of controlling and annihilating the status of a person.

The Strangers Face

> When two Indians meet as strangers, 'the encounter is often a duel' writes Pavan Varma, to ascertain the caste, status in the hierarchy of power. 'Everything-response, behavior, body language, social niceties, form of address, receptivity-depends on an assessment of where the person stands on the scale of power and influence.'[113] For an Indian, superior and subordinate relationships 'have the character of eternal verity and moral imperative – (and the) automatic reverence for superiors is a nearly universal psycho-social fact.'[114] The entire worth of a person is dependent on the position he occupies on a hierarchical scale. In Hinduism identity is dependent upon worth, and worth is determined as people are born and reborn in accordance with their karmas, the quality of their deeds.
>
> Human dignity cannot be given to a person by the kindness of others. It involves equality,

freedom and economic empowerment and relations of mutual respect among people and a conscious participation in the life of the society. Vinoth Ramachandran remarks that, "For those outside the Brahmanical tradition in India, Hindu 'hierarchical relativism' is experienced as deeply oppressive, not only in its caste expression, but also in its resistance to criticism. Those who have initiated change have had to step out of Hindu society, and then their difference is later absorbed into what is now redefined as the Hindu mainstream. The Buddha and Buddhist monasticism, Jain vegetarianism and non-violence, local tribal deities and religious myths have all suffered the same absorption. Here it seems that particularity, difference and critique are swallowed up in a suffocating universalism."[115]

Indian society advocates toleration while maintaining an otherwise intolerant cruel society. Who can leave the caste hierarchy and claim the benefits of toleration? Who can vertically challenge and aspire for the higher caste in the hierarchy and expect accommodation? The characteristics of "accommodation" to be found in a holistically conceived hierarchical society are not the same as those, which will bring about a liberal egalitarian society.[116]

> M. M. Thomas writes: "Considering the fact that the Christian Mission were the first in many parts of India to treat the untouchables as human beings, and to bring them the gospel of their dignity in Christ as well as education, Christianity has played a part in arousing and strengthening Anti-Brahmanism… And this in turn awoke the Brahmin and other caste Hindu leadership to the need of putting the Hindu household itself in order by social and religious reform …fear of Christianity has been the beginning of social wisdom for Hinduism."[117]

Confront Caste Identity

Vengal Chakkarai a high caste Hindu convert to Christ advocated that the church should 'confront Hinduism on the plains of life.' By this he meant confronting the caste oppression and exploitation. The household of Jesus Christ is duty bound to spread social equality, and the practice of caste divisions in the church runs counter to the teachings of Jesus Christ who said, "there is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ" (Gal.3: 28). Caste thinking is in some of our churches. Many scholars have documented it. Anantha Krishna Iyer, outlining the caste oriented manners and customs of Syrian Christians, writes, "Each division among the Syrian Christians has

become, as in Hindu caste, an endogamous sect, with no intermarriage between the members of one sect and those of another, though no objection is made to inter-dining". [118] It is not uncommon that high caste Christians demand separation, for fear of pollution, from the Christians of Dalit origin. Reflecting on the opposition between 'the pure and the impure' in his classic exposition, *Homo Hierarchicus,* Louis Dumont has argued that this binary opposition is the ideological principal and the essence of the caste system.[119]

The Christian of Dalit origin speaks of triple discrimination of which they are victims. First, they are denied their government instituted reservation privileges when they publicly declare their allegiance to Jesus Christ. Second they encounter discrimination in the Church. Third the high caste uses the Dalits to persecute the Dalits who turn to Christ.

Dumont himself recognized the existence of caste among Non –Hindus as due to 'the proximity of the Hindu environment, which predominates both generally and regionally.'[120] But isn't this proximity an opportunity for the church community to work for cultural transformation of India. As we saw earlier the challenge and warning of Christ rings loud and clear for his disciples for whom he said, "You are the salt of the earth,' since you cannot season it, tasteless salt "is no longer good for anything, but is thrown out and trampled under foot" (Matthew 5:13). The Church in India must exemplify obedience by engagement in cultural transformation which is not an option.

Will caste system survive in India? This question has been debated several times over for a century and a half now. There are various voices answering this question. Harold Gould writes, 'It …appears very unlikely that so admirable an adaptive structure as caste is in any serious danger of ever disappearing completely.'[121] N. Jayaram is of the opinion,

> "Its religious basis may wane, its systemic rigor may weaken; but its social (kinship) basis will persist, and its group connotation will gain strength. As far as its interface with Hinduism is concerned, though Hinduism may lose meaning as a justificatory ideology for the hierarchy and inequalities of the system, its cultural crux will persist and crystallize. And, Hinduism will benefit more from the survival of caste than caste from Hinduism"[122].

However the Dalits have a different approach to caste system which is succinctly summarized by Bhagwan Das, who challenges the dehumanizing caste identity, as he writes,

> "Upper caste Hindus have a vested interest in maintaining and perpetuating caste. If caste goes, Hinduism will die. With the Dalits it is just the opposite. Caste is the greatest obstacle in the way of their unity and progress. If they do

not destroy caste, caste will destroy them. The Hindus have no real sympathy with them. They need them only to do dirty work and to render them friendless by pitting them against the Muslims one day, against Sikhs the next day and may be against the Christians very soon." He proposes that "in the eradication of caste and adoption of the right code of conduct based on equality, compassion, loving kindness and justice lays their salvation."[123]

The laudable list of transformational values that Bhagwan Das has proposed, and as he has observed, are not part of Hindu culture.

Economic projects as such do not help poor people develop the crucial sense of self worth. Rather the development of self-worth is the foundation for every other human growth. This makes the gospel so vital for change. The gospel transforms the perception of the poor from worthless failures to an appreciation that in Christ they have their own and other people worth. V. T. Rajshekar, a non-Christian leader of Dalits, suggests for the Dalits, "Poverty is not the number one problem. People cannot live by bread alone. They want the self-respect which is denied under Hinduism. They will get it the moment they get out of Hinduism and convert to other religions."[124]

Identity in Community

Identity is not first of all an individual identity, although the secular world promotes individual identity. The philosopher of individual freedom, Jean-Paul Sartre, claims that when we encounter a stranger we come upon a look that threatens us because the other might define us and take away our identity and freedom. On the other hand the Christian Identity is affirmed through relationships in the new household of Christ. When people are alienated from their true identity, the gospel of Christ 'reconciles them with their true selves as God intends them to be, stewards of creation and children of God.'[125] The heavenly Father calls those who repent to form a new community headed by the Son of God, and created by the Spirit of God. The household of Christ is made up of the lost who have accepted Jesus as Lord and Messiah, and been united by the Spirit. These people have equal spiritual standing. Because all believers are united by faith to Christ (Gal. 3:29), membership and opportunities in the household are not based on political affiliation, economic status, ethnicity or educational attainment. Believing women and men in the household of Christ are all priests enjoying equal access to God. The Church needs to live the new values of God's kingdom. This enables them to participate in authentic social transformation.

The category of identity gives a criterion for analyzing and identifying oppression. Identity cannot be provided by relief, welfare, or development projects. Identity is provided by the gospel. That is why the gospel is so primary to Christian involvement in any transformation. Identity

is not left in the abstract. It is expressed in a new community where old barriers are broken down. Only in Christ can people be given that new identity as sons and daughters of God the father.

Nagaland Transformation: From Head Hunters to Hallelujah Singers
Rev. Bendangtoshi[126]

Referred to as the "Switzerland of the East" because of its beautiful hills and scenic beauty, Nagaland is a strip of mountainous territory located in the extreme North – Eastern end of India, bounded by Myanmar in the east; Assam in the west; Arunachal Pradesh and part of Assam in the North with Manipur in the south.

During the British colonial rule many tribal groups were amalgamated into one administrative region in North East India and Nagaland was one of them. Nagaland received statehood and was inaugurated as the 16th state of the Indian Union on the 1st of December 1963. Nagaland is inhabited by sixteen major tribes along with other sub tribes. Each tribe has its own customs, language and dress. It has a rich oral tradition, which has been handed down from generations.

It has an Airport and a railhead, which connects Nagaland with the rest of the country.

The Naga Society before the Gospel: Social Life

Naga's were animists and believed in a supreme spirit which created the world. Enslaved by this belief in an unknown power or spirit, they were very superstitious that their whole life was surrounded by both good and bad powers.

Their cultural practices of head hunting meant that they had to live on hill tops for security reasons. They lived in thatched houses which were neither free from natural or fires created by other enemy tribes. These villages were strongly fortified and well guarded by wooden gates with heavy stone fencing for defense against the enemy attacks. The village was and still is headed by the village chief with a council comprising of clan representatives.

The unmarried young men and women were sent to dormitories, where they are taught art and discipline, recreation and all the important ceremonial activities. The 'dormitory life' was a very important part of the young people.

Head hunting was an important factor in social life; though it was not practiced by members of the same village. The more heads a warrior obtained from the enemy tribe, the higher the status and respect he would gain. The concept of headhunting (to bring home the head of the enemy killed) was to gain individual glory and prosperity. When a young man desired to be married, he would show himself as a hero to his intended bride by displaying the number of heads he had collected. And the more heads he had to his credit the more she admired him.

Art and Culture

The arts and culture of Nagaland reflects the socio-cultural mirror of the Naga people. Each community has its own cultural identity as for dress, ornaments, social customs, festivals, amusements and ceremonies relating to the life after death. They have a rich variety of textiles using plants and vegetables dyes vibrantly hued threads were inter-woven forming eye-catching designs, which are unique to each community. A person's status could be discerned by the patterns on the textiles.

How Has The Gospel Transformed The Nagas?

It was not till 1872 that serious attention was given to sharing the gospel with the Naga people. Rev. and Mrs. Clark and Mr. and Mrs. Godula Brown were the pioneer missionaries who worked in Nagaland[127].

On one occasion, having seen Clark working with the mission press and teaching the children, the leader of the group, requested him saying, "come up to our village and teach our children" Dr. Clark who had been receiving information from the Assamese friends about the Nagas, that they were ferocious people, that they killed people even for petty reason, replied, "I want to keep my head on my body, not on your house top". However once assured of their protection, there was no turning back. The invitation turned out to be the Macedonian call to the early missionary.

A joint venture of Dr. Clark and Mr. Godula ushered in a new era for the Naga people. Clark's intense love for the people and Godula's beautiful voice helped them to win their way into the hearts of the Naga people.

The Gospel has changed the individual and social life of the Nagas. As the Gospel began to be accepted by the Nagas, the Christian value system greatly influenced the individual attitudes and the social structures. The Christians stopped drinking local brewed beer and stopped participating in the revelry of drinking and dancing during festivals. The prior superstitions that ruled the minds of the Nagas were replaced with a trust and dependence on the living God. The practice of head hunting which created a deep mistrust and fear of the Nagas was substituted by a love for their neighbours and an eagerness to share the gospel.

The Christian Nagas took part in the process of spreading the Good News to all the people of Nagaland in order that peace and prosperity may be experienced by all the tribes. The role of the Church in transforming Nagaland has been very significant. The Church continues to endeavor to exercise her Mission to all Nagas in the fields of socio-economic development, gender equality and Education.

Role of the Church in Nagaland's Socio-Political Set-Up

Despite the transformation of Nagaland through the gospel, it still faces social, cultural and political problems. The state occupies a strategic place geographically

and the abundant resources attract people from other states and immigrants. A recent study reveals that there are more than 20,000 foreign nationals in Nagaland. Of these, Bangladeshis and Nepalis account for the maximum number of immigrants. This has created a negative impact as many of the immigrants exploit the Nagas, who are by nature simple and honest. This disturbs the socio-cultural and political development of their lives and raises lot of social issues and creates problems. In the mid 1950s the situation in Nagaland greatly deteriorated politically. The Church played an active role to bring peace in Nagaland. A group of Naga Church leaders formed 'Naga Church Ministers Mission for Peace'. They preached peace and non-violence in Churches and other public places. The Church has also been instrumental in negotiations with the insurgent groups of Nagaland. They also gave messages of peace to those in the Armed Resistance who were in the underground camps. In September 1964, a cease-fire agreement was reached between the Indian Government and the Naga insurgency groups[128].

Some of the pressing issues Nagaland is facing today are drug addiction, alcohol abuse, HIV/AIDS, stress in families, crime and violence, insurgent movements and others.

In response to these challenges the Church of Nagaland is constantly praying and working towards a better Nagaland. While maintaining the denominational and cultural distinction of the churches and tribes the Christians are striving to build a society that is essentially characterized by integrity and responsibility. The voice of the Church in Nagaland gives peace and hope to its citizens and is transforming lives and society.

During "Nagaland Transformation"[129] held in November, 2003 in Kohima, the churches and Christian Non Governmental organizations (NGO's) came together and pledged the following Prayer of Commitment:

> As our 'Celebration of Faith in Jesus Christ' under the banner of Nagaland Transformation, comes to the end, we, the participants, offer ourselves before God to continue in the endeavour of transforming Nagaland by the power of God, the Holy Spirit.
>
> The beginning may be small but, even as the kingdom of heaven is liked by the 'yeast in the dough' we make this prayer of commitment towards the transformed future.
>
> We shall constantly pray and work for the transformation of Nagaland.
>
> While maintaining our denominational and cultural distinction, we shall regard one other as brothers and sisters in the family of God.
>
> We shall, as we ought to, strive to build a society that is essentially characterized by the integrity,

responsibility and cheerfulness.

We shall, come what circumstances, work in honesty and transparency in all our respective offices and work places.

God has blessed our land with plenty-rich forests, variety of flora and fauna, mineral and human resources. We shall be faithful stewards of God's rich blessings- to utilize them judiciously as God would have us use and not engage n mindless destruction and reckless exploitation

Human beings are the crown of God's creation because we bear the image of God. Therefore, except to appreciate and to bless we continue to denounce hate, abuse, suppression and bloodshed.

We shall urge ourselves and others too to uphold truthfulness and honesty in trading and business transaction.

By being law abiding citizens of the state we shall submit ourselves to the authority of the civil government. At the same time as responsible citizens and people of God we shall oppose policies and practices that stand against the Kingdom of God and his righteousness.

Today, we are witnessing some of the worst crisis in various forms such as drug addiction, alcohol abuse, dreaded communicable diseases, stress in families, crime and violence and others. While we decry such appalling situations it shall be our endeavour to take to people of such society the hope in Jesus Christ.

Chapter 8

Urban Transformational Mission in India, Atul Y Aghamkar[130]

Introduction

Urbanization of Christian missions is an urgent and serious need. Cities determine the destiny of nations, and their influence on the every day affairs of individuals is incalculable. Beyond question, the new chapter in world and mission history is entitled 'Cities' and the church of tomorrow will be largely an urban church.[131]

These were prophetic words pronounced by two prominent North American urban mission thinkers two decades ago. What was stated twenty years ago is more relevant today because for the first time we are living in a world that is predominantly urban. As rightly observed by John Palen, 'The first years of the twenty-first century make a major transition to over half the world's population living in urban centers'.[132] Today Christians have no other option than to take the cities seriously, because the real battle for mission will be fought in cities and that too in the cities of Asia.

The world is rapidly becoming urbanized. At the beginning of the twentieth century, little over ten per cent of the world population lived in cities. However, at the beginning of this century, more than half of the world is living in cities. John Palen points out that this urban growth is primarily taking place in Asia, Africa and South America.[133] This means that the process of urbanization will affect the non-western world significantly since much of the Western Hemisphere is already urbanized. Therefore, the implications of urbanization for the non-western world are great. Although urbanization is not new, what is new is the degree and the speed with which non-western countries are becoming urban. Since urbanization is an irreversible trend, it is imperative that mission leaders are adequately informed about this emerging trend, and prepared and equipped for undertaking ministry among the growing urban population of India.

This paper attempts to reflect critically on the contemporary missions scene in the light of a rapidly urbanizing India and to develop a framework for theological and missiological reflections for doing mission in urban India.

1. Urban Scenario in India

Asia on the whole is rapidly turning urban. An increasing number of mega-cities have emerged in Asia. There was a time when most of the world-class cities were found only in Europe and North America, but this scene is changing rapidly. A significant number of mega-cities are found in Asia. It is estimated that by the beginning of the twenty-first century, Asia will have more city dwellers than any other continent. The process of urbanization took more than a century in Europe and North America, but given the speed at which Asia is becoming

urbanized it may take only a few decades.

India in south Asia is leading the way. Though India has been generally perceived to be a rural country, cities have been a part of it for centuries. Archaeological excavation shows that India had a well-developed Sindhu civilization with cities like Mohanjo Daro and Harappa. A number of ancient cities like Benaras, Ranchi and Madurai have survived till today. Most of these ancient cities in India were either religious centers or political and administrative hubs of ancient India.

With the advent of the British in India, the process of urbanization picked up speed with the creation of ‘cantonments'. These cantonments were developed adjacent to indigenous towns and cities. These came into being as well organized military, administrative and commercial centers of India. Initially, the concentration of British activities was primarily confined to port cities like Bombay, Calcutta and Madras, but gradually, as the British established themselves firmly in India, they also developed 'district headquarters' cities. Most of these cities were developed as administrative headquarters for the region. In this way the British contributed to the process of urbanization in India.

The post-colonial phase of urbanization can be connected with industrialization. It may be argued that cities have grown rapidly due to industrialization. Thus, with the emergence of industry in certain regions of India, urbanization spread rapidly. The most industrialized regions became the most urbanized regions.[134] This explains why states like Maharashtra, Gujarat and Tamil Nadu, being leading industrial states, also have a high percentage of urban population. The impact of industrialization in India had to wait for about a couple of decades. It was only in the early seventies that rapid urbanization began to grip India. Millions of rural people are drawn to our industrial cities. Heavy migration of the rural population to the industrial centers of India has accelerated during the last three decades. Hence what Bogue and Zachariah said is true: 'A discussion of urbanization in India fundamentally is a discussion of net rural-to-urban migration'.[135] Social scientists call this the 'pull factor' in migration.

Today, India claims to have almost one third of its population living in the cities. This means over 280 million Indians are urban dwellers. These urban people by and large are very open to new ideas, values and practices. Not only do most urban people come under modern ideologies of secularism, modernity and rationalism, but these ideologies directly or indirectly influence their attitude and behavior. Of course, the reality of increasing fundamentalism, also at rise in Indian cities, cannot be neglected.

Looking at the contemporary Christian scene in India, we find that the epicenter of Christianity is moving city-ward. This trend is more evident in the last thirty years or so. The 1981 Census of India has also recorded this trend. According to this Census figures, the city of Madras (now

Chennai) had 10.0 per cent Christian population, whereas Bombay (now Mumbai) had 7.0 per cent and Bangalore 6.71 per cent.[136] Apart from these major urban centers, significant Christian population is also found in other metropolitan areas. For example the estimated Christian population of Maharashtra state is 885,000. Out of this about half of the Christian population is found in Bombay alone. One third of Maharashtra state's Christian population is distributed between the districts of Thane and Pune. This means that almost two thirds of the total Christian population of Maharashtra is found in three cities and their vicinities. This is indicative of the fact that Christianity in India is rapidly becoming an urban faith and this is where the challenges lie. Since India has a growing number of Christians living in cities, they must be informed and equipped to minister to the urban population effectively.

2. Contemporary Mission Scene in India

The missions scene in India has also drastically changed. Traditionally, India was considered as a mission field, but now along with being a mission field, India has also become a significant missionary force. The post-independent India has witnessed a slow but steady indigenous missionary movement. Today, we have more cross-cultural missionaries in India than ever before. There are at least 200 indigenous missionary societies with about 40,000 indigenous missionaries working cross culturally in India, making India one of the leading missionary sending countries in the world.[137]

A close scrutiny of the focus of these indigenous missionary societies uncovers the fact that almost ninety to ninety five percent of them are ministering among the Dalit and marginalized tribal population of India. A very small percentage of this indigenous missionary force is working among the city people. The Indian indigenous missionary force is still strongly rural bound in their focus and practice. Although it is evident that a very significant number of the unreached people are found in our Indian cities, we still tend to glamorize sending missionaries to the uttermost parts of India. What we need to realize is the fact that the people of the uttermost parts have been drawn to our cities. As a matter of fact, more unreached, untouched, and unevangelized people are increasingly found in our cities.

Even in pastoral ministry we are witnessing staggering changes. Traditional urban churches were stagnant for a while because they hardly undertook any serious outreach program beyond their own constituencies. With enormous church buildings at the heart of various cities, these churches were almost in danger of becoming monuments due to fizzling out Christian populations. In recent decades, however, urban churches in India in general and south Indian urban churches in particular, have been experiencing tremendous growth. Many new churches have been mushrooming over a decade or so in major metropolitan areas of India. This growth is primarily due to rural migrants who by and large were Christians

prior to moving into the city. As these migrants move into the city, they are added into the existing churches. In reality, most of these churches are growing because of rural-urban migration and not necessarily because of conversions – though there are some exceptions to this reality.

It is disturbing to note that very little is being done for the cities and the city people from the Christian perspective in India. Perhaps one of the major reasons for this neglect is the lack of information about the growing urban trends in India. But more particularly, it is due to the fact that the mission scene in India is dominated by mission practitioners and very few of them are able to understand, articulate and reflect on contemporary urban realities from theological and missiological perspectives.

3. The Need of Theological/ Missiological Reflections

Urban theology/missiology is a comparatively new field of study and not much literature has been produced in this area. What is available today is primarily written from the North American and European perspectives. Hence their applicability in the Indian context is limited. Theological reflection on Indian cities is rare, if not non-existent. Even though much contextual theology has been produced in India, Indian theologians very rarely address urban issues and concerns. As aptly stated by Henry Koetsier, 'There has been little theological analysis and reflection on what is happening in cities. It seems as if theology has lost interest in the world of the modern city. Hence, churches have not been able to cope with the situation in the cities. They ... have not been willing to reflect critically and creatively on the challenges posed by them in the cities'.[138] What Koetsier said about the European situation is true with the Indian situation too.

To make any substantial impact on our cities, we need to reflect on them both theologically and missiologically. This reflection will eventually percolate into mission/ministry practice. Most Indian theological reflection either neglects missiology, or underestimates its importance. 'Just as the church ceases to be church if it is not a missionary, theology ceases to be theology if it loses its missionary character'.[139] There is a need of a missiological agenda for theology rather than just a theological agenda for mission. Looking at the theological scene in India one is amazed to find out how little theological reflection is done from a missiological perspective. Just mere theological reflection will not take the Church too far, unless it is grounded in missiology. 'The kind of mission work that pleases God and can expect his blessing is done carefully, on sound Biblical foundations. Developing a theology of the city is one of the ways to survive in urban ministry'.[140] It is not sufficient to undertake mere sociological analysis of the city, but the city has to be exegeted missiologically.

The Indian urban context is not yet seriously perceived by theologians from a missionary perspective. Because there is a great dearth of urban theological reflection,

most mission practitioners tend to continue to do what has been traditionally carried out on the mission field. Hence most of them keep working among the Dalits and tribals. Till recently, India was overwhelmingly a rural/tribal country; therefore, the major emphasis was given on reaching the rural tribal people. The urban context has not received sufficient attention from theologians. Most of the nineteenth and early twentieth century theologians reflected on the Bible from a non-urban perspective. Even though most theologians lived and worked in the cities, they rarely reflected on the city. This led to neglect in the development of an urban theology.

Most urban churches and missionary societies are slow to awaken to the challenges of a rapidly expanding urban reality in India. And yet the outburst of urban activities is evident in most Indian cities. Koetsier's warning is important when he says, 'The pace of urbanization is so rapid that there is the danger that the urgency of the task will cause them to neglect Biblical foundations. The needs in the city are so many and so pressing that we are tempted to move in multiple directions without pausing to take our theological bearings'.[141] This probably is happening in most cities of India where a lot of Christian activities are taking place without much theological reflection. It is comparatively easy and self satisfying to respond to the needs and demands of the city and to start some ministry without reflecting theologically on that ministry. The problem of urban theology in the Indian context is made more acute due to the complexity of the urban context. Looking at the city from the perspective of the church, which is apparently weak and divided, also adds to these complexities.

There is a general tendency of churches to run away from this theological challenge. Most pastors and mission practitioners ignore the awesome challenges. Although the majority of Christian churches and theologians are physically in the city, they tend to neglect the city for all practical purposes. They dwell in the city, but do not take the city seriously either theologically or ministerially. What little attention is given to urban ministry tends to focus on methods and statistics rather than on foundational questions that are biblical and theological in nature. There is a great need for studying Scripture, and interpreting its message in the urban context and developing a theology that is relevant for the ministry/mission in the city.

Further, what reflections we do have on the city are also inadequate. Harvie Conn cites hermeneutical carelessness as one more reason for a lack of theological reflection on the city. He describes the biblical study as 'spotty' and sometimes eccentric. He states: 'Some try to handle the overall thrust of the Bible with a concentration on the history of several cities – Sodom and Gomorrah, Nineveh, Babylon, and Jerusalem. Antioch becomes a model from which to draw strategic principles for contemporary urban church planting and growth'.[142] Conn further strongly asserts that, 'The temptation is strong to make restricted Biblical passages on the city say more than they do.

Hermeneutical carelessness can miss larger Biblical themes into which urban concerns are gathered'.[143] This kind of hermeneutical short-cut leads to shabby urban theology.

4. Biblical Perspectives of Urban Mission

The Bible begins in the garden and ends in the city – the heavenly city. A systematic reading of the Bible makes it very evident that the Bible is overwhelmingly an urban book. The world in which most of the Bible was written was dominated by its cities. After the story of the creation and fall, the Bible mentions the first city that was ever built by man (Gen 4:17). Then onward the importance the Bible gives to urban places, urban contexts, and urban people is clearly seen. If we look at the Bible through urban glasses, we will notice that from the book of Genesis to the book of Revelation, the Bible apparently is pro-urban. Ray Bakke found 1,200 references to cities in the Bible, with at least 119 specific cities mentioned by name.[144] Prominent biblical characters are seen as urban dwellers, urban ministers and urban planners. Hence the ultimate imagery of the Bible is strongly urban.[145] Understanding this urban emphasis of the Bible is crucial for our ministry in the city.

The Biblical account of the city is not uniform but it demonstrates amazing contrasts and dichotomies. On the one hand, cities are portrayed as symbols of human arrogance, pride and self-sufficiency. Cities are understood as a mark of man's success and advance against God.[146] On the other hand, cities are also a manifestation of the creativity of God. They are a symbol of the blessings God has given to humanity to multiply and dominate the earth. They are symbols of humanity's creativity and vitality.[147] At the same time, cities are seen as symbols of evil and injustice, and sometimes as symbols of redemption and grace. The tension between good and evil in cities is quite evident and runs throughout the Bible. The presence of saturated evil, wickedness and unjust systems often tend to dominate Biblical cities, whereas the presence of God and his people continue to mark the difference in evil-dominated cities. Linthicum puts it well when he says: 'The essential Old Testament assumption about the city is that it is the battleground between Yahweh and Baal. The essential New Testament assumption is that the city struggles between God and Satan'.[148] However, most cities mentioned in the Bible are not depicted as totally evil. Some element of good is often seen in every city, even in a city like Sodom. At the same time, we also find no city that is totally good and godly – not even Jerusalem. It is important to note that cities are portrayed as being both good and evil, since often the negative impression and perspective of the city tends to dominate theological writings.

The New Testament portrays cities as significant and strategic, especially when it comes to Paul's life and ministry. Great importance is attributed to the city and urban people. 'The Mission movement of the New Testament was primarily an urban

movement' states Greenway.[149] Jesus' birth, ministry, passion, crucifixion, resurrection and ascension took place primarily in the urban contexts of Jerusalem, Nazareth, Bethany, Cana, Jericho and Sychar. Luke takes note of this when he states that Jesus was born in the city of David (Lk. 2:4,11) and went around preaching in all the cities and towns (Lk. 8:1), and great multitudes of people came to listen to him from every city (Lk. 8:4). Even casual reading of the Gospels show how frequently Jesus visited, ministered and taught in the cities and ministered to city people. Jesus demonstrated equal love and compassion for the city people as he did for rural people. Apart from having a deep concern for the poor and destitute rural people, Jesus significantly ministered to urban dwellers. As a matter of fact, he did not bypass the rich and the affluent.

Early Christian faith moved smoothly from cities of Palestine to cities of the Roman Empire and it was Paul and his urban strategy which were crucial in the process. Paul was an urban person, who opted to minister primarily in the cities of his time. 'All of the cities, or towns, in which he planted churches were centers of Roman administration, of Greek civilization, of Jewish influence, or of some commercial importance'.[150] While keeping his focus initially on the Jewish people in the Diaspora, he began targeting 'God fearing' urban Gentiles. Consequently, Paul established churches among this receptive Gentile population of Asia Minor.

These churches were basically house churches that included poor, slaves, and other ignorant people. But Paul's letters provide us with some glimpse of early church composition that included business people, intellectuals, and strategically important people. Paul's focus was on strategic urban dwellers, who had potential to make a difference in their generation. An influential segment of Roman society was targeted by Paul, although the appeal of the Gospel was greater to the poor and the marginalized. 'The early church contained not only "unlearned and ignorant men" but many of the rich priesthood, the wife of Herod's steward and one of his youthful amici, leading Pharisees, rich Cypriots like Barnabas and prominent provincials like Paul'.[151] We notice Paul making conscious efforts in reaching the educated, intellectuals, philosophers and elite of the urban society. Often he is seen arguing, persuading and challenging educated, thinking and affluent people to consider the claims of Christ. The fact that he was accompanied by highly educated team members like physician Luke, well respected and credible Barnabas, bi-cultural and probably multi-lingual John Mark indicates his desire to identify with the upper level of urban society. This fact is further strengthened by the way in which he appointed young urban men like Timothy and Titus to pastor urban churches in Ephesus and Crete.[152] Paul focused on urban family networks. His approach to urban people was family based. He reached urban families through household evangelism and planted house churches in different cities of Asia Minor. This was

probably done keeping in mind the potential of urban families to network within the cities but with their counterparts back in rural areas. That is why Paul could claim to have reached all the provinces of Asia Minor, though he had only ministered in key cities of these provinces.

5. Three Representative Views

To help structure a biblical view of the city, we have selected three fairly representative works that provide three quite different scriptural views of the city.

The first view contends that the city is evil. Although this view has been consciously or unconsciously prevalent for some time, it was Jaques Ellul who voiced it in his classic book *The Meaning of the City.* Ellul is thorough and extensive in tracing the city through the Old and New Testaments. Consequently, he is widely quoted in urban literature. His biblical view of the city is very pessimistic. He sees the city as the ultimate expression of humanity's rejection of God. Cain, a murderer, built the first city. The city is inherently evil. Real hope is possible only with the coming of the New Jerusalem. Ellul's theology seems to reflect the pessimism and despair of the social sciences in dealing with the crushing burden of urban issues.

The second view states that the city is good. One of the strong advocates of this view is Harvey Cox. In his book entitled *The Secular City* he provides a second reading of the city from a theological perspective. Cox's book marks a milestone in theological response to the city. He strongly presents his case and states that urbanization is not to be feared. Cox agrees with Wayne Meeks that urbanization facilitated the spread of Christianity in the early church.[153] Secularization, as opposed to the philosophy of secularism, opens the door for the church to shed its non-traditional approaches and engage in meaningful social ministries. This view strongly contends that the city is a manifestation of Christian life and faith, not antagonistic to it nor to be deplored and despised. Taking this view many have accepted the city as it is and have given themselves to ministry in the city.

The third view contends that the city is both good and evil. This view is advocated by some, but has explicitly surfaced in Robert Linthicum's book, *City of God, City of Satan.* His position is that the city is neither intrinsically good nor evil, but is rather a battleground. Satan desires to use the city and its systems and structures for his own purposes. Linthicum does not deal at length with the church in the city. However, his view does set the stage for the church engaging in spiritual warfare against demonic elements in the city.

Depending on what view we take of the city, we will exegete the cities accordingly. There are two extreme views: the negative and the positive. Each has its pros and cons. But what is needed is a view that will take into consideration both sides and yet set a balance between the two extremes. If we take the view that cities are the result of human rebellion against God and his authority, then we will agree with Ellul's

interpretation that the cities are nothing but citadels of sin and evil. Those who have taken the negative approach to the city have failed to see anything good coming out of the city. Thus they shun any ministry in the city.

But if we take the view that cities are the result of God's common grace as advocated by Greenway and others, then we will develop a sympathetic understanding toward the city. This positive understanding is further elaborated by Conn when he says that the cultural mandate given to Adam and Eve in the garden, to fill, rule and subdue the earth (Gen 1:28), was nothing more than a mandate to build the city.[154] Although we may not completely agree with Conn's interpretation, we cannot fail to see his positive approach to the city. Those who have attempted to understand the city positively have seen greater hope and prospects for the ministry in the city. However, while emphasizing the positive aspect of the city, there is a danger also in neglecting the dark and evil side of the city. What we need is an approach that will take into consideration both the evil and good sides of the city.

Conclusion

Emergence of rapid urbanization poses a great challenge to the Church in India. Despite her struggle to adjust to the rapidly changing context, the Church is showing signs of openness to change. It is becoming increasingly clear that more and more people will be migrating to Indian cities. The Church in India has to be equipped to take the challenge of urbanization seriously so that she can minister effectively. While doing this she needs to take her biblical and theological bearings seriously. This would require a conscious effort on her part to take the urban context seriously, reflect on it theologically and draw some clear missiological implications. Out of these reflections, meaningful and effective urban ministry should emerge.

Chapter 9

Transformational Health in Action[155]

A high proportion of the population continues to suffer and die from preventable infections, pregnancy and childbirth related complications, and under nutrition. At the same time new health threats are stretching the capacity of the health system to respond. An estimated 4 million Indians are living with HIV and the virus has spread beyond highly susceptible groups to the general population in some states, threatening to erase much of the social, economic and health gains since Independence. At less than 1% of GDP India's health spending is among the bottom 20% of countries. Irrespective of the type of provider, quality assurance is a problem, with poor clinical practices, inadequate staffing and unethical practices.

Emmanuel Hospital Association is committed to the transformation of communities with programs that invest in the health and well being of everyone, irrespective of caste, creed or race. It aims to focus on the development and empowerment of women and the health and nurture of under fives.

Health Indicators India

Total population: .....1027 million

% of population above 60 years ...7.7

Life expectancy at birth 60.8

Average annual growth rate 2%

Sex Ration.....933

Crude birth rate.....25

Crude death rate.....9

Literacy rate.....65.38%

Female Literacy rate.....54.28%

Life expectancy (female).....63

Infant mortality rate (per 00).....61

Under 5 mortality rate (per 00).....87

Vaccine coverage 81%

Malnutrition (<5 years).....52%

Maternal mortality ration (per 00,000).....570

Total fertility rate (per 000).....3.1

% of pregnant women receiving antenatal care.....34

% of deliveries attended by trained midwives.....62

Total Expenditure on health as % of GDP.....4.9

General Gov. Expenditure on health (As % of total expenditure on health).....17.8

Private expenditure of health (As % of total expenditure on health).....82.2

Per capita total expenditure
on health 23
at average exchange rate (US $)

Case Study 1: Makunda Christian Hospital: Subsidized School Education for the Tribal

The hospital is located in a tribal area and has a large number of tribal groups. These include Hallams, Charm, Jaintias and Mizos. Traditionally these people exist by doing "jhoom" cultivation, the old method of 'slash and burn' agriculture in the forests and betel nut cultivation. Many people have lost their lands to non-tribals who have settled in their land.

There are very few good schools in the area and many families save money to send their children to far away hostels. The poor are however unable to do so. The poor tribal children living in the vicinity of MCH are deprived of good education. The Hospital Staff employed from other states also have no access to good school for their children.

In response to the need, MCH started a high quality low cost English medium School in February 2004, on tile hospital premises. They constructed a school building to accommodate classes from LKG to standard HI. Hostel facility has also been provided for children from distant villages. At present 107 students are enrolled m the school and 67 are admitted in the hostel. Committed teachers have been recruited from different backgrounds. Children from distant villages are now able to attend school.

The hospital has plans to develop the school to achieve high standards in the quality of education imparted, while keeping the costs within the reach of the poor and maintaining a Christian atmosphere.

Case Study 2: Jiwan Jyoti Christian Hospital: Reaching the Poorest of the Poor

The JJCH hospital is well known for its eye services. People from adjoining districts and states like Bihar Jharkhand and Madhya Pradesh come to JJCH for their eye problems and operations.

Once during a visit to an interior village, the JJCH found many old people blind with cataract. On questioning to why they didn't get their cataracts operated in the free eye operation camps held in the hospital, they replied that they couldn't afford to travel to the hospital. This set them thinking that the really poor people were r being reached.

In response to this need in the poor people, JJCH networked with other missions and organizations. It contacted Indian Missionary Society (IMS) and trained their volunteers to detect cataract patients. The JJCH ophthalmic' Technicians screened the patients in their villages. The cataract patients name were noted down and date for conducting operation was given. On that day the JJCH visits the village and brings the patients to the hospital for the free IOL operations. After the operations the patients are taken back to their villages. The joy on their faces is a sight to behold.

JJCH has networked with organizations like Sampoorna India, Varanasi, Manav Kidmad Foundation, AG Church GEMS mission AND Gospel for Asia. Free eye camps are held in association with them and they help in bringing patients from their villages. During the past year 770 free IOL operations were done for the poor.

Chapter 10

Conclusion: Vision led Community of Christ as an Agent of Transformation

The distinctiveness of the community of Christ is found in the radical and challenging nature of God's dynamic and transforming relationship with the people God has called to be His own. The Church is the people of God, the body and bride of Christ, and the temple of the Holy Spirit. The global Church is transnational, transcultural, trans-denominational and multi-ethnic family, the household of faith; and as we have discussed earlier that the community of Christ in a particular context also must reflect the multicultural reality of the body of Christ.

The church as a called community of God's people has a special responsibility – to be a sign, a foretaste, and an instrument of God's reign. This means, that the community points beyond itself to the coming reign of God. As a Spirit-filled community, church is to manifest the coming reign of God in its common life and shared ministry. The church, as a messianic community, is to participate in the actualization of the coming reign of God in the world as it works for fullness of life for individuals and justice in the society and healing for all creation.

The Challenge for the community of Christ is to be open to the power, the presence and the promise of God's vision of the future. The community as a whole needs to discern together God's vision for the transformational mission.

Transformational mission does not require larger- than- life leaders at helm. Rather the fruitfulness of transformational mission lies in building the strength of the community as the primary way forward. How we think about the community of Christ is most important. People are always subjects and never objects that is because of its belief that all followers of Christ are called children of God. The Church is in transformational mission with its members. This principle is difficult for many Churches, since so much of the history of church leadership has been patriarchal and paternalistic, with the leaders making every making decision for, people. As we have discussed earlier, Jesus said, his disciples are "salt, "light," "leaven," "loved." Persons are not objects to be acted upon but subjects who act. They are gifted, creative, self-responsible subjects who are to be involved in the out working of the transformational mission.

One of the wondrous aspects of human life is the ability to remember the past and to analyze the present; we have the capacity to project ourselves into the future. It is because the community of Christ believes in "God of Hope" (Romans 15:13), a God who declares "See, I am making all things new" (Revelation. 21:5), that its vision can be hopeful and even imaginative Not limited by the facts, figures, and trends of the current situation, believing hope imagines a new state of affairs not yet

existing.

We are given the ability to imagine –to visualize- God's dream for humanity: a time when the lion and the lamb will lie down together, when sword will be pounded into ploughshares, when war will be no more, when the captives will be freed and the blind will see, when the hungry will be fed and the naked clothed. In other word, when all of creation will be transformed into a new heaven and a new earth. The community of faith knows rather than human progress or development, it is God's freedom and God's faithfulness which is the source of the new things that are to come.

The cultivating of faithful imaginations is crucial for the community of Christ who in this life "walk by faith, not by sight (2 Corinthians 5:7). If we cannot imagine a time of fullness of life, reconciliation and healing, when God will dwell with his people and 'wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death will be no more" (Revelation 21:3), then we are enslaved to our present experience of alienation and death and overwhelmed by poverty, suffering, and injustice of our world. Faithfulness is not only about submitting our wills in obedience, but also opening and trusting our imaginations in delight.

The community of Christ is not first a sociological entity but a theological experience – a joint participation in God's vision, reign, reality, world –which enables us to participate with one another in a fellowship of faith, hope, and love (cf. 1Corinthians 13:3). Because in Jesus Christ all that alienates us from God and divides us from one another has been overcome, the Holy Spirit is at work creating a reality of holy living, mutual support, and sacrificial service which the New Testament calls fellowship, challenging old competitive order of interdependence, shared responsibility, and mutuality.

While it is comforting to believe that Jesus died for our sins, the community of Christ in transformational mission must embrace the reality of the cross indicating the shape, direction, and destiny of the life and witness of the church: "take up your cross and follow me." The way of the cross-humility, sacrifice, rejection, persecution, and suffering, even unto death—does not market well in a consumer-oriented, "meet my needs" culture. In other words cross is still a scandal and a folly within the dominant vision of our contemporary world. The community of Christ should not change its vision and ethical practices in response to the changes in the market society rather it should change markets to remain true to its vision.

In Jesus Christ God's promised future invaded the present. The raising of Jesus from the dead was an event of cosmic proportions; in the midst of the old creation of sin, darkness, and death, God inaugurated a new creation of forgiveness, light and life. The biblical image of new creation signifies not only a redeemed humanity, but a renewed earth, set free from its "bondage to decay" (Romans 8:21). The worldly forces of class privilege, economic advantage, environmental

exploitation, gender domination, ethnic discrimination, absolute loyalty to family or nation that subvert and block the actualization of God's vision for God's creation have been unmasked, exposed, and disarmed (Colossians 2:15).

As the first fruits of God's new creation, the community of Christ visualizes and experiences God's transforming power the presence and peace of God in a whole new way. Transformational mission requires a major reorientation. That is, it requires new ways of perceiving, new ways of thinking, and new ways of behaving.

God's vision, God's truth, God's will, cannot be legislated by the political maneuvering of special interest groups, but only through prayer and in fellowship of the community which expects to hear and listen from the Spirit working with the Word and through the Word of God. It is within the context of community of Christ through the power of the Holy Spirit that we are formed and transformed by the Word for sacrificial engagement for transforming of the world. The vision of God clarifies the direction in which the community of Christ needs to move. The love of God poured love into our hearts by the Holy Spirit is the glue that will keep us together over time (Rom. 5:5).

Appendix A

New Delhi Model: The World Inquiry

Introduction

Evangelizing Our World Inquiry, a one-day consultation took place on the 6th of January 2003 at Bible Bhawan, New Delhi. It was organized by Evangelical Fellowship of India (EFI) and the chief resource person was Luis Bush. Richard Howell, General Secretary EFI, moderated the proceedings.

Listening to the Word of God and the insights on it was highly inspirational. The sharing by the participants of God's initiatives through church institutions and individuals added to the dimension of excitement and all became aware of how God is working in and around the city of Delhi. Expectation increased as the day went on that God was up to something new and great in our midst. Immediate commitments were made of resources, places and worship to take up the initial major concern for the leadership of Christ in this birthing initiative by means of intercessory prayer to seek his face on behalf of the people of the city of Delhi. The first specific agreement was to launch a city prayer watch inter- church initiative 24/7-twenty four hours per day seven days a week in different churches who would take responsibility for specific focused prayer over a time period every week.

One approach to the transformation graphically proposed at the consultation was by means of increasing leadership influence of Church in the city (See Figure 1). The reality that was recognized that for the city to be transformed the church need to be transformed. It is a parallel process. Nominal Christians need to be renewed and transformation experienced by the spiritual core of the city.

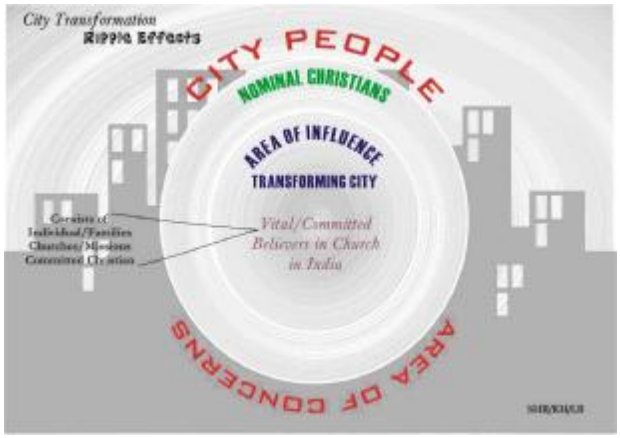


FIGURE 1
AREA OF INFLUENCE AND AREA OF CONCERN

City-Based Action Plan Emergence

During the India consultations in early 2003 a pattern emerged as city after city inquiry led immediately to action plans. Certain questions of the inquiry became the basis for very distinct action steps (See Figure 2).

FIGURE 2
WORLD INQUIRY CITY-BASED ACTION PLAN

Integrated Response of Focus Groups of Five Leaders Each

The major challenges facing the Church in Delhi

1. Materialism
2. Religious fundamentalism
3. The relevance of Christian faith
4. Post modernity
5. Unreached social groups e.g. the youth.

The major obstacles internal to the Church in Delhi

1. Lack of vision
2. Lack of united prayer
3. Unhealthy churches that are not able to reproduce themselves
4. Lack of effective leadership
5. Lack of effective cooperation and coordination

God's call to His people for evangelization over the next 25 years

1. Seeking social transformation
2. Establishing an indigenous people's group
3. Preaching the gospel to every person using personal evangelism

Suitable phrase/watchword for the next 25 years

1. The Whole Church Taking the Whole Gospel to the Whole City
2. Discipling the Nation/City
3. Transforming our World/City
4. Filling the World/City with the Glory of God

Global Evangelical structures to enhance city/world evangelization efforts

1. Inspiration and prayer networks
2. Leadership development
3. Relationship building with other leaders/fellowship network opportunities
4. Resource networks linking to resource geographical and/or functional world evangelization initiatives
5. Reports of what is happening in other cities/countries

New Delhi Model: The Action Plan

Based on the above reflection an Action Plan emerged:

Watchword - Transformational Movement New Delhi

Mission Statement

> The whole Church taking the whole Gospel to the whole city of Delhi so that the power, the presence and the peace of God is experienced by all and the country is discipled.

Major objectives

- Acknowledge the Lordship and leadership of Christ as the head of the body of Christ in Delhi.
- Develop a city leadership team submitted to the Lordship criteria and committed to the Delhi City Transformation mission.
- Facilitate a Delhi city- based Transformational mission initiative.
- Build a community of truth, love and faith especially in the urban heart of India through the multiplication of the World Inquiry Process through the city of Delhi and the nation of India.
- Increase the positive influence of the church in the spheres of life/community in Delhi such as medical, primary health care, communal harmony, educational, legal, slum, political, refugees by means of a common vision, effective communication and developing people's skills of individual Christians, churches and other Christian structures and the community of believers in the city of Delhi.
- Raise up Delhi City Transformation advocates.
- Raise up Delhi City Transformation implementers for the different city based networks.
- Seek to bring positive change
- Proclaim in word and deed the good news of the Gospel to the poor, the oppressed, the sick and the marginalized of Delhi with intentionality and to every person in the city of Delhi.
- Support existing and build new ongoing, life- giving united programs and projects that minister to the poor, the oppressed, the sick and the marginalized of Delhi.
- Establish meaningful training mechanisms with appropriate training materials for the discipling of the people in each congregation in the city.
- Establish a congregation of believers in every class and kind of people and within practical and relational reach of every person, that are permeating every segment of society in Delhi with the love, truth and saving power of Jesus Christ.
- Cultivate younger leaders for leadership and in their

discipling of younger people.

Immediate Action Plan

- City watch prayer 24/7 for Delhi by end of February 2003
- Reproduce/multiply the World Enquiry process among four geographical areas of Delhi by the end of February 2003
- Hold a National Consultation with the leaders of the Inquiries in each of the 20 major cities in which city-wide consultations were held in January 2003 by September 30, 2003.
- Reproduce/Multiply the World Enquiry process among 320 cities in India with more than 1,000,000 by the end of December 2004.
- Build a City Transformation network of 16,000 (50 X 320) Christian leaders by December 30, 2004.
- Establish/strengthen Delhi based resource networks for prayer, youth, family, marginalized, refugees, transients, AIDS, political leadership, women, evangelism, unreached people, saturation church planting, revived families, professionals, etc by December 31, 2004.
- Establish a monitoring centre for information gathering and distribution.
- Conduct workshops on transformational leadership with special emphasis on younger leaders (under 35 years old) in 320 cities (over 100,000) by December 2005.

It was decided that the programs and processes highlighted in the consultation and the steps suggested in the action plan should be regularly and continuously followed up by a core group from among the participants of the consultation. Accordingly, a core group was formed.

Conclusion

The Inquiries were highly motivational and spirit filled. The unanimous Mission Statement focused on the need to mobilize the whole Church to take the whole Gospel to the whole city so that the cities are is transformed by the power, the presence, the peace of God for all and the country is discipled. The strategy is based on principles of communication and partnership. The transformation of communities to reflect Kingdom values is a Christological concern for it recognizes that enabling people to experience Christ's Lordship is the key to holistic ministry.

Appendix B

World Inquiry Questions for Focus Group

Question I. 2-18. (Omit Question 1) What are the major external challenges facing the Church regarding evangelization in our city or country?

	Select 3 only & rank from the highest=1, 2=second highest, 3=third highest	1=highest
2	Globalization—the internationalizing of our shrinking world due to rapid communication toward a common culture	
3	Racial Tension	
4	Pluralism—the coexistence within the one political community of groups who hold incompatible views regarding religion	
5	Illiteracy	
6	Post-modernity—exhaustion of modernity. It celebrates diversity, fragmentation, ambivalence	
7	Religious fundamentalism	
8	Persecution/Political opposition/Injustice	
9	Technological advances	
10	Unreached linguistic and ethno-cultural peoples	
11	Unreached geographic areas	
12	Unreached social groupings - such as the youth	
13	AIDS and other major diseases	
14	Materialism/Distraction	
15	Relevance of the Christian Faith	
16	Food and Water	
17	Other. Please specify	

Question II. 22-36. (Omit Questions 18-21) What are the major obstacles internal to the Church to participate effectively in world evangelization (beyond the city)?

Select 3 only & rank from the highest=1, 2=second highest, 3=third highest		1=highest
22	Lack of money	
23	Lack of effective leadership	
24	Lack of vision	
25	Lack of workers	
26	Lack of training of workers	
27	Lack of appreciation by outsiders of contextualized local distinctives	
28	Opposition from inside the church	
29	Family issues	
30	Lack of united prayer	
31	Lack of good research and information on the remaining task	
32	Lack of effective cooperation and coordinated action between mission agencies	
33	No common goals or strategies for world evangelization	
34	Unhealthy churches that are not able to reproduce themselves	
35	Other. Please specify_____	

Question III. 37-47. (Omit Question 36) What do you believe God is calling His people to do in world evangelization over the next 25 years?

	Select 3 only & rank from the highest=1, 2=second highest, 3=third highest	1=highest
37	Preach the gospel to every person using personal evangelism	
38	Make the Scriptures and gospel message available in every language for both literate and non-reading by radio, TV, the Jesus Film, Bible translation and distribution and by CD	
39	Do you believe God is calling you to set goals for your ministry?	
40	Seek social transformation—seeking positive change in the whole of human life materially, socially and spiritually, by recovering our true identity as human beings created in the image of God and discovering our true vocation as productive stewards, faithfully caring for our world and people.	
41	For the church to be a prophetic voice to the city	
42	Establish an indigenous church planting movement within every people group on earth	
43	Reach unreached social groups such as the youth	
44	Ethnic Reconciliation	
45	Develop regional and global mission-field partnerships for mission agency cooperation and coordination	
46	Get the church involved in things like: • developing a primary health care network • improving the health of communities • teaching adults, and especially women, to read and write • establishing primary schools for those who have no schools • developing vocational training programs to give skills to young people	

Question IV. 48-59. (Omit Question 47) What would be a suitable phrase (watchword) to capture the essence of world evangelization to serve as a unifying paradigm for the next 25 years?

	Select 3 only & rank from the highest=1, 2=second highest, 3=third highest	1=highest
48	The Whole Church taking the Whole Gospel to the Whole World	
49	Fill the World with the Glory of God/ God's Glory for All	
50	The Power, the Presence and the Peace of God for all	
51	City-reaching	
52	Social Transformation/ Transforming our World	
53	Turning the World Right Side Up/ Changing Our World	
54	Christ's Kingdom Come	
55	The Church for Every People	
56	The Evangelization of the World in This Generation	
57	Discipling the nations	
58	Should the watchword have the time frame of 2025?	

Question V. 60-72. (Omit Question 59) How important are the following for Global Evangelical Structures provide to local believers to enhance world evangelization efforts?

	Select 3 only & rank from the highest=1, 2=second highest, 3=third highest	1=highest
60	Inspiration and prayer networks	
61	Serve their country/Bless their country/Nation building	
62	Leadership development	
63	Pertinent information for world evangelization	
64	Resource networks linking to resource geographical and/ or functional world evangelization initiatives	
65	Functional networks linking by ministry-type	
66	Reports of what is happening in other cities/countries	
67	Relationship building with other leaders/Fellowship networking opportunities	
68	Place and opportunity for missiological reflection	
69	Geographical networking opportunities	
70	Place for publications on missiological issues	
71	Other. Please specify_____	

Endnotes:

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[2] Lash and Urry, *Economies of Signs and Spaces,* (London: Sage Publication, 1994), pp. 314ff.

[3] Chris Sugden, *Gospel, Culture and Transformation* (Regnum, Oxford 1997&2000), p.15f.

[4] T. N. Madan, ed. 'Secularism in its Place' in *Religion in India*, (Delhi, Oxford University Press,1992),p.400

[5] Karl Polanyi, *The Livelihood of Man* (New York: Academic Press, 1977), p.9

[6] Iran's 1978 Islamic revolution religion provided the basis for a new national consensus and a new kind of leadership. In 1992, two large, multiethnic states much like India- the Soviet Union and Yugoslavia- crumbled. The nationalist movements based on the assertion that one majority ethnic or religious group defines a nation emerged with new force and resourcefulness. Their ides, images, media, organisations, and resources are transnational in form, scope, and influence.

[7] The powerful critiques of Karl Marx (1818-82), Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900), and Sigmund Freud (1856-1939) have influenced the way societies and individuals conduct themselves. Marx, the German philosopher, economist, and revolutionary, saw religious practices used by one class of people to oppress another. Nietzsche the German thinker expressed alarming doubts about rationalism, humanism, and scientism. He challenged objectivity by revealing the desire for power behind claims to knowledge. He asked the powerful: "Why do you call for love? Is it not just a way to keep anyone from revolting against your authority?" He asked the powerless: "Why do you call for justice? Is it not just a way for you to get on top?" Freud, the founding father of psychoanalysis, saw religious observations as a means by which guilt-ridden people cleanse themselves and force God to bless them.

[8] The mission of the Evangelical Fellowship of India is to empower and mobilize the local churches, church related organizations and Christians to become effective witnesses; to safeguard and shape the evangelical faith and ensure that the Indian Christian voice is heard nationally and internationally.

[9] Richard Howell is the General Secretary of the Evangelical Church of India.

[10] The Global Christian Forum held the gathering in Asia from 30th April to 4th May 2004 in Hong Kong in under the theme, "Jesus Christ in Asia Our Journey Together With Him." These are some of the responses of the participants. "Being here was an eye opener. It took away misconceptions I had about the Pentecostals and Catholics." "I gained a lot. The journey towards unity has commences. It is a beautiful thing to come together and journey together." Around sixty Christians from a broad range of traditions and organizations — including Anglican, Catholic, Evangelical, Mar Thoma, Orthodox, Pentecostal, Protestant, Salvation Army, the Christian Conference of Asia, Evangelical Fellowship of Asia, Federation of Asian Bishops' Conferences and World Vision — came together in Hong Kong for the purpose of reflecting on our journey together with Jesus Christ in Asia. This coming together was the initiative of the Global Christian Forum process. It provided space for us as Asian Christians from different traditions to meet with each other and to listen to each one's "faith journey", our particular struggles and challenges in different situations in Asia, with all its plurality. We experienced a fresh sense of unity under the Lordship of Jesus Christ, and a shared passion for participating in his mission in the world. Arising out of this sharing we developed a new awareness of one another's existence and spirituality and with it the importance of each other in being church in Asia. We affirm that we need to build bridges that would facilitate co-operation in order to have a united voice in confronting the various issues facing Asia. We acknowledge that this in no way means that we should lose our individual identity or distinctiveness. We acknowledge the need to respect and uphold this diversity, among those who confess that God is Father, Son and Holy Spirit and Jesus Christ as perfect in his divinity and humanity. In this spirit, we need to establish trust, openness, honesty, love and humility as we work with one another. We affirm the need for an emphasis on holiness of life and prayer for the fostering of unity amongst us, and a deepening and strengthening of our participation in God's mission in His world. We commit ourselves to explore together models for working,

studying and addressing issues which are common concern, notably poverty, oppression and religious intolerance. We further affirm the need to work together and continue this initiative at the regional, national and local level. We urge the Evangelical Fellowship of Asia, the Christian Conference of Asia and the Federation of Asian Bishops' Conferences to assist in forwarding this initiative.

[11] Light is a very important metaphor in the Bible. "God is light" according to 1 John 1:5, and Christ is described in the Fourth Gospel as "the light of the world" (John 8:12; 9:5; 12:46; cf. 1:7–8). God is also described as light in eschatological contexts (e.g., Isa 60:19–20; cf. Rev 21:10–11). God, moreover, has come in Christ to bring light into the darkness (John 1:4–5, 9; 12:46; cf. Ps 27:1), a point Matthew has already emphasized in his quotation of Isa 9:2 (9:1), in 4:16 ("the people sitting in darkness have seen a great light"). In Paul, the metaphor also extends to Christians, who are described as "children of light" (Eph 5:8; 1 Thess 5:5). In Isa 42:6, Israel's mission is to be a "light to the Gentiles" (cf. Isa 51:4–5). Light is thus associated with God, his Messiah, his people, the law, the temple, Jerusalem, and the accomplishment and experience of salvation. Paul writes of "the light of the glorious gospel of Christ" (2 Cor 4:4; cf. 4:6). Of Christians he writes that in this fallen world they "shine as lights" (Phil 2:15). For Matthew, the metaphor of light is applied specifically to God's new people represented by the disciple.

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[13] Volf, p. 52.

[14] David B. Barrett, George T. Kurian, and Todd M. Johnson, eds., *World Christian Encyclopedia A Comparative Survey of Churches and Religions in the Modern World*, 2nd ed., 2 vols. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001), vol. 1, pp. 12-13.

[15] Walter J. Hollenweger, *Pentecostalism: Origin and Developments Worldwide* (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1997), pp. 18-40.

[16] Harvey Cox, *Fire from Heaven: The Rise of Pentecostal Spirituality and the Reshaping of Religion in the Twenty-First Century* (Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley, 1995), pp. xx-xx.

[17] Larry Martin, *The Life and Ministry of William Seymour* (Joplin, MO: Christian Life Books, 1999), pp. 147, 166.

[18] Martin, *The Life and Ministry of William Seymour*, p. 269.

[19] For his courageous work, see David J. duPlessis, *The Spirit Bade Me Go* (Plainfield, NJ: Logos International, 1970); David J. duPlessis (as told to Bob Slosser), *A Men Called Mr. Pentecost* (Plainfield, NJ: Logos International, 1977). For a deeper insight, also Rick Howard, "David du Plessis: Pentecost's 'Ambassador-at-Large'," in *The Spirit and Spirituality: Essays in Honor of Russell P. Spittler*, eds. Wonsuk Ma and Robert P. Menzies (London: T. & T. Clark, 2004 forthcoming). The thought on Pentecostal movement I have use dare from the paper presented by Wonsuk Ma and Julie C. Ma, Korean Pentecostal missionaries teaching at Asia pacific theological Seminary in Philippines

[20] Elijah Gergan is Pastor of the Moravian Church in Leh and Principal of Moravian School

[21] Samuel Jayakumar is the Principal of Madras Theological Seminary and College.

[22] S. Jayakumar, Dalit Consciousness and Christian Conversion: Historical Resources for a Contemporary Debate, (Delhi: ISPCK. & Oxford: Regnum. 1999) pp. 151-221

[23] MacNaughton, "Foreign Missions and their work among the Tribal People", in M. M. Thomas and W. Taylor (ed), Tribal Awakening. (Bangalore: CISRS. 1965). p.172

[24] P. Van der Veer, "The Foreign Hand", in C.A. Breckenridge and P. Van der Veer (ed). Orientalism and Postcolonial Predicament. (Philadelphia: UPP. 1993). Pp.23-44. T. M. Metealf, Ideologies of the Raj. (Cambridge: CUP. 1996). Pp.1-27, 66fT.

[25] We may add, that so long as caste and the dispositions fostered by it remain in the native Christian Churches, the 'heathen' [non Christians] can not but entertain degrading thoughts about Christianity: for they see that the 'rudiments of this world' - a sinful [evil] Yugam are retained, not withstanding our

proclaiming Christianity to be the only and true way of wisdom. The 'heathen', when they look upon native Christian congregations, can not say, as the 'heathen' [non-Christians] of old respecting the first Christians -see how they love each other! J .Rhenius, Memoir of C. T. E. Rhenius', (London: James Nisbet, 1841), p.211.

[26] V. S. Azariah. "Open Letter to Our Country Men...," Indian Witness. (September 17, 1936). p.598.
[27] Vinay Samuel and Chris Sugden, Mission as Transformation, p.231.
[28] F.R. Bird, "Telegu Mission" (1922-1923), SPG-DL, p.6.
[29] Stephen Neill, Under Three Flags. p.77.
[30] Bishop Spencer. (May 3, 1841), C/IND), Madras. Box 11.
[31] S. Jayakumar. Dalit Consciousness and Christian Conversion., p.173.
[32] S. Jayakumar. Dalit Consciousness and Christian Conversion., p.110, 217-218.
[33] G. A. Oddie, Social Protest, (Delhi: Manohar, 1979). p.19.
[34] D. B. Forrester. Caste and Christianity. (London: Curzon Press, 1980). Pp.24-25.
[35] Stephen Neill, Under Three Flags, (New York: Friendship Press, l954) p.72.
[36] J.W. Picket, Christ's Way to India's Heart, (Lucknow: Lucknow Publishing Co.. 1938), P.173.
[37] V.Mangalwadi, "A Theology of Power in the Context of Social Development", TRACI Journal (April.1981), p.15.
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[39] S. Jayakumar. Dalit Consciousness and Christian Conversion, p.218
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[42] V. S. Azariah, "A Change Delivered to the Clergy of the Diocese of Domakal," (November, 14, 1923), pp.9-10.
[43] V. S. Azariah, "A Change Delivered to the Clergy of the Diocese of Domakal," (November, 14, 1923), pp.9-10).
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[45] A. F. Bird, Telegu Mission, p.7.
[46] V. S. Azariah, "Bishop's Letter" DDM, Vol. VII, No.6, (June, 1930), pp.2-3.
[47] D. A. Christudhas, Caldwell Athiyachar, p. 140.
[48] Y. V. Kumaradhas, "The Swadeshi Movement, ICHR, Vol. XXII, No. 1,p.5
[49] S. Jayakumar, Dalit Consciousness and Christian Conversion, p. 218
[50] V. S. Azariah, Church in Rural India, (Domakal: Diocesan Press, 1928), p.5
[51] Movement among the caste Villagers, p.12.
[52] V. S. Azariah, "Bishop's Letter," DDM, Vol. Vii, No.2, (February, 1930), P.I
[53] V. S. Azariah, The Caste Movement, p. 542.
[54] V. S. Azariah, "A Change Delivered," (1923), pp. 1-24.
[55] Mark Satin *New Age Politics*, New York: Dell, (1979).
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[57] As quoted W. Owen Cole, *The Guru in Sikhism* (London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1982), p.55
[58] c.f. George A. Lindbeck, *The Nature of Doctrine: Religion and Theology in a Postliberal Age* (Philadelphia: Westminister Press, 1984)
[59] Blaise Pascal, *Pensees* (Baltimore: Penguin, 1966), no. 131
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[61] Ibid.

[62] David Rapoport, 'Fear and trembling: terrorism in three religious traditions,' *American Political Science Review*78:658-77).
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[64] Juergensmeyer, p. 382
[65] Romila Thapar, Ibid. Also see, Romila Thapar, *Cultural Transaction and Early India*, 19ff See, M. Muller, *India What Can it Teach Us*? London 1983, 101ff.
[66] Juergensmeyer, Ibid.
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[86] Ibid., p.152
[87] Honourary Secretary of the Theological Commission of the Evangelical Fellowship of India.
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[96] Ibid., p. 114
[97] Hendrik Kraemer, *The Christian Message in a Non-Christian World*, p. 60
[98] Jacques Ellul, *The Political Illusion*, p.187
[99] Mrs Tehmina Arora is the secretary of Christian legal Association of India, an initiative of the Evangelical Fellowship of India.

[100] In China and India for instance the birth of children is restricted by law to one and two respectively, where violation of the same would result in penal provisions and or loss of certain privileges

[101] Indian Constitutional Law by M.P. Jain (Wadhwa and Company Nagpur) (Fifth edition 2003, pg 18)

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[104] Taken from International Justice Mission's website and can be found at the link http://www.ijm.org/ijm_case_radha.html

[105] Dino L. Touthangs is from Manipur is the General Director of Evangelical Fellowship of India Commission on Relief (EFICOR).

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[125] 'What is Good about Good News to the Poor ?' by Chris Sugden in AD 2000 and Beyond by Vinay Samuel and Chris Sugden (Oxford, Regnum, 1991)

[126] Rev Bendangtoshi is an ordained minister of the Baptist Church in Nagaland and is currently working with the Evangelical Fellowship of India

[127] 'From Darkness to Light', a publication of the Nagaland Baptist Church council on the occasion of the celebration of 125 years of Christianity in Nagaland. (First published 1997)

[128] 'Christian Peacemaking: From Heritage to Hope' by Daniel L. Buttry. (Pg. 123- 125. Published in 1994 by Judson Press, Valley Forge)

[129] Organised by Evangelical Fellowship of India (EFI) and Nagaland Christian Forum (NCF), the seminar called for a celebration of faith in Jesus Christ.
[130] Atul Y Aghamkar is Professor and Head of the Department of Missiology, SAIACS, Bangalore
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